



CHINA-ASEAN
STUDIES CENTER

Selected Works

Contemporary Perspectives on Cambodia and the Asia-Pacific

Volume IV

Chheang Vannarith



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Preface

This **fourth volume of Selected Works: Contemporary Perspectives on Cambodia and the Asia Pacific** continues the reflections presented in Volumes I, II, and III. It emerges at a defining moment in Cambodia's long journey toward state modernization—one shaped by sustained political stability, propelled by institutional and economic reform, and challenged by profound changes in the regional and global environment. As Cambodia enters a new era of leadership, economic aspiration, and diplomatic engagement, the essays collected here offer both a chronicle of recent national developments and a forward-looking assessment of the opportunities and uncertainties that lie ahead.

Published in Khmer Times and other platforms between November 2023 and December 2024, the articles capture the evolution of events during a period of notable transformation. Domestically, Cambodia experienced a peaceful transfer of power unparalleled in its modern political history. Regionally, the Asia Pacific confronted intensifying geopolitical rivalry, growing economic fragility, and shifting diplomatic alignments amid global power reconfigurations. Globally, post-pandemic recovery, the climate crisis, and rapid technological disruptions demanded that small and middle states adapt with agility and foresight.

Against this backdrop, the writings in this volume seek to contextualize Cambodia's trajectory within broader regional and international dynamics. They reflect my enduring belief that Cambodia must continue to shape its future through transformative leadership, accountable and agile governance, people-centered development, and proactive engagement in regional and global affairs.

Cambodia's Transformation and Peace

A central theme throughout Part I is the indispensable foundation of peace. Cambodia's hard-won stability, achieved after decades of conflict, continues to form the bedrock of national development and strategic choice. Peace enabled the revival of political institutions, the expansion of democratic participation, and the steady modernization of the economy. As the country moves forward, peace remains not an endpoint but an ever-relevant condition that must be nurtured, protected, and renewed.

This volume underscores how Cambodia's new generation of leaders—embodied most notably by Prime Minister Hun Manet—inherits both the achievements and the unfinished tasks of the past three decades. Their mandate is to preserve national unity while accelerating reforms in governance, human capital development, economic diversification, innovation, and international integration.

Leadership Transition and Institutional Renewal

Several essays examine the leadership philosophy and political outlook of Prime Minister Hun Manet. Rooted in the historical legacy of the Cambodian People's Party yet representing a generational shift, Hun Manet brings a leadership style informed by international education, technological awareness, reform-mindedness, and a commitment to expanding engagement both domestically and globally.

His rise reflects a broader renewal of Cambodia's political and technocratic class. A new cohort of ministers, advisors, and institutional leaders has emerged, emphasizing professionalism, accountability, performance-based governance, and strengthened state capacity. This renewal is essential for tackling corruption, enhancing public service delivery, and building the resilient institutions needed for Cambodia to realize its aspiration of becoming a high-income country by 2050.

Economic Modernization in an Era of Global Uncertainty

The section on Cambodia's economy highlights the urgency of accelerating reform in a global landscape marked by uncertainty—whether due to disrupted supply chains, technological competition, shifting investment patterns, or climate-related pressures. Cambodia must move beyond labor-intensive manufacturing and build an economy anchored in innovation, skills, green transformation, and economic resilience.

These essays examine how domestic governance reforms intersect with external economic opportunities, particularly in the areas of economic diplomacy, SME revitalization, financial stability, and industrial diversification. At the heart of this transformation is a strategic investment in human capital: strengthening education, nurturing technical and digital skills, and empowering Cambodia's youth to contribute to national development.

Equally significant is the role of major infrastructure initiatives such as the Funan Techo Canal. This landmark project symbolizes Cambodia's ambition to become a logistics and economic gateway for the Mekong subregion, enabling greater connectivity, competitiveness, and economic sovereignty. It demonstrates the country's long-term commitment to shaping its own development trajectory with confidence and strategic purpose.

Diplomacy, Sovereignty, and the Art of Navigation

Part II broadens the analysis to Cambodia's engagement with the region and the world. Cambodia's foreign policy—anchored in independence, multilateralism, and respect for international law—must navigate an increasingly complex geopolitical environment dominated by great-power rivalry, especially between China and the United States.

The essays illustrate that Cambodia's strategic posture is not defined by passive alignment but by pragmatic calculation. Cambodia seeks to safeguard its sovereignty, diversify partnerships, strengthen ASEAN centrality, and champion cooperation on shared transnational challenges. Discussions on the South China Sea, ASEAN dynamics, and Cambodia's relations with China, the United States, Japan, Korea, Vietnam, and Thailand demonstrate how small and middle states can exercise meaningful agency even amid asymmetric power relations. Cambodia's diplomacy strives to avoid enmity, foster trust, and serve as a bridge for dialogue.

Humanitarianism, Society, and the Spirit of Shared Prosperity

Beyond geopolitics, the volume also engages the human dimension of Cambodia's national transformation. Essays on the Cambodian Red Cross, youth empowerment, social innovation, public health, and the evolving Cambodian dream remind us that national progress is measured not only by economic metrics but by the well-being of communities and the strength of social solidarity.

Humanitarian innovation emerges as a vital pillar—mobilizing community-based responses, empowering young people, and fostering partnerships that link local capacities with international networks. These reflections highlight the moral and societal foundations of sustainable development and inclusive prosperity.

Closing Reflection

Although written in response to specific moments and issues, the articles in this volume aim to serve as building blocks for broader conversations on Cambodia's strategic direction. They embody a commitment to balanced analysis, constructive reflection, and an unwavering belief in the potential of the Cambodian nation.

Cambodia today stands at a crossroads—facing global headwinds yet rich in opportunity. The country must navigate geopolitical turbulence, enhance democratic and institutional resilience, modernize its governance systems, and unleash the creativity and capabilities of its people.

If Cambodia's recent history teaches anything, it is that the nation possesses extraordinary resilience. From the ruins of conflict, Cambodia has risen with determination, vision, and dignity. The journey continues—shaped by hard-earned lessons, sustained by collective aspirations, and strengthened by the courage of its people.

It is my hope that this volume contributes, in a modest but meaningful way, to ongoing efforts to understand, reflect upon, and shape Cambodia's future within the Asia Pacific and the wider world.

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Part I: Cambodia

Hun Manet, the hope of Cambodia

Over the last 500 years, Cambodia has seen various waves of violent transitions of power. Thanks to the win-win policy spearheaded by Prime Minister Hun Sen, Cambodia had achieved peace in late 1998, after all Khmer factions came together under one roof, one constitution, and one government.

Peace should not be taken granted. We need to keep nurturing and building the foundations of peace, especially amidst rising geopolitical uncertainties and volatilities. Political leaders are held accountable for national unity, peace, and development.

Prime Minister Hun Sen has never abandoned Cambodians. He remains loyal to his people in all circumstances and events. This is his leadership trait. As a historical power transition is going to take place after the general election in July this year, he needs to ensure that the transition will go peacefully and smoothly. He has shown zero tolerance towards those who aim to destroy our hard-earned peace.

If our next leader is not carefully chosen, it would leave opportunities for foreign forces to interfere with our internal affairs most likely through the oppositions or it could mean anarchy within the Cambodian People's Party (CPP). If there is no party unity, the civil servants would be too preoccupied to deal with party politics and won't be able to serve the Cambodian people as they were voted in to do.

We have already seen the example of how a scenario like this would play out with British politics. For the last few years, there is no party unity or solidarity within the reigning Conservative Party. The different factions within the party have been so preoccupied with competing for leadership that has left the British people facing high inflation, food insecurity, energy, and health care crisis.

Consequently, as emphasised before, it is crucial that the next leader of a political party is carefully chosen in order for the country to remain peaceful and stable. As such, this is a crucial task for the Prime Minister to choose who to pass the torch to, in order to lead our country into the next era of peace, stability and prosperity.

At the 2021 party congress, CPP's Central Committee unanimously voted to anoint Mr Hun Manet as its future Prime Minister candidate. Mr Manet is the most qualified and decorated candidate to be our next prime minister. Here are some facts. He is the first ever Cambodian to have graduated from the prestigious United States Military

West Point Academy in 1999, he then obtained his Master of Arts in Economics from New York University in 2002 and a PhD in Economics of the University of Bristol in 2008.

After his academic journey, he joined and led the Ministry of Defence's National Counter-Terrorism Special Forces where he worked his way up the military ladder to be appointed as the Deputy Commander-in-Chief of the Royal Cambodian Armed Forces and the Commander of the Royal Cambodian Army. He came into national and international spotlight when he took a leadership role in overseeing the negotiations during the 2008-2011 Cambodian-Thailand border conflict.

Apart from the military duties, he has been actively involved in philanthropic social works. As the Chief of the Samdech Techo Hun Sen Scholarship Committee and the Samdech Techo Scholarship Association, he provides scholarship opportunities to thousands of Cambodian youths to enrol in universities across Cambodia.

Along with his wife Pich Chanmony, he founded and serve as chairman of the Board of Directors of the Samdech Techo Youth Volunteer Doctor Association, which mobilises thousands of medical professionals, trainees, and volunteers to provide free healthcare in rural areas throughout Cambodia. Most remarkably, during the COVID-19 pandemic, he spearheaded the projects to lead medical teams to fight against the disease and established treatment facilities across Phnom Penh in order to provide accessible healthcare for the Cambodian people, which resulted in a great success. This of course contributed to the overall effort of our country's fight against the pandemic.

In regard to the CPP responsibilities, he was nominated as head of the CPP's youth wing in 2020, where membership has been enlarged and diversified since this new leadership came into effect. He understands that, as a leader, he needs support from all of CPP's diverse pool of members and not just the political elites. With this in mind, his most noticeable reformatory strategy for CPP was to increase engagements with Cambodian diaspora communities overseas, which over the years has become a playing field for the oppositions to monopolise their influence and propagandas, in which they were succeeding. Not only that these communities still have families in Cambodia, crucially, they also play a role in how external actors perceive Cambodia as a whole.

Oppositions has been able to spread their propaganda to other governments through the Cambodian diasporas with narratives of Cambodia being embroiled with corruption, communism, nepotism, and Vietnamese/Chinese puppets.

Mr Manet understands that in order to rectify these narratives, CPP needs to provide a safe platform where they can engage with the Cambodian diasporas so that they would feel valued. At the same time, these Cambodian diasporas abroad can also be kept informed of developments in Cambodia in order to see how far we have developed and prospered since the days of Khmer Rouge.

Furthermore, he understands that engagements with CPP youths is crucial for the future of Cambodia as well since the youths will be leading our country one day. It is important that they are valued by CPP and that they will be more political involved in attributing to relevant up-to-date policymaking one day.

With this vision in mind along with his down-to-earth, approachable and caring personal characteristics, he is beloved by CPP especially by his youth wing, which is crucial to having a peaceful transition of power in the future.

With these credentials, how could one say that Mr Manet is not a qualified prime ministerial candidate? The critics should not be so laser focused on the fact that he is the son of Prime Minister Hun Sen but that he is a young Cambodian leader who has earned merits and trust from the people. He has millions of supporters behind him.

In terms of foreign policy, it is widely believed that Mr Manet will continue to follow an independent foreign policy based on international law and core national interests. Pragmatism and hedging strategy will continue to inform the next generation of Cambodian foreign policy makers. Cambodia's vision as a global peace maker will gain new momentum.

This article was first published in Khmer Time on 10 March 2023.

The Interconnectedness among Peace, Democracy, Governance, and Development

Cambodia has experienced a tumultuous history marred by conflicts and unrest, which has instilled in the nation a profound appreciation for the importance of peace. Through firsthand experiences, Cambodia has witnessed the devastating consequences of violence and instability on its people and the nation as a whole.

Consequently, Cambodia recognizes that sustainable development and the well-being of its citizens can only be achieved within a peaceful environment. This editorial explores the interconnectedness among peace, democracy, good governance, and development from a Cambodian perspective, emphasizing their mutually reinforcing nature.

❖ Peace as the Foundation

In Cambodia, peace is considered a paramount priority due to its historical context. The nation acknowledges that peace serves as the bedrock upon which democracy, good governance, and development can flourish.

Cambodia's commitment to peace is rooted in its understanding that without a peaceful environment, sustainable development and the well-being of its citizens cannot be realized. The experiences of violence and instability have shaped Cambodia's dedication to fostering peace, as it has witnessed the positive impact that peace has on societal progress.

❖ Democracy as a Catalyst

Cambodia recognizes the significance of democracy in ensuring peace and stability. The core principles of inclusivity, transparency, and accountability inherent in democracy play a vital role in fostering dialogue, protecting human rights, and fostering social cohesion.

By upholding democratic values, Cambodia empowers its citizens, providing them with opportunities to actively participate in decision-making processes and contribute to the nation's development and governance. A robust democracy in Cambodia promotes dialogue and inclusivity, facilitating a more peaceful and harmonious society.

❖ Good Governance as an Engine

Good governance acts as an essential pillar supporting both peace and democracy in Cambodia. This encompasses principles such as transparency, efficiency, rule of law, and accountability. By strengthening institutions, promoting integrity, and implementing sound policies, Cambodia enhances the effectiveness and legitimacy of its governance systems.

Good governance fosters public trust, ensures effective service delivery, and combats corruption, which are crucial for building a just and equitable society conducive to peace and sustainable development.

❖ **Development as Outcomes**

Development, in its broadest sense, encompasses economic growth, social progress, and environmental sustainability. Cambodia's development journey is firmly grounded in the belief that economic prosperity must be accompanied by social justice and environmental responsibility. The nation aspires to achieve inclusive and sustainable development that leaves no one behind.

Addressing poverty, inequality, and environmental challenges are vital components in building a peaceful and resilient society. Cambodia acknowledges that development efforts must prioritize equity, social cohesion, and environmental stewardship to create a harmonious and prosperous nation.

❖ **Cambodia's Progress and Ongoing Challenges**

Cambodia has made significant strides in peace, democracy, good governance, and development over the past decades. Its commitment to peace and reconciliation has laid the foundation for stability, enabling the nation to focus on democratic consolidation and institutional reforms.

Measures to enhance governance, promote the rule of law, and empower citizens have been implemented, leading to improvements in socio-economic indicators and increased access to education, healthcare, and infrastructure. However, challenges persist, and Cambodia remains dedicated to addressing them by deepening democratic practices, strengthening institutions, and improving governance processes.

The interconnectedness among peace, democracy, good governance, and development is evident in Cambodia's progress. Although each country's path may be unique, shaped by historical, cultural, and socio-economic contexts, the underlying principles connecting these elements are universal.

Cambodia's institutional landscape faces several significant challenges. Issues such as corruption, limited transparency, and weak accountability mechanisms hinder the efficient functioning of institutions. These challenges undermine public trust, hinder economic development, and impede social progress. To overcome these obstacles, Cambodia needs a transformative leader who can envision a future of strong institutions and drive the necessary reforms to achieve this vision.

The transformative leader might well be General Hun Manet, well educated and nurtured and groomed and the incoming cabinet ministers.

Transformational leaders articulate a vision that's appealing and inspiring to the masses in and outside the country, providing a vivid mental image of the long-term goals and aspirations of the country. This is crucial, especially during times of drastic internal governmental changes which brings with it, its own unique set of challenges.

Transformative leadership is therefore crucial for catalyzing institutional change in Cambodia. A transformative leader possesses a clear vision, inspires others, and exhibits the political will and courage necessary to initiate and sustain comprehensive reforms. Such leadership is characterized by its ability to engage with diverse stakeholders, foster a culture of meritocracy, and promote transparency and accountability at all levels of governance.

Transformative leadership in Cambodia must prioritize institutional building as a core objective. This involves establishing robust legal frameworks, strengthening oversight mechanisms, and ensuring the independence of judiciary and law enforcement agencies. Moreover, creating a culture of meritocracy and professionalism within public institutions is essential for attracting and retaining competent individuals who can drive effective governance.

With the transformative new cabinet lists floated, up to two thirds of incoming ministers will be second generation leaders who have been well educated, nurtured and tutored in governance, need for professionalism and capacity building.

This is probably the first time in 30 years Cambodia will be seeing such significant changes in a cabinet line-up and it offers hope for the future and does away with the notion that one stays in his posts until he or she expires.

This article was first published in Khmer Time on 21 July 2023.

Political Parties and Democracy in Cambodia

Cambodia, having emerged from the shadow of the Khmer Rouge regime, has undergone significant transformations in its political landscape.

A key driving force behind its democratic development has been the establishment of a multi-party system. This op-ed aims to highlight the vital role political parties play in fostering democracy, while acknowledging both the progress made and the challenges that remain in Cambodia's journey towards an inclusive and vibrant multi-party system.

Since the reintroduction of multiparty politics in the 1990s, Cambodia has witnessed the growth of various political parties, each representing different ideologies, interests, and constituencies. This multiplicity of parties has allowed for diverse political perspectives, enabling citizens to exercise their democratic rights by choosing representatives who align with their values and aspirations.

The multi-party system has also facilitated a competitive political environment, encouraging parties to engage in robust debates, policy discussions, and electoral campaigns. This competition serves as a check on power, pushing political actors to respond to the needs and concerns of the electorate. Furthermore, multiple parties provide citizens with meaningful choices during elections, ensuring that their voices are heard, and their preferences are represented.

Cambodia's democratic progress has been a subject of global attention. The Kingdom has made notable strides over the past two decades, with political parties emerging as vital pillars of a functioning democracy.

Political parties are the lifeblood of any democratic society, providing a platform for diverse voices and opinions. In Cambodia, they play a crucial role in representing the interests, aspirations, and concerns of citizens across the nation. By fielding candidates for elections and engaging in political discourse, parties ensure that a multitude of perspectives are presented to the electorate, fostering a pluralistic and inclusive democracy.

Effective political parties serve as vehicles for citizen engagement and political education. They mobilize and organize individuals, giving them an opportunity to participate actively in the political process. Through party membership, citizens can contribute to policy formulation, advocate for their communities, and actively shape the future of their nation. Political parties act as platforms for debate, encouraging informed

discussions and raising awareness about critical issues, thereby strengthening democratic values among citizens.

One of the primary functions of political parties in Cambodia's democracy is to hold those in power accountable. Different parties play a critical role in providing checks and balances, ensuring that the ruling party operates within the framework of the law and respects democratic principles. By scrutinizing government actions, proposing alternative policies, and advocating for transparency and good governance, political parties contribute to the overall accountability of the political system.

Political parties also play a crucial role in policy formulation and national development. Through their political platforms and manifestos, parties articulate their visions for the country's future and propose solutions to societal challenges. By engaging in rigorous policy debates, parties contribute to the development of well-informed and robust policies. Furthermore, successful parties often serve as incubators of political talent, nurturing individuals who can lead the nation and shape its future trajectory.

While political parties play essential roles in Cambodia's democracy, there are challenges that need to be addressed. It is crucial to foster an environment where parties can operate freely and without undue interference. Ensuring a level playing field during elections, protecting freedom of speech and assembly, and promoting transparent campaign financing are all essential elements for a vibrant party system.

Parties must strive to be representative of the diverse population of Cambodia, including women, youth, and marginalized communities. By promoting inclusivity and diversity within their ranks, parties can better address the needs of the entire citizenry and enhance democratic legitimacy.

A robust democracy celebrates diversity and ensures equal representation for all citizens. Political parties in Cambodia bear the responsibility of fostering a pluralistic and inclusive political landscape. By actively recruiting and nurturing a diverse range of candidates, including women, ethnic minorities, and marginalized communities, parties can bridge societal divides, promote social cohesion, and establish a government that reflects the true fabric of Cambodian society.

As Cambodia progresses on its democratic journey, it is imperative to recognize and support the critical roles that political parties play in shaping a vibrant and responsive political system. By fostering an environment conducive to their operation, encouraging

inclusivity, and upholding democratic values, Cambodia can continue to strengthen its democratic foundations and fulfill the aspirations of its people.

And now, with some form of timeline ascertained for the transfer of power, Cambodia does indeed has democracy, albeit with its own brand and variety.

This article was first published in Khmer Time on 22 July 2023.

Cambodia's Resilient Democracy

On Sunday, 23 July 2023, Cambodia achieved yet another landmark in its journey towards strengthening its democratic values with a successful election.

Yesterday, some 8.177 million registered voters or 84.58 percent of the total registered voters of 8,213,260 people had cast their ballots in a peaceful and amiable manner. Attempts to discourage people from heading to the polls was also foiled.

This electoral exercise serves as a testament to the unwavering resilience of Cambodia's democracy, demonstrating the country's commitment to upholding democratic principles and fostering political participation. Despite the challenges faced, the recent election highlights Cambodia's determination to forge ahead on its path of democratic progress.

To truly appreciate the significance of the July 2023 election, it is crucial to acknowledge Cambodia's tumultuous history. Emerging from a prolonged period of conflict and foreign intervention and occupation, the nation has made remarkable strides towards establishing a stable and inclusive democratic system that respects the rights and aspirations of its citizens, in which peace and development are the backbones.

The commitment to conducting free and fair elections demonstrates the government's dedication to upholding democratic principles and ensuring the voice of the people is heard. It is a clear signal that Cambodia is determined to strengthen its democratic institutions and build a more inclusive society. It is safe to say that the democratic values and multi-party system in Cambodia prevail and continue to thrive. No forces can change this trend.

One of the most significant indicators of a vibrant democracy is the participation of citizens in the political process. The July 2023 election witnessed a surge in voter turnout, exemplifying the increasing engagement and interest of Cambodian citizens in shaping their nation's future. This heightened participation not only strengthens the legitimacy of the elected government but also underscores the people's faith in their democratic system.

A resilient democracy thrives on the diversity of its political landscape. The recent election showcased the emergence of a multi-party system, allowing for a broader range of voices and perspectives to be represented. There were eighteen political parties contested in the election. The presence of multiple political parties fosters healthy

competition and ensures a more balanced governance structure, providing citizens with a wider array of choices and platforms to express their political preferences.

A fundamental pillar of a mature democracy is the peaceful transfer of power. In the aftermath of the July 2023 election, Cambodia demonstrated its commitment to this principle. The peaceful transition of power reinforces the stability of democratic institutions and sets a positive example for future elections. This peaceful handover not only strengthens trust within the society but also enhances national resilience and political maturity.

While factional politics and power competition within the ruling party exist, internal unity will be likely maintained for the sake of national interest. Notably, over the past five hundred years, Cambodia has not had smooth and peaceful power transition.

While celebrating the resilience of Cambodia's democracy, it is important to acknowledge the challenges that lie ahead. Upholding the integrity of democratic institutions, ensuring transparent governance, and safeguarding human rights must remain priorities for Cambodia's leadership.

Ongoing efforts are required to further strengthen democratic values, promote inclusivity, and provide equal opportunities for all citizens.

While acknowledging the progress made, it is important to recognize that Cambodia's democracy still faces challenges. Upholding the rule of law, ensuring checks and balances, and strengthening public service delivery to meet the needs and expectations of the people.

Fighting against corruption remains the most challenging, necessary task. Addressing these challenges requires sustained efforts from both the government and civil society, as well as support from the international community.

The international community has a vital role to play in supporting Cambodia's democratic journey. Positive engagement, characterized by constructive dialogue and assistance, can help reinforce democratic institutions, promote good governance practices, and foster respect for human rights. Building on existing partnerships and expanding cooperation will contribute to Cambodia's continued progress as a democratic nation.

Over 600 international observers from some 60 institutions, including the speaker of Dewan Rakyat of Malaysia, the Prime Minister of the Republic of Guinea-Bissau and

many former heads of state, heads of government, former presidents and vice presidents of the National Assembly, had been accredited for the July 23 National Election.

This is the transparency of the electoral system, and it is a pre-requisite to ascertain the legitimacy of the election despite calls to claim otherwise well before the election just because of the absence of one recalcitrant party which wants to be above the law, treated as a 'god's gift to Cambodian politics' and under-handed tactics of urging voters not to cast their ballots or to invalidate their votes.

This stupidity, rather than endorsing any of the opposing 17 other parties, shows the opposition's immature style of politics, abetted by their covert and overt supporters and financiers.

As Cambodia continues to address the challenges ahead, it is crucial for the government, civil society, and the international community to remain vigilant in safeguarding and nurturing Cambodia's democracy.

By doing so, Cambodia can build on the achievements of the July 2023 election and further strengthen its democratic foundations, ensuring that the voice of its people remains central to the nation's progress and prosperity.

This article was first published in Khmer Time on 24 July 2023.

Cambodia's next leader Hun Manet presents a new era for the country's global relations

After gaining independence from France in 1953, Cambodia has experienced several violent regime changes due to conquest, coups and civil wars. The latest events include the 1970 coup, the rise of the Khmer Rouge regime in 1975, a violent power transition in 1979 and a violent power struggle in 1997.

This time, the shift of power has been remarkably peaceful, with Hun Manet set to assume the role of prime minister on Aug 22, following the Cambodian People's Party's (CPP) victory at the Jul 23 election.

The reactions to Hun Manet's appointment have been mixed: On one hand, there is optimism that Western-educated Hun Manet may improve Cambodia's testy relationship with the West; on the other, there is concern that Hun Sen will still be running the show from behind the curtains.

While it is still early to fully evaluate Hun Manet's leadership capacity, we can glean insights into his worldview from his academic background and over a decade of experience as the army chief and head of the CPP youth wing.

❖ HOW WILL HUN MANET STEER RELATIONS WITH US AND CHINA?

Hun Manet, 45, was trained at the West Point military academy in the United States and holds a master's degree from New York University and a doctorate from Britain's Bristol University, both in economics.

His exposure to different ideas and approaches is likely to play a role in shaping his leadership style in both domestic and international political landscapes.

The relationship between Cambodia and the US has been tense due to the US' interference in Cambodia's democracy and human rights issues.

After the election, the US derided the polls as “neither free nor fair” and announced visa bans on individuals it said had undermined democracy. It also paused several foreign assistance programmes in Cambodia.

“As the ruling Cambodian People's Party forms a new government, authorities have an opportunity to improve the country's international standing, including by restoring genuine multi-party democracy, ending politically motivated trials, reversing convictions

of government critics, and allowing independent media outlets to reopen and function without interference,” US State Department spokesman Matthew Miller said.

China, Cambodia’s key partner country, on the other hand congratulated Hun Sen on his victory.

“China and Cambodia belong to one community with a shared future,” said Chinese President Xi Jinping in his congratulatory letter.

Although the Cambodia-China relationship is expected to remain core to the nation's foreign policy, under Hun Manet's administration, a robust implementation of hedging and diversification strategies is expected.

Due to economic reasons, Cambodia is naturally inclined to have close ties with China. China is Cambodia’s largest trading partner, and about 35 per cent of everything Cambodia imports come from China. Last year, China also accounted for 90.5 per cent of Cambodia’s total foreign direct investment.

Hun Sen famously said in 2021: “If I don’t rely on China, who will I rely on?”

While Hun Manet’s handover is expected to come along with a leadership reshuffle that could see almost the entire Cabinet replaced by younger officials, Hun Sen has also made it clear that he still holds political power after leaving his post.

Now that the baton has been passed to Hun Manet, the best course of action would be for him to pursue an independent foreign policy. This approach will allow Cambodia to determine its diplomatic course based on what it perceives as best for its citizens and the nation's development.

By avoiding alignment with any specific power bloc or forming exclusive alliances, Cambodia can preserve its autonomy and sovereignty in the international arena.

Central to Cambodia's foreign policy will be a commitment to abide by international law and norms. This includes respecting the principles enshrined in the United Nations Charter, such as territorial integrity, non-interference in internal affairs of other nations, and peaceful dispute resolution.

It is expected that Cambodia will continue to engage in open and inclusive multilateralism, which involves active participation in international organizations, forums and initiatives that address global challenges such as climate change, poverty alleviation and global health.

❖ **PRIORITISING CAMBODIA**

At the same time, Hun Manet's administration is expected to prioritize Cambodia's national strength and interests in its foreign policy considerations. This entails leveraging the country's resources, economic potential, and strategic location to pursue opportunities that contribute to Cambodia's development and well-being.

Foreign policy decisions will be guided by a keen understanding of Cambodia's internal priorities and how international engagement can support those goals.

A secure and resilient economy is vital for national stability and sovereignty. By prioritizing economic diplomacy and security, the message Hun Manet will send is that he acknowledges the critical role economics plays in shaping politics, while also recognizing that domestic politics significantly influences foreign policy.

To enhance economic security, the government will likely implement policies that diversify the economy and reduce over-reliance on specific sectors or trade partners. This may include efforts to bolster the agriculture, manufacturing and services sectors while investing in technological advancements and innovation to boost productivity.

The government would do well to work to create a favorable business environment that attracts both domestic and foreign investments. This involves streamlining regulations, improving infrastructure, promoting transparency, and combating corruption.

In addition to proactive economic diplomacy and economic security measures, it is essential to consider how domestic political stability interacts with foreign policy. A stable domestic political landscape ensures that the government can focus on economic development and international cooperation without being hampered by internal strife or conflicts.

Thus, promoting political unity and social cohesion within Cambodia will be a priority for Hun Manet's administration.

❖ **POTENTIAL AND PROMISE FOR HUN MANET'S LEADERSHIP**

The path that Cambodia treads under Hun Manet's leadership is filled with potential and promise. But the road ahead will also present new challenges, and Hun Manet will undoubtedly need to navigate them with resilience and adaptability.

By embracing a cautious reformist approach, valuing diverse perspectives and fostering a balanced foreign policy, Hun Manet can pave the way for Cambodia's emergence as a responsible and respected member of the global community.

With a collective and thoughtful leadership, Cambodia's path towards progress can be firmly set.

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Hun Manet's Leadership and Cambodia's Path Towards Progress

The recent leadership transition in Cambodia marks a significant departure from its history of turbulent power transfers. Hun Manet's peaceful ascension to the role of Prime Minister, following the Cambodian People's Party's (CPP) landslide victory at the July 23 election, sets a positive precedent for the country's political stability.

As we look into Hun Manet's leadership capacity, his academic background and experience as the Army Chief and Head of the CPP youth wing offer valuable insights. His commitment to engaging with various sources and active listening positions him as an informed and receptive decision-maker. This attribute is essential for addressing the complex challenges that lie ahead.

Strategic foresight and scenario analysis are prominent features of Hun Manet's approach. Seeking input from advisors and assistants to explore potential outcomes before making critical decisions demonstrates his commitment to finding the best course of action, a crucial trait for effective leadership.

Hun Manet embodies the role of a cautious reformist. Recognizing governance challenges in Cambodia, he appears willing to implement necessary reforms while ensuring internal unity within the party and government. This pragmatic approach could drive positive change while maintaining stability.

In terms of foreign policy, Hun Manet displays an openness to embracing new ideas, particularly in engaging with the West. While Cambodia's relationship with China will remain central, the administration is expected to implement hedging and diversification strategies, balancing its external relations.

Cambodia's pursuit of an independent foreign policy is a key principle. By making autonomous decisions, free from undue external influence, Cambodia seeks to determine its diplomatic course based on the nation's best interests and development. This stance preserves Cambodia's autonomy and sovereignty on the global stage.

Hun Manet's administration will prioritize Cambodia's national strength and interests in its foreign policy considerations. Leveraging the country's resources, economic potential, and strategic location will enable the pursuit of opportunities that contribute to Cambodia's development and well-being.

Central to Cambodia's foreign policy is a commitment to abide by international law and norms, promoting stability and predictability in international relations. Engaging in open and inclusive multilateralism allows Cambodia to collaborate with other nations and find collective solutions to global challenges.

Economic diplomacy and security are paramount under Hun Manet's leadership. Recognizing the integral role of economics in politics, the government will focus on ensuring economic resilience and safeguarding the nation's interests against external threats.

To enhance economic security, policies will aim to diversify the economy and reduce reliance on specific sectors or trade partners. Creating a favorable business environment, streamlining regulations, and combating corruption will attract domestic and foreign investments.

Promoting political unity and social cohesion within Cambodia will be a priority. A stable domestic political landscape allows the government to focus on economic development and international cooperation without internal conflicts hindering progress.

The path ahead for Cambodia under Hun Manet's leadership is filled with potential and promise. His cautious reformist approach, strategic planning, openness to engaging with the international community, and commitment to Cambodia's interests bode well for the nation's progress.

As Cambodia charts its path towards the future, the significance of sustained observation and assessment cannot be emphasized enough. In the journey of progress, challenges are inevitable, necessitating the display of resilience and adaptability by the nation's leadership and its people. However, with a united and thoughtful approach to governance, Cambodia holds the potential to emerge as a responsible and esteemed member of the global community, firmly committed to advancing on a trajectory of growth and development.

By embracing collective leadership and fostering a sense of unity, Cambodia can effectively navigate through the intricacies of its internal and external landscapes. A thoughtful leadership, armed with a deep understanding of the nation's priorities and aspirations, can steer the country towards stability and sustainable advancement. This will not only solidify Cambodia's standing in the international arena but also enhance its reputation as a reliable partner in global cooperation and development efforts.

As the nation embraces these qualities, it gains the ability to effectively respond to challenges and complexities that may arise on its developmental journey. By cultivating an environment of stability and progress, Cambodia can attract foreign investments, encourage innovation, and bolster economic diversification. In doing so, the nation can leverage its vast potential, promoting inclusive growth and prosperity for its citizens.

Furthermore, by showcasing its commitment to responsible governance and cooperative diplomacy, Cambodia can play a more active role in addressing pressing global issues. The nation's active participation in international forums and collaboration with other countries can contribute to collective efforts to tackle challenges such as climate change, poverty, and public health.

Cambodia stands at a crucial juncture where visionary and thoughtful leadership can propel the nation towards a future of promise and achievement. By embracing collective efforts and demonstrating adaptability, Cambodia can foster a legacy of sustainable growth and responsible global engagement, solidifying its position as a respected member of the global community.

This article was first published in Khmer Time on 03 August 2023.

My Cambodian Dream

As the sun sets on this month, Cambodia is poised to step into a new chapter of its history, one defined by ambitious nation-building endeavours. The nation stands at the cusp of a transformation that hinges on the development of its human capital- the foundation of all.

Built on the foundations developed by the previous generation, the new generation is expected to robustly carry out innovative governance reforms with substantial investments in cultivating a knowledge-based economy.

In my childhood, I nurtured the ambition of becoming a teacher. Yet, this aspiration was accompanied by a sense of poignancy and uncertainty. The aftermath of the devastation caused by the Khmer Rouge infused my dream of teaching with a deeper purpose – it stood as a testament to the undying determination of those who had tragically perished, a living tribute to their unrealized aspirations, a torch symbolically passed from the fallen to the living. Within this dream, I carried the hopes of those who dared to envision a brighter future during the bleakest hours of our history.

I came into this world, nurtured by the unwavering strength of a single mother, in the wake of the Khmer Rouge's collapse in January 1979. My early years unfolded amid a generation marked by the indelible scars of hardship, and my childhood was a canvas painted with shades of adversity, uncertainty, and despair.

The aftermath of a shattered education system loomed before us, a stark mirror reflecting the immense devastation that had gripped our nation. In the confines of my village nestled in Stoung district, Kompong Thom province, the teachers who survived the Khmer Rouge's brutal reign could be counted on the fingers of one hand, a testament to the sheer resilience that had carried them through those harrowing times.

I could recall walking to school was a perilous endeavour, with the threat of landmines lurking on either side of the path. A mere misstep could lead to injury or death, a grim reality underscored by the tragic fate of several children who fell victim to the remnants of war.

The spectre of civil war still loomed large, even after the Paris Peace Accord in October 1991, with my hometown witnessing the last vestiges of fighting in 1993 during an attempt by the Khmer Rouge to disrupt United Nations-supervised elections. The very

UN peacekeeping forces stationed nearby found themselves besieged- their temporary camp located right behind my house.

In 1992, I encountered two Japanese civilian engineers working under the United Nations Transitional Authority (UNTAC)- the first foreigners I had ever met. They stayed in a concrete house just in front of our home. They told me that one day peace would eventually return to Cambodia and the road in my district would be rebuilt (national road number 6). I smiled, but deep down I was not convinced.

A decade later, a resurgence of peace began to take hold, heralding an era of infrastructure development and incremental socio-economic progress. I managed to complete my high school education and ventured abroad for higher studies under various scholarships, carrying with me a profound aspiration inspired by those who had taught me in the early days, especially my mother and teachers.

Today, the arc of my journey has taken me from the depths of hopelessness to the shores of hopefulness. Having emerged from a period of strife and struggle, I now find myself imparting knowledge at various universities around the world. My dream, against all odds, has been realized, a testament to the hard-won peace of the late 1990s.

Surveying the landscape of our achievements and envisioning the road ahead, I cannot help but feel a surge of pride for Cambodia's indomitable spirit and for our ability to rebuild a nation from the ashes of the Khmer Rouge's tyranny. However, our journey has not been without its share of missteps and shortcomings. To truly progress, we must embrace the wisdom that comes from acknowledging and learning from our mistakes and failures. This very process of introspection strengthens our resilience and propels us toward better solutions.

The Cambodian dream that has guided me is one of peace – a dream that has been realized but not one that we can afford to take for granted. We must remain vigilant in safeguarding the fragile tranquility we have painstakingly nurtured. Yet, another facet of this dream lies in the realm of knowledge. To forge a path towards a progressive and civilized nation, we must prioritize the development of our human capital, laying the foundation for a knowledge-based economy. This path, though arduous, demands visionary leadership, transformative actions, and the unwavering participation of each and every one of us. We all have a stake here.

Diversity of opinions and perspectives is the cornerstone of a thriving society. In this spirit, I urge each of us to engage in a constructive dialogue that enriches our

understanding and fuels the engines of progress. Constructive criticism, when offered with the intent of improvement and growth, is an invaluable tool that can catalyze positive change. Let us welcome ideas that challenge the status quo, as they often hold the potential to unearth innovative solutions and unearth hidden pathways to success.

However, as we embrace differing viewpoints, it is paramount that we draw a clear line between constructive criticism and destructive comments or behaviors. Destructive comments, driven by negativity or animosity, have the potential to undermine the very foundation upon which our aspirations are built. Such comments not only hinder progress but also sow discord and erode the unity that is essential to our shared journey. Likewise, behaviors that seek to disrupt, divide, or derail our collective efforts are antithetical to the spirit of nation-building and have no place in the narrative of our future.

As we look to the horizon, the Cambodian dream beckons us forward – a dream rooted in the principles of peace and knowledge. It is a dream that resonates not only within the hearts of individuals like myself but within the very soul of our nation. With unwavering determination, we shall continue to strive, learn, and grow, ensuring that the Cambodian dream flourishes for generations to come.

This article was first published in Khmer Time on 08 August 2023.

Five Pillars of Cambodia's Economic Reforms

Last month, the dialogue on economic policy among political parties was facilitated by the National Election Committee. Within this context, Vongsey Vissoth, a prominent figure associated with the Cambodian People's Party, presented an ambitious economic vision – an all-encompassing plan intricately formulated to guide the nation towards a more inclusive, sustainable, and resilient economic framework.

The blueprint outlines five interlinked policy focal points, with each priority echoing a resolute dedication from the newly formed administration. It indicates the commitment of the new government to construct a socio-economic structure that surpasses mere statistical indicators, deeply touching upon the essence of people's well-being.

The roadmap plots a course towards a future characterized by increased prosperity and resilience, adroitly navigating the intricate currents of economic complexities and uncertainties both domestically and internationally.

Anticipated to be a potent instrument for ushering in a transformative wave of positive change, this roadmap is poised to uplift individuals, families, and communities towards better livelihoods and a more promising horizon.

❖ Ensuring Macroeconomic and Financial Stability

At the core of Cambodia's economic strategy lies the imperative to maintain macroeconomic and financial stability. This entails a multi-faceted approach, encompassing measures to curb inflation, stabilize exchange rates, balance the national budget, and secure the resilience of both traditional banks and emerging non-bank financial institutions. These foundational steps create a solid platform upon which subsequent growth initiatives can flourish.

❖ Fostering Inclusive and Resilient Economic Growth

A standout objective of Cambodia's vision is the pursuit of robust, inclusive economic growth as a means to alleviate poverty. The spotlight here falls on empowering small and medium-sized enterprises (SMEs), fortifying the informal economy, harnessing the potential of digital technologies, and prioritizing sustainable "green" development. By nurturing a diverse range of economic drivers, Cambodia aims to not only raise its GDP but also ensure that the benefits of growth are widely shared.

❖ **Efficient and Sustainable Budget Management**

An integral component of the plan centres on optimizing the management of the national budget. The government has charted a course towards fiscal efficiency and sustainability through a comprehensive public financial reform program. This program seeks to enhance revenue management within the national budget, thereby maximizing resource mobilization. The outcome promises to be a judicious allocation of funds that fuels development projects across the spectrum.

❖ **Strengthening the Financial Sector**

Recognizing the pivotal role of a robust financial sector in propelling economic progress, Cambodia has identified this as one of priority areas. A central objective revolves around facilitating the seamless channelling of national savings into priority sectors through increased efficiency. Diversification of financial products, bolstering financial inclusivity, embracing financial technology, and innovative financing mechanisms such as sovereign bonds, collectively underscore the nation's commitment to nurturing a dynamic financial ecosystem.

❖ **Empowering the Private Sector**

The plan rounds off with a resolute focus on elevating the private sector to the vanguard of economic growth. By cultivating a business-friendly environment, Cambodia seeks to unleash the full potential of private enterprise. This entails initiatives aimed at attracting investments, fostering collaboration within regional and global economies, and streamlining public services to better support private sector enterprises. The emphasis on this sector serves as a testament to Cambodia's belief in the entrepreneurial spirit as a driving force or engine behind economic growth.

The bedrock upon which the realization of these five pivotal pillars stands is the cultivation of human capital, the ignition of innovation, seamless coordination between state entities, and the nurturing of robust public-private-people partnerships.

❖ **Human Capital Development**

The true potential of any economic agenda lies within the capabilities, skills, and aspirations of its people. As Cambodia sets its sights on the horizon of sustainable growth, the development of its human capital takes centre stage. Investing in education, skill enhancement, and fostering a culture of lifelong learning becomes paramount. By

empowering its citizens with the tools to excel and adapt in an ever-evolving landscape, Cambodia lays a solid foundation for the holistic fulfilment of its aspirations.

❖ Igniting Innovation

The spark of innovation is the catalyst that propels nations beyond the boundaries of the ordinary. Embracing cutting-edge technologies, nurturing a culture of creativity, and incentivizing research and development, Cambodia can infuse its economic policies with a vibrant spirit of innovation. This not only bolsters industries but also opens doors to entirely new avenues of growth, creating an ecosystem that thrives on constant evolution.

❖ Seamless State Coordination

The orchestration of a nation's economic vision necessitates harmonious coordination between its various arms. Ensuring that state agencies work in tandem, share insights, and collaboratively pursue common goals optimizes the deployment of resources and minimizes inefficiencies. By fostering an environment where government bodies function in unison, Cambodia sets the stage for the effective execution of its multifaceted policies.

❖ Dynamic Public-Private-People Partnerships

At the heart of transformative growth lies the convergence of public sector innovation, private sector dynamism, and the aspirations of the people. Creating partnerships that leverage the strengths of each stakeholder ensures that the entire spectrum of society is actively engaged in the nation's progress. This collaborative approach not only bolsters economic endeavours but also nurtures a sense of collective ownership, fostering a more inclusive and participatory growth trajectory.

This article was first published in Khmer Time on 16 August 2023.

Hun Manet's Evolving Foreign Policy Doctrine

The world is watching as Cambodia navigates the complex web of international affairs. In an era marked by trust deficit, fast-evolving global power shift and transforming geopolitical and geo-economic landscapes, Cambodia finds itself compelled to take an active and forward-looking stance in its foreign affairs—an approach that seeks friendship with all nations while harboring no adversaries.

The Asia Pacific region is at an inflection point- facing an arc of geopolitical instability. Regional security flashpoints such as the tensions on the Korean Peninsula, Taiwan Straits, East and South China Seas, and Myanmar crisis continue to threaten regional peace and stability. Against this backdrop, Cambodia must be prepared to face different scenarios, while taking a leadership role in international crisis prevention and management by prioritizing diplomacy, dialogue and international law.

It has been slightly more than a month since Prime Minister Hun Manet assumed office. In his inaugural month, Hun Manet embarked on a whirlwind diplomatic journey, which included attending the ASEAN Summit and related Summits in Indonesia, making his first official visit to China, where he also participated in the China-ASEAN Expo, and addressing the 78th UNGA in New York.

These high-level engagements provided him with invaluable opportunities to raise the Cambodian flag and connect with a diverse array of global stakeholders, ranging from political leaders and chief diplomats to business leaders and thought leaders.

The key question that arises is what we can discern from Prime Minister Hun Manet's foreign policy doctrine.

❖ Independence

One of the central tenets of Hun Manet's foreign policy doctrine appears to be a commitment to an independent and non-aligned stance. This approach underscores Cambodia's determination to steer its own course in international affairs, free from external pressures or alignments. In an era where geopolitical rivalries loom large, this emphasis on autonomy is a notable cornerstone of Cambodia's foreign policy.

Addressing the 78th United Nations General Assembly, he reaffirmed Cambodia's consistent and firm stand to neither host foreign military bases on its soil nor allow its

territory to be used against a third country. This non-alignment stance is deeply rooted in Cambodia's history and its struggle for self-determination.

Throughout its tumultuous past, Cambodia has strived to maintain a position of neutrality in international conflicts, seeking to avoid entanglements in the disputes of others while adhering to international law. This policy serves as a foundation for peaceful coexistence with neighboring nations.

❖ **Multilateralism**

Another defining feature of Hun Manet's vision is the unwavering commitment to multilateralism. The 21st century has witnessed the rise of complex global challenges that transcend national borders. From climate crisis to the pandemic crisis, these issues necessitate collaborative, cross-border solutions. Unilateralism and block politics are ill-suited to address these complex and interlinked challenges.

Multilateralism is fundamentally rooted in the concept of shared responsibility and collective action. It acknowledges that global challenges require coordinated efforts, shared responsibilities, and pooled resources from multiple nations.

ASEAN remains the cornerstone of Cambodia's foreign policy. It reflects a strategic vision that prioritizes regional stability, prosperity, and cooperation. Embracing ASEAN-led initiatives like RCEP and AOIP, Cambodia aims to leverage regional partnerships and frameworks to enhance its economic growth, diplomatic engagement, and resilience in the face of emerging challenges. By doing so, Cambodia not only strengthens its regional standing but also contributes to the broader mission of ASEAN in building a resilient, sustainable, and inclusive community.

❖ **International Law**

Lastly, Hun Manet's foreign policy doctrine firmly aligns with the concept of a rules-based international order- referring to a system of global governance in which international relations and interactions are guided by a set of agreed rules, norms, principles, and institutions. These rules are established to promote peaceful coexistence, cooperation, and peaceful settlement of disputes.

By adhering to the established international norms and standards, Cambodia envisions to be a responsible, reliable, and principled member of the international community that is genuinely committed to upholding the principles enshrined in the United Nations Charter.

Embracing a rules-based order also entails strengthening and supporting international institutions such as the United Nations and ASEAN. Cambodia's active participation in these forums reinforces its political will and leadership to address cross-border challenges.

❖ **Cambodia First**

At the heart of foreign policy lies core national interests, which include economic prosperity, security, stability, and the well-being of the people. Notably, economics determines politics. Cambodia seeks economic growth, access to markets, attract foreign investments, and reach favorable trade agreements to enhance their prosperity and the standard of living for the people so that Cambodia could realize its vision to become a high-income country by 2050.

Crafting foreign policy is an intricate and multifaceted undertaking that demands a deep comprehension of national and international megatrends, core national interests, and the intricate interplay and delicate balance among these interests. There is a need to enhance the capacity to analyze evolving international structural dynamics and anticipate diverse potential scenarios, and the competence to navigate through challenges which ultimately can develop innovative solutions and breakthroughs.

As Prime Minister Hun Manet is thriving to navigate Cambodia in an increasingly complex, uncertain, and volatile world, it will be intriguing to observe how these three key strategic principles – independence, multilateralism, and a rules-based international order – shape Cambodia's foreign policy direction. These principles are not just a roadmap for Cambodia's international role but also a testament to its commitment to being a responsible and respected member of the international community.

This article was first published in Khmer Time on 25 September 2023.

Cambodian Red Cross, Pioneering Humanitarian Innovation

In a world grappling with mounting humanitarian challenges, the 20th Southeast Asia Red Cross and Red Crescent Leaders Meeting and the 2nd Southeast Asia Youth Forum held in Phnom Penh last week served as a platform of partnership building and innovation.

Hosted by the Cambodian Red Cross and attended by eleven Red Cross and Red Crescent national societies from Southeast Asia, the International Federation of Red Cross and Red Crescent Societies, the International Committee of the Red Cross, and the ASEAN Secretariat, this annual meeting marked another critical turning point in the humanitarian sector.

This annual meeting aims to discuss Red Cross and Red Crescent policies and issues, assess progress in strategic directions, foster sub-regional cooperation and accountability, strengthen collaboration, enhance performance, align with global commitments, and ensure adequate follow-up on the agreed commitments.

In her opening address, Samdech Kittiprittpondit Bun Rany Hun Sen, President of the Cambodian Red Cross (CRC), emphasized the critical need for cultivating innovative solutions to tackle humanitarian issues and challenges, particularly in optimizing the utilization of scarce resources and impacting more people.

As the critical outcome of the meeting, the Phnom Penh Statement was issued to highlight the progress made and set forth new directions, while underscoring the importance of building partnerships and leveraging the responsibility and privilege to impact changes.

The statement commended the relentless efforts of the Cambodian Red Cross in championing humanitarian innovation while encouraging knowledge sharing and the professional development of our youth in the domains of humanitarian innovation and public communication.

Humanitarian innovation is not an abstract concept but a tangible force for positive change. The Phnom Penh Statement is a testament to our collective commitment to advancing innovation, fostering collaboration, and empowering the youth who will carry the torch forward. Together, we are paving the way for a more resilient, inclusive, and

sustainable future where the most vulnerable among us receive the support and care they deserve.

❖ **The Imperative of Humanitarian Innovation**

Humanitarian innovation has emerged as an indispensable tool for addressing these complex challenges as the world grapples with multifaceted crises ranging from the pandemic to climate crisis, natural disasters, and protracted conflicts.

It is a dynamic force that offers creative and sustainable solutions, substantially enhancing the effectiveness of humanitarian responses, empowering communities, and contributing to constructing a more resilient and inclusive society.

The core premise of humanitarian innovation is rooted in the idea that conventional approaches are no longer sufficient to meet the evolving needs of vulnerable populations. It challenges us to think outside the box, to embrace technological advancements, and to engage in proactive problem-solving. The Cambodian Red Cross has exemplified this ethos, leading the way in adopting innovative approaches to humanitarian action.

❖ **Multi-Stakeholder Collaboration**

The significance of multi-stakeholder collaboration and partnership building cannot be overstated in a world characterized by interconnectivity. The strategic partnership between the Red Cross and Red Crescent National Societies in Southeast Asia and the ASEAN Secretariat, particularly in addressing natural disasters, is a testament to collective action's power.

The challenges posed by natural disasters, exacerbated by climate change, require a coordinated and harmonized response. By aligning their resources and efforts, these organizations can better mobilize and allocate resources to meet the urgent needs of affected communities. It underscores the notion that we can achieve far more when working together than when working in isolation.

❖ **Leading by Example**

The Cambodian Red Cross has emerged as a trailblazer in humanitarian innovation, inspiring others to follow. Its unwavering commitment to harnessing the power of innovation is not merely a testament to its dedication to Cambodia but also lessons learned for other humanitarian organizations.

One of the Cambodian Red Cross's most notable achievements is its implementation of various humanitarian innovation projects. These initiatives have ranged from effectively delivering Covid-19 vaccines to vulnerable groups to providing remote and marginalized areas with access to safe drinking water. The construction of climate-resilient housing further illustrates the organization's commitment to addressing pressing needs and building long-term resilience.

❖ Empowering Local Response

A cornerstone of the Cambodian Red Cross's approach has been decentralization, which empowers and enables local provincial committees to respond to humanitarian issues in their respective localities. This model, grounded in local resources, knowledge, and community engagement, has proven highly effective. It ensures that responses are swift and contextually relevant, reflecting the specific needs and challenges faced by local populations.

The convergence of innovation, collaboration, youth empowerment, and localization can reshape the humanitarian landscape. Innovation knows no boundaries, and compassion transcends borders. Leading with innovation demonstrates that our collective efforts can bring about lasting humanitarian impacts.

In the spirit of unity and humanitarianism, let us move forward with determination, fully aware that our collective efforts can shape a brighter, more inclusive, and sustainable future for all. As an African proverb wisely reminds us, 'If you want to go fast, go alone; if you want to go far, go together.' Red Cross and Red Crescent for all; all for Red Cross and Red Crescent. Let's keep the momentum of the movement.

This article was first published in Khmer Time on 02 October 2023.

Cambodia's Funan Techo Canal, A Game Changer?

Cambodia, a nation rich in history, culture and natural resources, has long been a land of opportunities and untapped potential.

Over the past three decades, after gaining total peace in 1999, the country has been making strides towards economic growth and poverty reduction.

One of the most ambitious and transformative projects on Cambodia's horizon is the Funan Techo Canal, a colossal endeavor that could reshape the country's future.

❖ Why is it named Funan?

Funan, an ancient state influenced by Indian culture and located in the Mekong Delta, flourished from the 1st to the 6th century AD. It featured an intricate network of canals linking its economic core to coastal regions, which together formed the main area of Funan. Angkor Borey was the hub of economic and cultural activities during this era. As such, Funan represents an example of economic and cultural interconnection.

Funan Techo Canal project can be regarded as Cambodia's endeavor to transform itself to be the economic and cultural gateway of the Mekong.

The project was approved at the 6th Plenary Session of the National Assembly on 19 May 2023. On 7 June 2023, the government decided to establish an inter-ministerial commission to implement the project. On 17 October 2023, Cambodia signed an agreement to allow China Bridge and Road Corporation (CRBC) to conduct a feasibility study on the project.

Stretching 180 kilometers from the Takeo canal of the Mekong River to the coastal province of Kep, the canal traverses four provinces: Kandal, Takeo, Kampot, and Kep. This waterway is set to be a game-changer for Cambodia, and here's why.

The Funan Techo Canal is designed to be a remarkable engineering feat. With a width of 100 meters upstream and 80 meters downstream, and a depth of 5.4 meters, it will accommodate two-way traffic and can carry ships with up to 3000DWT (Deadweight Tonnage). The canal is built to international standards, prioritizing safety and quality in its construction.

One of the notable aspects of this project is the thoroughness of the planning and the environmental considerations. A serious study was conducted by the government

before project approval, taking more than two years of technical, legal, economic, environmental, and social studies and inter-ministerial consultations.

This comprehensive approach ensures that the canal will not only benefit the economy but also help preserve the ecology and environmental balance of the region. While it is acknowledged that some environmental impacts may occur during construction, measures will be taken to mitigate them.

The Funan Techo Canal is not just a grand infrastructure project; it's a lifeline for approximately 1.6 million people living along its route. By facilitating efficient transportation and trade, it promises to bring economic opportunities to these communities.

The project aligns with Article 5 of the Mekong Agreement of 1995, which mandates that projects on tributaries of the Mekong River, including the Funan Techo Canal, must be subject to notification to the Joint Committee. Cambodia has duly complied with this requirement, demonstrating its commitment to regional cooperation and sustainable development.

The estimated cost of constructing the canal is a staggering USD 1.7 billion, a significant investment in Cambodia's future. However, this investment is expected to yield substantial returns. The canal is projected to cut transport costs significantly, with savings of approximately USD170 for a 20-foot container and USD 223 for a 40-foot container, reducing transport costs by about 16%.

This will not only benefit businesses but also consumers, as lower transport costs can translate into more affordable goods.

The Funan Techo Canal is expected to boost the country's fourth major economic center. This new development joins the ranks of existing three key economic regions: the first being Phnom Penh and its neighboring areas, known for their vibrant urban economy; the second is Sihanoukville along with its adjacent regions, noted for their strategic coastal economic activities; and the third is Siem Reap and its surrounding locales, renowned for their cultural and tourism-driven economy.

The economic internal rate of return, according to the study of the government, is calculated to be between 20% and 31%, indicating its potential for profitability and economic growth. The canal's impact will extend beyond its immediate vicinity. It will promote the development of industrial zones, the formation of production lines, and supply chains, particularly in the agriculture and aquaculture sectors. Moreover, the

canal will spur urbanization along the waterway, contributing to the development of what is being referred to as the fourth economic pole.

Clearly, the project will improve transportation networks and bring new opportunities to communities along its route. In this regard, relevant stakeholders, including the government, private sector, and local communities, must work together to ensure the Funan Techo Canal becomes a model of national and regional economic integration and connectivity as well as the promotion of inclusive, resilient and sustainable development.

This article was first published in Khmer Time on 04 October 2023.

The Cambodian Narrative on the South China Sea Dispute, The Unfinished Story

Early this month, George Yeo, former Foreign Minister of Singapore, returned to Cambodia after his last visit to the country in 1999. His visit was notable for his well-received public lectures at both the National Institute of Diplomacy and International Relations, under the Ministry of Foreign Affairs and International Cooperation of Cambodia, and the Royal University of Phnom Penh.

Subsequently, on December 8, 2023, the Khmer Times published an op-ed by Mr Yeo titled “Why the West Should Not Give Up on Cambodia.” In this piece, Mr Yeo provides a balanced analysis of Cambodia’s remarkable transformation. He underscores the country’s journey from being ravaged by conflict to achieving a state of peace and developing a vibrant economy.

The article also addresses Cambodia’s foreign policy. Although I noticed its overall objectivity, there is one critical issue that I would like to draw readers’ attention which is the South China Sea dispute. The issue is one of the most intricate and hotly contested geopolitical issues in the Asia Pacific region, involving regional and global powers. Cambodia is not immune to this complex dispute.

In his commentary, Mr Yeo wrote, ‘When Cambodia blocked the issue of a joint statement communique by ASEAN foreign ministers in 2012 and 2016, many felt that the decision was taken to please China’.

It is crucial to clarify that the 2016 ASEAN Foreign Ministers’ meeting did manage to issue a joint communique after a tense debate.

Indeed, ASEAN did not succeed in issuing a joint communique in 2012 during Cambodia’s tenure as the ASEAN Chair. This period was marked by allegations that Cambodia was collaborating with China to obstruct discussions on the South China Sea within ASEAN meetings, claims that Cambodia subsequently refuted.

It is noteworthy, however, that following this impasse, ASEAN foreign ministers eventually reached a six-point consensus on the South China Sea issue. This breakthrough was largely attributed to the shuttle diplomacy efforts of the then Indonesian Foreign Minister, Marty Natalegawa. This development illustrates Cambodia’s ability to adapt and approach diplomatically sensitive issues with a pragmatic mindset.

❖ Challenging the Criticism

Former Prime Minister Hun Sen has been vocal in questioning why Cambodia was singled out for the South China Sea issue when other ASEAN Chairs faced similar challenges.

He characterized the singling out of Cambodia as ‘injustice’. At the graduation ceremony at one university in Phnom Penh in February 2016, he said, “Those who attacked Cambodia or me personally apologize to me and repay my justice.”

“Maybe it is time to return justice to me. I told John Kerry I was disappointed when the critics said that Cambodia’s closeness to China was the obstacle to realizing the Code of Conduct in the South China Sea,” he added.

He drew attention to the fact that even when Cambodia was no longer the Chair of ASEAN, other ASEAN Chairs also failed to make progress on the issue, including an attempt to finalize a binding, substantive Code of Conduct (COC).

“Before Cambodia took its turn, Vietnam and Indonesia were the rotating Chairs of ASEAN. Why couldn’t they realize it? Did they do it after Cambodia’s turn, Brunei, Myanmar, and Malaysia? What could they say about it?” he literally asked.

❖ Cambodia’s Stand on Sovereignty Disputes

Cambodia has consistently pushed to address the South China Sea issue within a regional context, cautioning against its over-internationalization. This stance, articulated by then Secretary of State Kao Kim Hourn in 2012, emphasized ASEAN’s role and the ASEAN-China mechanism in handling the dispute.

Cambodia also underscores the importance of direct negotiations between concerned parties. This approach aligns with the understanding that ASEAN, while instrumental for regional peace and cooperation, is not the arbitrator in sovereignty disputes.

Mr Hun Sen’s statements at various forums, especially in early 2016, reiterated Cambodia’s view that ASEAN should not intervene in territorial and sovereign disputes between the Member States or between the Member State(s) and other countries, advocating for bilateral negotiations between concerned parties.

“ASEAN does not have rights to divide land among them. Vietnam and China would have to sit down and work together. The Philippines and China, or the Philippines

and Vietnam, will have to sit down and work out their differences,” Mr Hun Sen said in early 2016.

❖ **Asserting Independent Foreign Policy**

Then Prime Minister Hun Sen had consistently affirmed Cambodia’s independent and sovereign foreign policy, emphasizing the nation’s strategic autonomy from major powers like China and the United States.

This stance is pivotal in understanding Cambodia’s approach to regional issues, reflecting its commitment to navigate a course based on national interests and principles.

In response to the 2016 arbitral tribunal’s decision regarding the South China Sea, Mr Hun Sen declared Cambodia’s unwillingness to support the decision, advocating for bilateral negotiations to resolve disputes.

He said the tribunal’s decision is “politically motivated.” The Philippines did not consult other ASEAN Member States before bringing the case against China- deviating from the spirit of the Declaration on the Conduct of Parties (DOC) in the South China Sea

Cambodia’s Ministry of Foreign Affairs and International Cooperation issued a statement on 9 July 2016 stressing that “Cambodia views this arbitration case is to settle dispute brought by the Philippines against China, and this proceeding is not related to all ASEAN Member States. Therefore, Cambodia will not join in expressing any common position on the verdict.”

Cambodia’s South China Sea dispute narrative showcases a nation striving to balance regional dynamics, uphold sovereignty, and advocate for a realistic and pragmatic approach to dispute resolution. While facing criticism and challenges, understanding Cambodia’s perspective is key to appreciating the broader context of this ongoing complex, volatile geopolitical issue.

This article was first published in Khmer Time on 12 October 2023.

Cambodia's Neighbourhood Diplomacy, Navigating Turbulent Waters

In a world fraught with uncertainty, complexity, and volatility, Cambodia finds itself at a pivotal inflection point, where global governance, multilateralism, and the rules-based international order face unprecedented strains and challenges after the end of the Cold War.

The world faces multiple crises, from the protracted war in Ukraine to the escalating war in the Middle East. In Asia, a trio of security flashpoints – India-Pakistan tensions over Kashmir, a fragile security environment on the Korean Peninsula, and deep-rooted complex disputes in the South China Sea and Taiwan Straits – keep the world on edge.

Southeast Asia grapples with a convergence of challenges or a perfect storm within this complex geopolitical landscape- a mixture of the US-China power competition, sluggish economic recovery, supply chain disruptions, and rising identity politics and nationalism.

The intricate dance between China and the US casts a long shadow over the region. Southeast Asian countries are under increasing pressure to choose sides although they persistently resist doing so. Maintaining strategic autonomy is an uphill, long-term struggle for small states like Cambodia.

The geopolitical and geoeconomic landscape in the Mekong region is undergoing a profound transformation, marked by increasing complex dynamics of power reconfiguration. Almost all significant powers have engaged the area through various initiatives.

This region, historically characterized by its natural beauty and rich cultural heritage, is now emerging as a pivotal theater for significant power competition on both political and economic fronts. China has taken all measures to secure this strategic backyard from being influenced by external powers, particularly the US.

The crisis in Myanmar has invited foreign intervention. ASEAN has not effectively responded to the problem due to its limited crisis management capacity and non-interference principle. The lack of political consensus and united position within ASEAN prevents this inter-governmental organization from having a breakthrough in dealing with the crisis.

Transboundary water resource management is another critical issue that requires a coherent, effective regional response. The Mekong River Commission provides technical solutions to the problems related to managing the Mekong River Basin but does not have enforcement power. Therefore, the political will of all riverine countries is of utmost importance.

Given these challenges, Cambodia believes confidence-building measures, preventive diplomacy, and robust crisis management mechanisms are essential. Simultaneously, Cambodia firmly upholds the principles of the rules-based international order while promoting open and inclusive multilateralism.

Cambodia has been proactive in strengthening cooperation and partnerships with its immediate neighbours to maintain regional peace and stability and create new economic opportunities for the Kingdom and the region.

Under the leadership of Prime Minister Hun Manet, Cambodia is going to deepen regional integration further- believing that Cambodia's future or destiny cannot be detached from that of the region. Transforming Cambodia into a gateway a hub, or a bridging state of the Mekong region is a long-term endeavor.

Cambodia's neighbourhood diplomacy is rooted in the fundamental principles of mutual respect, mutual understanding, mutual trust, and mutual interest for peace and prosperity (M4P2). These principles are the bedrock upon which Cambodia's foreign policy strategy is constructed. Neighbouring countries occupy a central and pivotal position within Cambodia's foreign policy framework.

❖ Cooperation with Lao PDR

Cambodia and Lao PDR share a deep history, cultural values, and identity. This strong bond has translated into a growing bilateral trade relationship, reaching USD 210 million in 2022.

Furthermore, the active participation of 35 Cambodian companies in Laos demonstrates a promising trend of bilateral investment cooperation.

Notably, Laos plays a pivotal role as a “battery” within the Mekong region. Cambodia currently imports approximately 445 megawatts of power from Laos. Looking ahead, is anticipated that power trade will surge to a remarkable 6,000 MW by 2030.

Sustaining and enhancing this trajectory will bolster our energy security and foster greater economic prosperity and sustainability for Cambodia and Laos.

❖ **Cooperation with Thailand**

Cambodia and Thailand enjoy a longstanding relationship marked by practical cooperation and increasing bilateral trade and investment.

At a recent bilateral meeting between the two leaders, both sides agreed to elevate bilateral trade to \$15 billion by 2025. Bilateral trade reached \$4.67 billion in 2022, demonstrating consistent growth since 2015.

Thailand's investments in Cambodia have exceeded \$2 billion in 2022, while Cambodia's investments in Thailand have increased to \$130 million. These investments reflect the strength of economic ties and the potential for further collaboration in various sectors, including infrastructure, agroindustry, and tourism.

❖ **Cooperation with Vietnam**

Cambodia and Vietnam have cultivated time-honored friendship and cooperation characterized by profound political trust and functional collaboration across sectors.

Economic cooperation between Cambodia and Vietnam has flourished. The collaborative efforts have borne fruit, manifesting in a bilateral trade volume that surged beyond \$10 billion in 2022.

Vietnam is one of the critical sources of foreign direct investment in Cambodia, distributed across a diverse array of 200 projects, amounting to a total of over \$2.9 billion.

Cambodia could better exercise its agency and be more resilient by fostering cooperation and collaboration with immediate neighbours. Through such proactive engagement, Cambodia can navigate a multiplex world and contribute to regional development.

The Mekong countries must uphold rules-based international order, promote open and inclusive regionalism, and ensure that diplomacy and dialogue prevail over conflict and confrontation.

This article was first published in Khmer Time on 25 October 2023.

Public Sector Innovation, A Key to Cambodia's Pentagonal Strategy

Cambodia is on the cusp of a transformative journey, and at its heart lies the ambitious Pentagonal Strategy Phase One. With well-defined goals and concrete action plans, this strategic blueprint is poised to propel the nation forward, guided by five essential pillars: human capital development, economic diversification, and competitiveness enhancement, private sector growth, resilient, sustainable, and inclusive development, and the nurturing of a digital economy and society.

At the core of this strategy lies a critical imperative – state institutions' governance and institutional modernization. This transformation hinges on three pivotal words: “cleanness,” “integrity,” and “trust” in public administration. These qualities are the bedrock upon which Cambodia's future success is built.

To realize this vision, Cambodia must continuously robustly enhance its leadership capacity within the public sector. It involves creating frameworks for leadership development, instituting training programs, and fostering networks of capable leaders in public administration. This is a fundamental step towards ensuring that our public institutions are efficient and responsive to the changing needs of our dynamic society.

Moreover, we must embark on a journey of public sector reform. This journey is multifaceted, encompassing process innovation in decision-making, a robust civil service management system, institutional coordination, decentralization, service integration, and digital transformation. These reforms, undertaken with determination, will streamline our bureaucracy, making it more responsive and accountable to the citizens it serves.

The Pentagonal Strategy places considerable emphasis on human resource development within the public sector. It seeks to implement meritocracy in recruitment, appointment, promotion, and incentives. This focus on merit ensures that the best and brightest serve in our public institutions, driving efficiency, accountability, and innovation. The problem the public sector faces is a low number of technocrats. We need more technocrats to drive positive change.

Speaking of innovation, it is not just a buzzword but a catalyst for progress. Innovation means creating something new, something that can be implemented, and something that benefits society.

However, the path to innovation is not a straight line but rather an interactive and social endeavor that demands time and effort.

To foster innovation in the public sector, we must first recognize the need for public organizations to embrace new ideas, approaches, and work methods in response to evolving challenges and the high expectations of our people. Cambodians expect this new administration to deliver concrete public sector reform outcomes. The primary source of legitimacy of the government is performance.

Moreover, we must appreciate the intricate interplay between the individual, the organization, public administration, and society. In this context, leadership should be innovative, data-driven, and people-centric, mirroring the principles of design thinking, which places the needs and aspirations of the people at the forefront. Leaders must motivate their teams to explore new ideas and experiment with novel approaches while building the capacity to collect and analyze data and share knowledge. Knowledge is built through social interaction.

Cross-sectoral and cross-functional collaboration and creativity are essential to driving innovation in the public sector. We must strengthen public-private-people partnerships to develop innovative solutions addressing our most pressing issues and challenges. By working together, we could deliver more as an African proverb says: “If you want to go fast, go alone; if you want to go far, go together”.

Financial commitment to innovation is vital. Allocating budgets for innovation-related projects and programs is essential, and recruiting external consultants to assess and monitor institutional innovation capacity can provide valuable insights. The government must use the budget smartly by investing more resources in building innovation capacity.

Lastly, Cambodia should actively seek international cooperation and support in public sector innovation. Capacity-building in leadership for innovation can benefit from shared knowledge and global best practices. Multi-stakeholder dialogue and consultation on leadership for innovation needs to be aggressively promoted.

The Pentagonal Strategy sets a bold vision for Cambodia’s future. To realize it, public sector innovation is not just a nice-to-have but a must-have. By fostering a culture of innovation, Cambodia can usher in a new era of efficiency, transparency, and progress, ensuring a brighter future for all its citizens. With the right mix of vision,

leadership, and collaboration, Cambodia's transformation is within reach, and public sector innovation is the key to unlocking this promising future.

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Fostering Leadership for Good, A Call to Action

The world stands at a critical juncture, characterized by a deficit in political and strategic trust, a diminishing global governance framework, and a waning commitment to the rules-based international order. This challenging landscape has witnessed the proliferation of wars and conflicts, extending from the conflict in Ukraine to the turmoil in the Middle East. Additionally, security concerns loom large in Asia, with notable flashpoints in the South China Sea and on the Korean Peninsula, heightening tensions in the region.

Cambodia is currently grappling with a myriad of both internal and external challenges. External challenges include escalating geopolitical rivalries, regional conflicts, the looming specter of climate crises, all of which collectively challenge Cambodia's resilience and development prospects.

Domestically, it faces the task of achieving a more robust and resilient economic recovery in the aftermath of the COVID-19 pandemic, addressing vulnerabilities in the real estate sector and financial institutions, promoting public trust in government, and combatting the growing issue of inequality.

Against this backdrop, it is imperative to infuse leadership and innovation into the public sector, nurture an environment conducive to supporting businesses, and cultivate a substantial pool of human capital.

In this connection, it is paramount to create an ecosystem that actively supports businesses, with a particular emphasis on nurturing micro, small, and medium-sized enterprises (MSMEs). These enterprises are the backbone of Cambodia's economy, and by empowering them through financial and infrastructural support, we can drive economic growth, create employment opportunities, and ultimately improve the standard of living of the Cambodian people.

Cambodia must proactively position itself ahead of the curve. We must adopt a strategic foresight approach, which involves anticipating future trends and opportunities, preparing for potential risks, and formulating innovative and transformative strategies to address them. This forward-thinking mindset is crucial to ensuring our nation's resilience and adaptability in the face of evolving global and regional dynamics.

Most importantly, what we need is leadership for the greater good. Leadership for good encompasses a fusion of four distinct leadership styles: conscious leadership, servant leadership, systems leadership, and resonant leadership.

Conscious Leadership is grounded in the belief that leadership is at the heart of every change initiative. During transformative periods, such as the one Cambodia currently experiences, where uncertainty and complexity abound, quality leadership is indispensable. It has the power to steer us through both upheaval and opportunity.

Servant leadership acts as the moral compass guiding our nation through an increasingly volatile, uncertain, complex, and ambiguous (VUCA) world. Leaders who prioritize the greater good ensure that the fruits of transformative change are accessible to all citizens, particularly the marginalized and vulnerable. They instill hope and unity, fostering a sense of shared purpose and commitment to collective progress. Ethical leadership fosters trust between the government and its people, a fundamental element for successful change initiatives.

Systems leadership skills are vital for comprehending the interconnections of issues, addressing root causes, and crafting holistic solutions with an eye on long-term sustainability. In times of transformative change, these leadership capabilities and intelligences—emotional, spiritual, and systems intelligence—jointly contribute to effective governance, social cohesion, and a sustainable path forward for the country, ensuring that no one is left behind.

Resonant leadership nurtures emotional intelligence, enabling leaders to connect with citizens, inspire hope, and rally collective efforts toward a shared vision. Resonant leadership actively involves diverse stakeholders in decision-making, tapping into the wisdom of the crowd and garnering support for transformative policies.

Engaging transformational leaders understand that ownership, learning and engagement are key enablers of high performance. Engaging leaders inspire followers to put in discretionary effort- to go the extra mile-transcending self-interest for the good of the organization and system. They are characterized by a genuine concern for the people, and they prioritize organizational health and development, understanding that employee wellbeing and growth is inextricably linked to long-term success and sustainability.

The inaugural Leadership for Good Summit, taking place on November 7-8 in Phnom Penh, invites stakeholders from the public, private, and civil sectors to reflect,

contemplate, envision, and take decisive steps toward constructing a more inclusive, sustainable, and resilient Cambodia through innovative and transformative leadership.

This summit endeavors to build a community of leaders dedicated to co-creating the Cambodia of their dreams. Through constructive dialogue, we aim to unearth our collective aspirations, strengths, and challenges and pinpoint opportunities for collaborative projects that will have a transformative impact on Cambodia, moving forward.

Ultimately, the goal of the Summit is to inject wisdom, innovative ideas and action plans to realize the Cambodia Vision 2050, which envisions Cambodia to be “a vibrant society”, “a high-income and resilient economy”, “highly knowledgeable” society, and a country that “enjoys harmony, resilience, and inclusivity of physical and natural environment, and has a good balance between development and environmental conservation”.

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Hun Manet's ASEAN Engagement Strategy

As Prime Minister Hun Manet's administration approaches its 100-day milestone this month, notable foreign policy accomplishments stand out as key highlights. This op-ed aims to shed light on Cambodia's ASEAN engagement strategy, drawing upon Prime Minister Hun Manet's remarks at the ASEAN Summits and related Summits held in Indonesia in September.

This discourse of power illustrates Cambodia's well-crafted policy towards ASEAN. It delves into the strategic narratives and increasing relevant role of Cambodia in shaping and molding regional architecture, while positioning Cambodia in the region and beyond.

Obviously, ASEAN stands at a crossroads. By embracing a strategy of inclusivity, cooperation, and forward-looking policies, ASEAN can navigate the complexities of the current global landscape full of uncertainties and risks.

The path ahead is really challenging, but with unity, shared strategic vision, and a commitment to the principles of ASEAN Centrality, the region might emerge stronger and become more resilient, ready to claim its place as the fourth largest world economy in coming years.

❖ Addressing Geopolitical and Goeconomic Challenges

The rising geopolitical and goeconomic competition poses significant challenges for ASEAN. Against this backdrop, cooperation in areas of common interest like trade, investment, green economy, and sustainable development is essential to build trust and avoid zero-sum outcomes.

In this connection, a stable relationship among major powers is crucial for advancing global agenda.

"Without a healthy and stable relation among the major powers, it is extremely difficult to advance any global agenda. Cambodia will do our utmost ability to contribute to strengthening multilateral systems that are inclusive, open, fair, rules-based, transparent, and mutually beneficial," stated Prime Minister Hun Manet.

❖ ASEAN Centrality in a Fragmented World

The principle of ASEAN Centrality must be the cornerstone of our approach. Cambodia has called upon our dialogue partners to support ASEAN Centrality and ASEAN-led mechanisms, fostering a regional environment where every nation, regardless of size, can thrive. In this era of a multiplex world, ASEAN's role as a unifying force is more crucial than ever.

Moreover, ASEAN's dialogue partners must support core priorities without undermining the principles of the ASEAN Outlook on the Indo-Pacific (AOIP)- including openness, transparency, inclusivity, a rules-based framework, good governance, respect for sovereignty, non-intervention. Cambodia has consistently advocated for inclusive, open, fair, and transparent implementation of these principles.

❖ A Strategic Vision for Relevance

To maintain its relevance, ASEAN must adopt a more strategic, proactive approach. This involves proactive engagement with global and regional powers and international organizations. By doing so, ASEAN can better exercise its agency and assert its position on the global stage.

❖ Navigating Transnational Challenges

ASEAN faces a myriad of transnational challenges, from climate change and natural disasters to regional development gap. These challenges necessitate a unified approach, as no single nation can effectively address them alone. By fostering unity and solidarity, ASEAN can turn these challenges into opportunities for regional cooperation and integration.

❖ Opposing the Use of Force

ASEAN and the international community must lead in opposing the use or threat of force against sovereign states. A concerted effort in this direction is indispensable for maintaining regional stability and peace.

❖ The ASEAN Outlook on the Indo-Pacific

Cambodia emphasizes the importance of the ASEAN Outlook on the Indo-Pacific (AOIP). It calls for building synergies between various initiatives and the AOIP, ensuring they contribute to regional peace, stability, and prosperity, and support ASEAN Centrality.

Prime Minister Hun Manet proposed that “we should continue to focus on working together to advance the four priority areas of the AOIP through practical and concrete projects”.

“We welcome any initiatives to support the AOIP as long as: (1) they contribute to regional peace, stability and prosperity, (2) they are not used against any country, and (3) they support the ASEAN Centrality, and are in line with the ASEAN Charter and the AOIP,” he added.

❖ **Myanmar’s Path to Peace**

In Myanmar, ASEAN can provide support but should not impose solutions. The country must lead its own peace process, with ASEAN supporting decisions emerging from a consensus among Myanmar’s parties concerned. This approach requires patience, pragmatism, and flexibility.

Prime Minister Hun Manet stressed that “for the dialogue to succeed, the parties concerned must be committed to finding a solution – including those who are key to the peace process – and do their utmost to build trust and promote a convergence of views. Undoubtedly, the road ahead will be difficult, and require a high degree of patience, pragmatism and flexibility”.

❖ **Leveraging RCEP for Growth**

The Regional Comprehensive Economic Partnership (RCEP) is a landmark agreement that can catalyze ASEAN’s economic growth. By effectively leveraging this partnership, ASEAN can ensure that the benefits of economic integration are equitably shared among its people, which in turn would transform region into an epicenter of growth and dynamism.

Cambodia believes that the RCEP is a catalyst for regional economic growth and integration. It is crucial that all RCEP members implement this partnership fully and effectively, maximizing its potential benefits.

❖ **The Potential of Digital Economy**

The digital economy presents a remarkable potential for ASEAN and its partners. Expected to add \$2 trillion to the regional GDP by 2030, this burgeoning sector offers a pathway to accelerate development and bridge economic disparities. To fully capitalize

on this, ASEAN must foster practical cooperation, ensuring that its citizens are equipped with necessary skills and knowledge to thrive in this digital era.

Prime Minister Hun Manet underscored that “while the digital economy is presenting great potential for ASEAN and its partners, we need to identify and seize this opportunity for practical cooperation to accelerate digital development.”

❖ **Inclusive and Integrated ASEAN**

For ASEAN to become a global growth epicenter, especially against a weakened and fragmented global economy, it must explore new sources of growth. This includes digital transformation, green transitions, and capitalizing on the blue and creative economies. Significantly increasing intra-ASEAN investments in these key sectors is crucial for deeper regional integration.

ASEAN must underscore its commitment to being inclusive and people-centered. Effective implementation of initiatives like Work Plan IV for the Initiative for ASEAN Integration is vital. These efforts will ensure that the benefits of growth and integration are accessible to all ASEAN citizens.

❖ **The Post-2025 Vision**

The High-Level Task Force working on the Post-2025 Vision for the ASEAN Community must propose bold, yet pragmatic, ideas. These ideas should enhance cross-sectoral coordination among the community’s pillars, ensuring that ASEAN remains forward-looking, future-proofed, and ready for upcoming challenges and opportunities.

❖ **ASEAN’s Role in the Global Supply Chain**

As a key player in the global supply chain, ASEAN presents myriad opportunities for businesses of all sizes. From large corporations to small and medium enterprises and startups, the region’s vibrant economic landscape offers fertile ground for innovation and growth.

This article was first published in Khmer Time on 24 November 2023.

Cambodia's Parliamentary Diplomacy in a New Era

At the dawn of a transformative phase, Cambodia is steering a new course in both its domestic reforms and foreign policy dynamics, following a pivotal transition in its executive and legislative leadership. In this evolving landscape, the role of parliamentary diplomacy emerges as a critical element, especially amidst escalating global geopolitical tensions and conflicts.

Parliamentary diplomacy encompasses the diverse international efforts made by parliamentarians aimed at enhancing mutual comprehension among nations, aiding in the enhancement of government oversight and people's representation, and bolstering the democratic validity of inter-governmental organizations.

Compared to executive diplomacy, parliamentary diplomacy holds distinct benefits. These include greater adaptability in engaging with a wide range of local players and the ability to communicate more freely, even on delicate matters. This approach is reshaping the traditional view of diplomacy and helping to bridge the democratic gap in foreign policy decision-making.

Under the leadership of Samdech Khuon Sudary, Cambodia's parliamentary diplomacy is gaining remarkable momentum. This new wave of diplomatic activism is evident in bilateral and multilateral interactions and consistent strategic narratives. Remarkably, over the past three months, she has met 24 foreign leaders and diplomats.

Cambodia's parliamentary diplomacy was at full play when Cambodia hosted the President of the Republic of Korea's National Assembly, Kim Jin Pyo, in early September. Both sides amicably, openly, and candidly exchanged views on regional issues of mutual interest and underscored a shared political will and commitment to boost comprehensive bilateral cooperation, particularly between the two legislatures.

Moreover, productive discussions with Thai Prime Minister Srettha Thavisin in late September highlighted Cambodia's dedication to nurturing its 'good neighbor' diplomacy. Immediate neighbors are central to Cambodia's foreign policy strategy. To further this objective, Khuon Sudary will lead a high-level delegation to Vietnam and Lao PDR later this month to reinforce traditional ties and deepen the scope of comprehensive cooperation between Cambodia and its neighbors.

Recent interactions and dialogues with foreign leaders and diplomats, coupled with the public statements by the President of the National Assembly, highlight the

evolution of Cambodia's parliamentary diplomacy around seven key pillars. These pillars represent Cambodia's aspirations and its commitment to contribute to international peace, harmony and prosperity- driven by a dual focus: to advance Cambodia's core national interests and to contribute meaningfully to the broader goals of humanity.

Firstly, economic diplomacy stands at the vanguard. In an era where economies are increasingly interconnected, Cambodia's legislature is pivotal in steering the nation towards seamless regional and global integration. This approach is not just about participating in the global economy; it's about strategically maximizing the benefits and opportunities stemming from globalization and regionalization. By enhancing market access and competitiveness, Cambodia can position itself as a dynamic player in the international market.

The forthcoming inaugural Cambodia-Lao PDR-Vietnam Parliamentary Summit, scheduled to take place early next month in Vientiane, presents an opportunity for the Cambodian parliament to exercise its agency and leadership role. This summit aims to bolster the synergy between legislative and executive branches, enhancing their combined efforts to meet shared development goals especially in the areas of cross-border trade, investment, and tourism, the building of resilient regional supply chains particularly in the agriculture sector, and the promotion of sustainable development. This summit is set to be a landmark event in fostering regional cooperation and connectivity.

The second pillar, peace diplomacy, combines the quest for economic advancement with the preservation of peace. In a global landscape often marred by strife, Cambodia's journey provides valuable insights for managing crises and resolving conflicts. The 'win-win' approach, championed by ex-Prime Minister Samdech Hun Sen, serves as valuable experiences and lessons learned for others. Along this line, the National Assembly President frequently emphasizes to international colleagues that peace is a prerequisite for development, just as development is essential for sustaining peace. The parliament plays increasingly relevant role in promoting peace.

Cultural diplomacy, the third pillar, underscores the power of cultural exchanges in building bridges. In an increasingly polarized world, Cambodia is leveraging the universal language of culture to foster understanding and trust between different civilizations. This effort goes beyond mere cultural promotion; it's about creating the relational bedrock upon which economic and political alliances can be built.

Notably, Khuon Sudary also serves as the Chairwoman of the Asian Cultural Council- a platform that she utilizes to promote culture as a cornerstone for fostering

peace, spurring development, and igniting innovation. Her leadership emphasizes the vital role of cultural understanding and exchange in shaping a more harmonious, prosperous, and sustainable future.

The fourth pillar, people diplomacy, underscores the essential role of parliamentarians as the voice of the people. By emphasizing direct connections between individuals and communities, Cambodia can promote a more inclusive and participatory approach to international relations. This approach is especially crucial in today's world, where the perspectives and voices of ordinary citizens can be overshadowed by high-level political dialogues. Cambodia's focus on people-to-people and person-to-person diplomacy aims to ensure that the voices of the people and key stakeholders are not only heard but are also integral in shaping global discourse and world order. Inter-personal relationships and friendships especially between leaders is critical to promoting mutual understanding and trust between nations.

The fifth pillar focuses on gender equality and women's empowerment. As the first female President of the National Assembly, she has significantly amplified her efforts to foster international cooperation, particularly among parliamentarians, to advance Sustainable Development Goal 5. Addressing the National Forum on 'Women in Leadership and Governance' this month, she advocated for the expansion of cross-sectoral partnerships and networks to support women in areas like capacity building and leadership development, thereby empowering them to take on more prominent roles in governance and decision-making processes.

The sixth pillar centers on the critical intersection of climate change and the water-energy-food security nexus. Recognizing the urgency of these interconnected challenges, she has emphasized the need for more robust international collaboration to address climate change through both mitigation and adaptation strategies while also advocating for stronger inter-parliamentary cooperation on climate change. This cooperation is key to effectively managing the interconnected issues of water, energy, and food security, ensuring a sustainable and resilient future.

Finally, the development of a digital parliament marks a significant leap towards good governance- which includes the principles of transparency and accountability. As Cambodia transitions into digital economy and society, the digital transformation of the legislative branch is not just a technological upgrade; it's a commitment to more accessible, efficient, responsive, transparent and people-centered governance. By equipping parliamentary staff and lawmakers with the tools and knowledge to navigate

the digital landscape, Cambodia is setting a precedent for the future of parliamentary work.

During the meeting with foreign counterparts, the National Assembly President has actively sought support and collaboration with international partners to foster the development of a digital parliament, encompassing not only the advancement of hardware and software but also the cultivation of human capital.

Cambodia's embrace of parliamentary diplomacy under the new leadership presents a dynamic and proactive approach to international relations, while setting a precedent for how nations can engage internationally in a more inclusive, democratic, and people-centered manner.

This article was first published in Khmer Time on 30 November 2023.

Cambodia's Fight Against Non-Communicable Diseases, A Multi-Faceted Challenge and Strategic Response

Cambodia's struggle against non-communicable diseases (NCDs) highlights a significant health challenge faced by many developing countries. These chronic diseases, which include cardiovascular diseases, cancer, chronic respiratory diseases, diabetes, and mental health conditions, are primarily driven by a combination of genetic, environmental, and behavioral factors. The prevalence of these diseases is increasing globally, and they now account for seven out of the ten leading causes of death worldwide.

In Cambodia, the prevalence of NCDs is not only a health issue but also an economic concern. NCDs are responsible for 64 percent of all deaths in Cambodia, and the population has a 23 percent probability of dying between the ages 30 and 70 years from one of the four main NCDs. The total economic burden of NCDs to the Cambodian economy is \$1.5 billion per year, equivalent to 6.6 percent of the country's annual gross domestic product (GDP).

This situation necessitates a multifaceted approach, integrating health interventions with broader economic and social policies.

A multi-faceted and multi-pronged approach is vital for safeguarding the health and well-being of the population, sustaining economic growth, fulfilling the 2030 UN Sustainable Development Goals, and realizing Cambodia Vision 2050.

In March 2019, the Cambodian NCD Alliance (CNCDA) was launched to intensify efforts against the escalating challenge of NCDs, while fostering a new wave of cooperative efforts. This informal alliance brings together 22 diverse entities, including civil society organizations, bilateral and multilateral agencies, academic and research institutions, relevant governmental departments, and patient advocacy groups. It introduced a comprehensive 3-year Strategic Plan (2020-2023), structured around four core objectives: advocacy, knowledge exchange, collaboration, and monitoring.

In 2013, the National Strategy Plan (NSP) for Prevention and Control of NCDs was introduced, which seeks to scale up screening, cost-effective care, and treatment.

Targeting at-risk people over 40 with routine check-ups can provide early detection before diseases become unmanageable and untreatable.

The National Assembly of Cambodia has been active in campaigning against NCDs. In a recent address at the consultation workshop on preventive measures on NCDs and gender Gap reduction in Phnom Penh, the President of the National Assembly, Samdech Khuon Sudary, called for a comprehensive national campaign to mitigate NCD risk factors through societal behavioral changes and lifestyle modifications.

President Sudary outlined a strategic ten-point action plan as following:

First, acknowledging complexity: Recognize NCDs as multifaceted challenges that intersect various sectors, including healthcare, education, the economy, agriculture, trade, society, culture, environment, and gender.

Second, elevating public awareness: Intensify public education on NCD risk factors and prevention, with a special focus on women. This involves a holistic health promotion strategy that goes beyond basic awareness to include environmental modifications, technological integration, and community mobilization for reaching hard-to-reach populations.

Third, launching “Healthy Life, Healthy Cambodia”: Initiate a campaign to educate citizens about maintaining a healthy lifestyle, emphasizing nutritious diets and regular physical activity.

Fourth, fostering Multi-Stakeholder Partnerships: Encourage collaboration across various entities for data collection, research, knowledge sharing, and ensuring healthcare accessibility, particularly for women.

Fifth, strengthening Public-Private Partnerships: Enhance collaboration between the public sector and the private sector on research, development and innovation in medicine, aiming to improve affordability and accessibility, especially within the context of health crises or emergencies.

Sixth, implementing the Ministry of Health’s Multi-Sectoral Action Plan: Advocate for the promotion and effective execution of the Ministry of Health’s Multi-sectoral Action Plan for NCD Prevention and Control (2018-2027), with an emphasis on gender-specific health issues.

Seventh, implementing the National Salt Reduction Action Plan: Ensure the successful implementation of the 2021-2027 National Action Plan for Salt Reduction. This includes public education on the dangers of high salt consumption, regulatory measures to lower salt in processed foods, and partnerships with the food industry to promote low-salt products.

Eight, enforcing health-related laws and regulations: Urge the Ministry of Health and other relevant ministries to rigorously enforce regulations pertaining to food safety and public health, including the control of alcohol and tobacco consumption.

Ninth, developing legal frameworks: Propose comprehensive studies to establish legal frameworks governing alcohol consumption, focusing on aspects such as the minimum age for purchase and consumption, restrictions on sale times, and regulation of advertising for alcoholic and high-sugar beverages.

Tenth, increasing taxes on harmful substances: Collaborate between the Ministry of Health and the Ministry of Economy and Finance to raise taxes on alcohol, tobacco, and sugar-rich drinks, aiming to reduce consumption of these harmful substances.

These proposals reflect a robust, multidimensional approach to combatting NCDs in Cambodia, highlighting the need for integrated efforts across various sectors and levels of governance. Health promotion extends beyond informing the community on what they can or cannot do to improve their own health – it calls for a holistic approach that encompasses modifying the built environment, leveraging data and technology, and rallying communities and volunteers to support the health of the hard-to-reach community members.

While Cambodia's response to the NCD crisis is evolving, there is a clear need for more coordinated, comprehensive strategies that transcend healthcare boundaries. This includes enforcing public health regulations, developing legal frameworks for alcohol and tobacco control, and increasing taxes on harmful substances including sugar-rich beverages.

Success in this endeavor will not only improve health outcomes but also contribute to sustainable economic growth and the realization of Cambodia Vision 2050- to become a high-income country.

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What to Expect in 2024?

We are not out of the woods yet. The year 2024 remains in a state of a perfect storm.

The global economy and geopolitical landscape are in a state of flux, with old paradigms being challenged and new ones emerging. This will undoubtedly be a period of multiple transitions, a time for cautious navigation through the choppy waters of global affairs.

It is a moment for policymakers, businesses, and individuals alike to be agile, adaptable, and prepared for a journey through uncharted waters.

The emergence of the new COVID-19 variant JN.1 is causing a new wave of infections worldwide. The pandemic, which has stretched over several years now, continues to exert unprecedented pressure on healthcare systems, with new infections and the need for ongoing vaccination and booster campaigns.

The impacts of the pandemic have been far-reaching, exacerbating existing inequalities. In 2023, we witnessed how the crisis deepened disparities across various spheres. The economic fallout disproportionately affected the lower-income groups, widening the income gap. Job losses and reduced incomes became more prevalent among the less privileged.

Environmental degradation and climate-related disasters have hit the poorer communities harder, who often lack the resources and infrastructure to deal with such calamities.

Conflicts and wars have added complexity to the crisis. Geopolitical tensions and internal strife in various parts of the world have led to humanitarian crises, with millions of people displaced from their homes, adding to the global burden of inequality and suffering.

Geopolitical instability emerges as a key global threat, casting a long shadow over global economic growth, with ramifications that transcend national borders.

In this global chess game, certain regions are emerging as critical theaters. The Asia Pacific region, with its three security hotspots – the Taiwan Straits, the Korean Peninsula, and the South China Sea – is set to become more complex and volatile this year.

The US-China competition further complicates the existing intricate geopolitical map. The relationship between these two global powerhouses is anticipated to be increasingly unpredictable, unstable, and volatile, underpinned by the extensive interconnectedness of the current global system.

While the risk of a full-scale military confrontation between these two competing giants remains minimal, the undercurrents of this rivalry will have far-reaching implications for global stability and economic growth.

This perfect storm has catalyzed a seismic shift in international trading patterns and growth prospects. The quest for national security and greater economic resilience has become a driving force, reshaping global trade and capital flows.

This new world order is opening up novel investment frontiers across emerging markets and Asia, offering a silver lining in the midst of global challenges. China – is likely to regain its footing after a year of slower growth. The stabilization of the Chinese economy in 2024 will be a crucial factor in the global economic recovery.

The world economic outlook is projected to achieve a modest growth of 2.7% in 2024 and rebound to 3% in 2025.

Democracies worldwide are bracing for an acid test as authoritarian inclinations and populist movements gain momentum, challenging the established order and potentially altering the global geopolitical landscape.

Populist movements, often characterized by their appeal to the general populace over the elite and their emphasis on nationalistic policies, are gaining momentum across the globe.

The rise in protectionism, a byproduct of this populist surge, further complicates the global economic and political landscape. Countries are more frequently looking inward, focusing on protecting their own industries and workforce, often at the expense of international trade and cooperation.

The upcoming elections in the U.S. are anticipated to be among the most contentious and polarized in its history. Some have called it the “poisonous” elections. The US will be more protectionist, inward-looking. As a result, the US will be weaker, not stronger.

For Cambodia, the economic outlook is quite resilient, with a projected growth rate surpassing 6 percent, supported by several key sectors.

One of the most significant contributors to Cambodia's robust growth has been the resurgence of its tourism sector. Cambodia has witnessed a substantial increase in tourist arrivals, and the trend will continue.

The country's rich cultural heritage, exemplified by the iconic Angkor Wat, coupled with its natural beauty, has once again made it a popular destination. This revival has not only boosted revenues but also stimulated associated sectors such as hospitality, retail, and transportation.

Another key driver of growth has been the rise in domestic consumption. As the Cambodian economy recovers, consumer confidence has rebounded, leading to increased spending on goods and services. This upswing in domestic consumption reflects the growing purchasing power of the Cambodian populace, a positive indicator of economic health and stability.

The diversification of the manufacturing sector has also played a pivotal role. While Cambodia has traditionally been known for its garment manufacturing, there has been a notable expansion in non-garment sectors. This diversification has made the economy more resilient.

The influx of FDI has been another cornerstone of Cambodia's economic success. Attracted by the country's stable political environment, competitive labor costs, and strategic location in Southeast Asia, foreign investors have been keen to capitalize on the opportunities present in various sectors such as manufacturing and agro-industry.

Lastly, substantial investments in infrastructure have significantly contributed to Cambodia's growth. The government's focus on improving roads, ports, and power supplies has made the country more attractive to foreign investors and has played a crucial role in supporting the other growth drivers, like tourism and manufacturing.

While we continue to walk in the dark woods entering 2024, we must always stay hopeful. It is an invitation for us to reimagine the future, to build a world that is more resilient, inclusive, and sustainable.

We can chart a course towards a brighter, more prosperous horizon. Cambodia needs to boost up reform momentum, with concrete results. People are waiting to see reform outcomes. We need to speed up before it is too late.

Governance and leadership reforms are expected to gain new momentum. More corrupt officials are expected to be punished.

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The Evolving Landscape of Nation-Building

Nation-building represents a dynamic process wherein the institutional and cultural elements continually interact and evolve. The success of this endeavour hinges on the harmonious alignment of these dimensions, with mutual reinforcement.

A robust and effective state institution relies on a unified national identity to secure the loyalty and social contract- people's trust in the state institutions. Conversely, a strong and cohesive national identity is best preserved and celebrated within the framework of a well-functioning state.

In an era defined by technological revolution, the traditional concept of nation-building is undergoing a profound transformation.

The core elements of nation-building, encompassing identity, legitimacy, penetration, participation, and distribution, continue to hold relevance in this evolving landscape.

Originally conceived as a process of national integration and consolidation leading to the establishment of the modern nation-state, nation-building now grapples with new challenges and opportunities in the digital age.

Within this digital age, it is crucial to encourage and empower active engagement and inputs from individuals in matters pertaining to state governance by allowing citizens to have a voice and leverage in the decision-making process. A people-centred governance is fundamental to advancing nation-building.

Moreover, the notion of “Smart Nation” has become an integral part of nation-building, where technology empowers citizens to impact changes and connect. The Smart Nation represents a future where boundaries are transcended, and digital solutions benefit people and businesses across borders.

Singapore launched “Smart Nation” strategy in 2014 aiming to “support better living, stronger communities, and create more opportunities, for all”, focusing on three pillars: digital society, digital economy, and digital government.

In Cambodia, a nation that has endured prolonged periods of war and internal conflict, the process of nation-building took a unique path. After achieving peace and national reunification in the late 1990s, Cambodia embarked on a journey of economic and social integration, bringing together people from diverse backgrounds. As a result,

peace and order, cultural identity, social harmony, and economic development are the key elements of nation building.

According to Cambodian academician Gaffar Peang-Meth, Khmer values, such as korup (respect), kaowd-klach (admiration and fear), smoh trang (loyalty), bamreur (service), and karpier (defense), persist as pillars of Cambodian society, shaping its character and guiding its interactions even in the contemporary context.

He added, for the Khmer people, the process of nation-building can be aptly described as a continuous journey of “re-building”, “reviving”, and “rebranding”. It entails preserving and revitalizing their national and cultural identities, adapting to change, and ensuring the enduring legacy of the Khmer nation.

Technology is driving the next phase of nation-building. Cambodia is forced to harness digital technology to its advantage, enhancing its strengths and overcoming challenges. The transformation brought by digitalization is pervasive, necessitating policies, legislations, and public-private cooperation to ensure success.

In this digital era, businesses are spurred to invest in technology and talent, while individuals are empowered to cultivate their talents and embrace digital technologies for better lives. The state needs to adapt and respond to these changes.

As we navigate the digital frontier, it is evident that nation-building is no longer confined to the traditional parameters of statehood and identity.

For instance, the Smart Nation concept and Cambodia’s unique journey underscore the importance of adaptability and innovation in the face of evolving challenges and opportunities. In this digital age, the path to nation-building is very much shaped by technology.

Cambodia launched the Digital Economy and Society Policy Framework 2021-2035 in 2021 aimed at fortifying digital ecosystem, ensuring its resilience in the face of crises, and enabling agile responses to the ever-evolving digital technology landscape.

Moreover, Digital Government Policy 2022-2035 was introduced in 2022 to establish a digital government that enhances citizens’ quality of life and fosters public trust through the provision of excellent public services.

In Cambodia, the trajectory of nation-building in a digital age is driven by the four unfolding initiatives.

First, the digital economy has emerged as a potent force, propelling businesses to redirect their investments into cutting-edge technology and the acquisition of top-tier talent.

Businesses, fuelled by the digital revolution, have the potential to expand their horizons, forging regional and global connections. Digital trade, e-commerce and digital payments are gaining pace.

Second, within the realm of the digital society, individuals find themselves empowered by possessing the tools and opportunities to cultivate their skills and harness the latest technological advancements.

As a collective force, individuals in this digital era can elevate their voices and opinion, using technology to address societal challenges, and create a more inclusive future. But the government and the private sector need to promote inclusive digital economy to ensure that no one is left behind in digital transformation.

Third, concerning digital government, it is important to enhance the efficiency, accountability, and transparency of the state institutions – delivering better public services and ensuring that the voices of the people are valued and integrated into the decision-making processes.

Fourth, the development of a digital parliament – still in a nascent stage – aims to overhaul and modernize the legislative body and process, ensuring efficiency, accountability, and transparency through digital adoption and transformation.

Digital parliament is designed to better serve the evolving needs and aspirations of the people. It is expected that through technology and digital platforms the lawmakers will be able to engage with their constituents more effectively and swiftly, leverage data-driven policy design and decision making, and streamline legislative procedures to address emerging social, economic, and environmental issues.

To realise the four pillars above, Cambodia needs to invest more resources in research and development, innovation, and human capital development, while promoting robust multi-stakeholder dialogues and consultations and developing strategic foresight.

Moreover, data accessibility, cybersecurity, and data privacy occupy a pivotal role in safeguarding digital transformation. Public agencies should make data sets accessible to the public, fostering a collaborative environment for digital solutions that benefit society at large.

The human factor is the most important element in driving nation building. A people-centred approach is a philosophical compass. Technology is a tool.

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Cambodia's Economic Diplomacy Gains Momentum

Economics determines politics. Economic security is national security. Economic performance defines regime legitimacy.

As a small and open economy, open and inclusive regionalism and international economic integration are the strategic compass of the Kingdom.

Against this backdrop, the new administration in Cambodia has exhibited a noticeable shift in its foreign policy priorities, focusing on economic considerations. It can be argued that economic pragmatism is one of the key features of Cambodia's foreign policy in a new era.

Cambodia's economic diplomacy has been remarkably gaining momentum under the leadership of Prime Minister Hun Manet. His relentless efforts to achieve national economic interests can be seen in numerous overseas visits and his meetings with foreign guests in the capital, all with the primary objective of economically connecting Cambodia with the world.

Each overseas visit demonstrates Cambodia's economic pragmatism and strategic diversification strategy to extract the maximum benefits from existing bilateral and multilateral mechanisms to advance Cambodia's economic interests. In other words, how to transform the international environment and partnerships into a source of national growth and strength.

In 2021, the Ministry of Foreign Affairs and International Cooperation unveiled a comprehensive economic diplomacy strategy (2021-2023). This strategy sets ambitious goals, including the promotion of international trade, attracting foreign direct investment, boosting tourism, and promoting Cambodia's cultural identity.

The strategy underlines the importance of establishing a robust and efficient mechanism that would sustain and further enhance the country's economic growth by fostering multi-sectoral and multi-stakeholder collaboration on both national and international fronts. Systemic approaches are required.

The key challenges identified in the strategy include insufficient qualified human resource, insufficient financial resource to carry out the implementation of relevant action plans, lack of cross sectoral coordination and an effective information sharing platform

between the relevant actors, and lack of nation branding campaigns and lobbying activities.

Looking ahead, the Ministry of Foreign Affairs and International Cooperation is in the process of crafting a new economic diplomacy framework- being designed to adapt to evolving national and international situations while aligning with the strategic objectives of the Pentagonal Strategy. Despite strong backing from top-level political leadership, the effective implementation of economic diplomacy still presents challenges at the working level.

The linchpin of Cambodia's economic diplomacy lies in domestic reforms. To fulfil its vision of attracting more investments, it is important to keep improving investment and business environment. Only through these results-based reforms and substantial improvements can the nation fully realize its economic potential and its vision to become a high-income country by 2050.

Notably, good governance takes centre stage in the Pentagonal Strategy Phase One, making it the core element of Cambodia's economic diplomacy. Ensuring clean, smart, and efficient public institutions, and a fair, just and efficient legal system is critical here.

The Pentagonal Strategy underscores the importance of improving the quality of public institutions at both national and sub-national levels to ensure efficiency of public services, strengthening private sector governance, and fostering favourable environment for business, investment, and trade. More concrete results are expected.

The new investment law adopted in 2021 provides new incentives, better guarantees, and easier procedures to attract more investments. Sectors entitled to investment incentives include those related to high-tech industries, digital technology, green technology, manufacturing, agriculture, agro-industry, education, health, and infrastructure.

Cambodia recognizes that expanding international trade requires a multifaceted strategy. In recent years, the Kingdom has actively pursued this goal through strategic trade negotiations, achieving significant milestones such as the conclusion of two free trade agreements with China and the Republic of Korea.

Moreover, Cambodia played a crucial role in the negotiation of the Regional Comprehensive Economic Partnership (RCEP) which was launched during its

chairmanship of ASEAN in 2012. After eight years of intensive negotiation, RCEP was concluded in 2021 and entered into force in 2022.

To further this endeavour, Cambodia is now working on instituting robust trade promotion policies, underpinned by an effective implementation mechanism. This strategic move aims to create an environment conducive to fostering trade relationships and removing barriers that impede the flow of goods and services.

In the wake of Cambodia's ambitious journey towards digital transformation, digital trade is emerging as a component of the nation's foreign trade strategy. Digital trade, relatively new to Cambodia, refers to commercial activities facilitated through electronic means, relying on telecommunications and information and communication technology (ICT) services. It encompasses a broad spectrum, including trade in goods and services.

It needs to be noted that the success of Cambodia's international trade strategy hinges not only on negotiations and policies but also on the development of a supportive ecosystem for Cambodian entrepreneurs and exporters. This ecosystem is indispensable for nurturing local businesses and enabling them to penetrate and thrive in the highly competitive international market.

Small and medium-sized enterprises play an important role in this regard. SMEs need more government's support in access to finance and market, capacity building digital literacy and digital marketing, and innovation capacity enhancement such as product, service, and process innovation.

Cambodia's economic diplomacy is on an upward trajectory, guided by a comprehensive strategy and driven by visionary, transformative leadership. However, to fully unlock its potential, Cambodia must continuously, robustly implement public sector reforms especially-with a focus on good governance and the war on corruption- and continue to foster an environment conducive to business, investment, and trade.

More resources are needed to invest in economic intelligence- collecting and analysing economic data, leadership development and capacity building in relation to economic diplomacy, nation branding, and strategic lobbying.

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Cambodia's Reform Path, A Promising Journey

Six months have elapsed since the inception of Cambodia's 7th legislature, heralding a new era of reform and progress. The trajectory of this reform is guided by a firm political will and a steadfast commitment to prioritize the needs and aspirations of the people.

Grounded in growth-oriented, innovation-driven, and efficiency-based strategies, the government's agenda underscores a fundamental shift towards more sustainable path.

While notable achievements have been recorded, challenges persist, demanding a comprehensive approach to address structural impediments and foster holistic, resilient growth across key sectors.

Importantly, a fair and equitable system of rewards and incentives, coupled with effective disciplinary measures and punishments, must be uniformly implemented across all state agencies, both at the national and sub-national levels. This will enhance effective enforcement of good governance principles outlined in the Pentagonal Strategy Phase One.

One of the noteworthy accomplishments lies in the domain of social security and healthcare. The expansion of the social security system and the health equity fund has significantly improved access to essential services, encompassing a staggering 6.8 million beneficiaries. Notably, over 2.1 million members of the National Social Security Fund now enjoy enhanced support, alongside assistance extended to vulnerable families and households in critical need.

Moreover, initiatives targeting youth development through vocational training underscore the government's commitment to empower marginalized segments of society, laying the groundwork for sustainable socio-economic advancement. The government has set the target to train 1.5 million youths from impoverished and underprivileged backgrounds, with 27,894 already benefitting from this scheme.

Despite these strides, structural challenges persist, chief among them being the fragmented state bureaucracy and weak governance. The labyrinthine bureaucratic apparatus poses a formidable barrier to effective governance and impedes the ease of doing business—a critical aspect for fostering entrepreneurship and attracting investment.

Recognizing the imperative of structural reforms, the government has embarked on a multifaceted approach aimed at streamlining governance, enhancing business regulations, and promoting domestic and foreign investment. These efforts are pivotal in unlocking the full potential of Cambodia's economy and ensuring equitable growth across all sectors.

The rural economy stands as a linchpin of Cambodia's economic landscape, with over 70 percent of the population residing in rural areas. While top-down reforms have been initiated to revitalize rural communities, there exists a pressing need to adopt a more inclusive, bottom-up approach.

Empowering local communities and soliciting feedback from grassroots levels are indispensable in crafting policies that resonate with the realities on the ground. Moreover, fostering innovation and bolstering the capacity of Micro, Small, and Medium Enterprises (MSMEs) are essential to unleashing the full potential of the rural economy. By harnessing niche areas of advantage and leveraging innovative practices, rural MSMEs can emerge as engines of growth.

In tandem with the digital revolution sweeping the globe, Cambodia is poised to harness the transformative potential of the digital economy. The establishment of the National Council of Digital Economy and Society underscores the government's commitment to fostering a vibrant digital ecosystem. However, ensuring inclusivity remains a paramount challenge, necessitating investments in both hard and soft digital infrastructure. Moreover, supporting the burgeoning startup ecosystem through targeted financial and technical assistance is crucial in nurturing innovation and driving economic dynamism.

Amidst the imperative to foster economic growth, the imperative of environmental sustainability looms large. The transition to a green economy represents a paradigm shift towards low-carbon activities and sustainable development practices.

By incentivizing private sector investment in renewable energy and dismantling barriers to market entry, Cambodia can chart a course towards a greener, more resilient future. For instance, it is important to enable private investment in green energy such as solar panel production and solar energy generation.

Cambodia's reform journey holds immense promise for ushering in a new era of prosperity and progress. By prioritizing people-centered policies, embracing innovation,

and fostering inclusive growth, the government can pave the way for a brighter future for all Cambodians.

However, this journey is fraught with challenges, necessitating concerted efforts to address structural impediments and foster sustainable development across all sectors. As Cambodia charts its course towards a more equitable and resilient future, the resolve to surmount these challenges must remain unwavering, guided by decisive and transformative leadership, good governance, and people-centered development approach. More investment in capacity building and institutional modernization at all levels and across sectors is imperative, moving forward.

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Why Cambodia Should Join BRICS

The emerging global landscape is transitioning towards a multiplex world, marked by the lack of a singular global hegemony, the complexity of multilevel governance, a diversity of civilizations and governance doctrines, and an expanding array of actors, including both state and non-state entities.

The ascension of the BRICS consortium—originally comprised of Brazil, Russia, India, China, and South Africa—signifies a pivotal shift in the balance of global power. This coalition of prominent developing nations is set to transform the geopolitical and geo-economic landscape, challenging the prevailing Western-centric order or the American hegemonic order.

Originally established as a mechanism to counter Western hegemony, BRICS embodies a shared vision to create a global environment that better represents their collective interests as well as those of other emerging economies. The interest in BRICS expansion is noteworthy, with over forty countries indicating a desire to join, reflecting its growing influence and appeal as a platform for more equitable international collaboration and representation.

Egypt, Ethiopia, Iran, Saudi Arabia and the United Arab Emirates (UAE) became the members of BRICS in January 2024. The expanded group has a combined population of about 3.5 billion, or 45 percent of the world's inhabitants. Combined, members' economies are worth more than \$28.5tn – about 28 percent of the global economy. BRICS countries produce about 44 percent of the world's crude oil.

The rise of BRICS underscores a global power transition, signaling the rising influence of developing countries. This new bloc represents the aspirations of the Global South. It is the main and the most comprehensive dialogue platform, which acts on behalf of emerging markets and developing countries. Under the chairmanship of Russia this year, BRICS aims to strengthen its role in the international financial system, develop cooperation between banks and expand the use of BRICS currencies, and promote collaboration between tax and customs authorities.

A key demonstration of BRICS' economic influence is the establishment of the New Development Bank (NDB) in 2015. Aimed at providing an alternative to Western-dominated financial institutions like the International Monetary Fund (IMF) and the World Bank, the NDB seeks to empower its members by facilitating lending in local currencies.

This strategy aims to reduce reliance on the dollar and challenge the financial hegemony of the West.

The NDB has been a partner to developing countries financing their development, logistical infrastructure, social projects focusing on inequalities, measures to address climate change, investing in clean energy, water and sanitation and preventing natural disasters. Its challenge is to secure the necessary volume of resources and for that the bank operates on two fronts: raising funds in different currencies and in local currencies, operations and in the other front expanding its capital basis, incorporating more emerging markets, and developing countries as new shareholders.

However, the path forward for BRICS is fraught with challenges. The coalition operates on a consensus-based model, requiring unanimity among its diverse membership. While united by a common goal to challenge Western hegemony, the individual interests and priorities of member states vary, posing a significant obstacle to achieving a cohesive alternative global order.

BRICS prioritizes cooperation centered around specific issues, rather than extensively focusing on the development and socialization of institutional frameworks and norms. The member countries lack a unified strategy or overarching vision, each grappling with their unique domestic challenges. The path towards internal institutionalization within BRICS necessitates the cultivation of trust and the establishment of tangible, practical cooperation among its members.

The inclusion of new members introduces additional complexities in reaching consensus, as each brings unique perspectives and interests. This diversity, while a strength, also complicates the process of forming a unified stance on various global issues. The question of how BRICS can align its members' varying agendas to forge a coherent strategy for an alternative world order remains open.

As BRICS navigates these challenges, it stands at a crucial juncture, seeking to define its role in an evolving global landscape. Achieving unity and a shared vision among its members is imperative for shaping the alternative world order they envision. In this era of shifting power dynamics, BRICS embodies the transformation of international relations, representing a move towards a more balanced and inclusive global governance structure.

Cambodia, positioned as an evolving nexus within the Mekong region, stands to gain significant advantages from the ascendancy of the BRICS countries, which are

central to the Global South's framework. At the Global South summit in January 2023, Indian Prime Minister Narendra Modi articulated the region's potential impact: "We, the Global South, hold the most substantial stakes in what the future holds. As the global governance model, established over eight decades ago, gradually evolves, it is imperative that we endeavor to influence the emerging world order."

Notably, the Global South represents 85 percent of the global population and accounts for nearly 39% of the world's GDP, making it a significant force in the global economy. Furthermore, trade among countries in the Global South is becoming a pivotal driver of worldwide economic growth. According to the United Nations Conference on Trade and Investment (UNCTAD), the value of South-South trade increased from \$600 billion in 1995 to \$5.3 trillion in 2021, surpassing the volume of North-South trade. This growth rate is outpacing the global average, underscoring the increasing importance of trade between developing countries. Moreover, South-South trade is encouraging the exchange of non-traditional exports, including goods with higher added value and those produced by technology-intensive manufacturing processes.

Cambodia has the potential to forge strategic economic networks with BRICS countries, capitalizing on its growing international integration and connectivity. By actively promoting South-South cooperation, Cambodia can foster the exchange of knowledge and best practices on peacebuilding and poverty reduction, the transfer of technology, and social innovation among countries of the Global South.

Utilizing its affiliations with the Association of Southeast Asian Nations (ASEAN) and the Regional Comprehensive Economic Partnership (RCEP), Cambodia is uniquely positioned to engage effectively with BRICS. Through participation in targeted dialogues and collaborative projects, Cambodia can promote inter-regional trade, boost investment opportunities, enhance tourism, and deepen development cooperation.

Embracing this proactive stance not only accelerates Cambodia's own developmental trajectory but also solidifies its stature on the global stage, aligning with the dynamic shift in global power dynamics favoring the Global South. This strategic alignment promises to elevate Cambodia's relevance and agency in shaping a future that acknowledges and leverages the collective strength of emerging economies and developing countries.

Lastly, BRICS plays a crucial role in enhancing Cambodia's ability to implement a robust hedging strategy by diversifying its strategic partnerships. This collaboration

strengthens Cambodia's agency and strategic autonomy, enabling it to adeptly maneuver through and navigate the complexities of an increasingly intricate geopolitical landscape.

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Navigating Cambodia's Path Amidst Economic Statecraft

In the current global landscape, economic statecraft is emerging as a dominant force, intertwined with the intricate geopolitics of supply chains. This practice, rooted in history since Greco-Roman times, involves leveraging economic prowess to advance foreign policy and national security objectives.

Recent events, notably the coordinated response of the Group of Seven (G7) and its allies to Russia's war in Ukraine, underscore the growing significance of economic statecraft. Through targeted sanctions and export controls, these nations aimed to freeze assets, reduce dependency, and degrade military capabilities—a strategy increasingly employed to address security threats.

In parallel, currency warfare has become a notable tactic, with the preeminence of the US dollar giving the US significant control over global financial systems. This has prompted adversaries to pursue anti-dollar strategies, evident in Russia's diversification away from the dollar and China's gradual internationalization of the yuan.

In order to uphold its technological dominance, the United States has implemented strategies aimed at safeguarding its technological edge, primarily by adopting a more assertive stance on export controls. For instance, the US has unveiled comprehensive export control measures designed to restrict China-based entities' access to cutting-edge semiconductors and related technologies crucial for manufacturing advanced microelectronics and supercomputers that rely on US technology.

These export controls represent just one facet of a multifaceted approach aimed at impeding China's efforts to develop its own advanced semiconductor technology capabilities. In addition to export controls, the US government has bolstered its oversight and regulatory authority over Chinese investments in critical US technology firms, offered subsidies to encourage the reshoring of semiconductor manufacturing, and stimulated further research and development investments in emerging technologies through initiatives like the CHIPS and Science Act. Moreover, new regulations have been implemented regarding outbound investments to China, particularly in activities involving advanced dual-use technologies.

China has strategically wielded economic statecraft to extend its geopolitical influence, enticing neighboring nations with deepened trade, investment, and financial

integration. Leveraging its burgeoning economic prowess, China has effectively employed various mechanisms of state control to steer its economy and economic agents towards objectives aligned with its national interests and overarching strategic agendas.

Through a concerted effort, China has intensified its sway over Southeast Asian countries, fostering deeper trade partnerships, facilitating substantial investment initiatives, and spearheading crucial infrastructure development projects, thereby solidifying its strategic leverage in the region.

For Cambodia, navigating this complex economic landscape requires strategic foresight and proactive measures, as its survival depends on the economic success and social progress. Moving forward, Cambodia should take the following measures.

First, actively seek to broaden its trade and investment relationships to reduce reliance on any single nation. Diversification not only mitigates risks posed by market volatility but also unlocks new avenues for growth.

Second, get access to larger markets and favorable trade terms which are essential for Cambodia's economic resilience. This necessitates diplomatic efforts to negotiate beneficial agreements and attract foreign investment.

Third, strengthening domestic industries, including manufacturing, agriculture, and services, is crucial for reducing import dependency and enhancing export competitiveness. Investment in innovation and skills development is key.

Fourth reduce reliance on the US dollar by promoting the use of its local currency, the Riel, and exploring alternative currencies such as the Yuan for international trade settlement. This mitigates vulnerability to fluctuations in the dollar-dominated financial system.

Fifth, actively engage in South-South cooperation. Collaboration with other developing nations can provide valuable insights and support in navigating geopolitical challenges and countering negative economic statecraft measures. By sharing knowledge and best practices, Cambodia can bolster its resilience in an increasingly competitive global arena.

Sixth, develop national economic security strategy by focusing on the promotion of economic base and competitiveness, the enhancement of national capacity to respond

to economic sanctions and coercion, the development of integrated and resilient supply chains, and the protection of critical infrastructure.

Seventh, invest in economic intelligence by collecting and analyzing risks associated with the resilience on supply chains, including energy security, industrial espionage, the physical and cyber security of critical infrastructure, the weaponization of economic dependencies or economic coercion.

Cambodia's ability to adapt and thrive amidst the shifting currents of economic statecraft hinges on strategic diversification, bolstering domestic capabilities, proactive engagement with international partners, developing national economic security strategy, and investing in economic intelligence capacity.

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Together Building a Community of Shared Future

The recent visit of Foreign Minister Wang Yi to Cambodia has not only underscored the enduring bond between the two nations but has also breathed new life into the vision of a community bound by a shared future. The ties between China and Cambodia have long been characterized as unbreakable ironclad friendship, rooted in mutual trust, mutual respect, and a commitment to tangible people-centered cooperation.

Cambodia, often hailed as China's closest friend in Southeast Asia, has stood shoulder to shoulder with China in championing the noble cause of forging a community with shared future. It's worth noting that Cambodia, along with Laos, stands as a pioneer among Southeast Asian nations in offering unwavering support to China's initiative on building a community of shared future for mankind in the new era.

In 2029, Cambodia and China signed a comprehensive action plan to build a Cambodia-China community of shared future, under which the two countries would undertake 31 measures in the fields of politics, security, economics, people-to-people relations, and multilateral cooperation.

In 2024, both sides signed a new action plan 2024-2028 covering a wide range of areas of cooperation to build a high-quality, high-level, and high-standard community with a shared future in the new era.

The Cambodia-China Intergovernmental Coordination Committee is the most important mechanism in coordinating bilateral efforts on practical cooperation in various fields. China has been consistently supporting Cambodia's development path that suits Cambodia's national conditions.

China's pivotal role in Cambodia's infrastructure development, particularly under the framework of the Belt and Road Initiative, stands as a shining example of mutually beneficial cooperation.

Both sides agreed to continue strengthening coordination and cooperation in international and regional affairs to safeguard the common interests of developing countries and promote regional peace, stability, development and prosperity. They also work closely and timely coordinate positions on major regional and international issues.

Cambodia firmly adheres to one-China policy. Taiwan is an inalienable part of China's territory as well as China's internal affairs. Cambodia will not develop any form of official relations with Taiwan.

When it comes to the Ream naval base, it's crucial to dispel any notions of military expansionism or strategic encroachment. Both China and Cambodia have consistently stated that the establishment of a naval base is neither on the agenda nor in the interests of either party. Instead, the focus lies squarely on enhancing Cambodia's defense capabilities and bolstering maritime security.

For Cambodia, the modernization of its defense infrastructure is paramount, driven by a desire to safeguard its sovereignty and territorial integrity. Any activities at Ream are centered around capacity-building efforts aimed at strengthening Cambodia's ability to respond to security challenges in its maritime domain. This includes training programs, joint exercises, and the development of necessary infrastructure to support maritime operations.

Turning to the Techo Funan Canal project, it's essential to recognize its purely commercial nature and the manifold benefits it brings to Cambodia. By creating a more efficient and cost-effective transportation route, the canal aims to reduce logistical burdens, stimulate local economies along its path, and enhance connectivity between localities.

Down the road, Cambodia and China need to stress the following approaches in their cooperation.

First, nurturing trust-based cooperation. Trust forms the bedrock of any successful partnership. Cambodia and China must continue to cultivate mutual trust through transparent communication, consistent engagement, and the fulfillment of commitments.

Trust entails honoring agreements, respecting each other's sovereignty, and addressing concerns in a constructive manner. By building a relationship grounded in trust, both nations can navigate challenges with confidence and work towards shared objectives.

Second, strengthening people-centered cooperation approach. At the heart of Cambodia-China cooperation lies the well-being and prosperity of their people. Both nations should prioritize initiatives that directly benefit the citizens of both countries, focusing on areas such as education, healthcare, poverty alleviation, and social development.

By investing in human capital and improving livelihoods, Cambodia and China can create a solid foundation for long-term cooperation built on the aspirations and aspirations of their people. This entails empowering communities, fostering cultural exchanges, and ensuring that development efforts are inclusive and equitable.

Third, promoting innovation-driven cooperation. In an increasingly interconnected and dynamic world, innovation serves as a catalyst for progress. Cambodia and China should leverage their respective strengths in technology, research, and entrepreneurship to drive innovation-led growth. This involves investing in research and development, supporting startups and SMEs, and fostering collaboration in emerging industries such as artificial intelligence, green technology, and digital infrastructure.

By embracing innovation, both nations can unlock new opportunities for economic diversification, job creation, and sustainable development, ensuring their competitiveness in the global arena.

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The Survival of Small States

In the labyrinth of global geopolitics, small states often find themselves navigating treacherous, uncharted waters.

Indeed, we stand at a critical juncture in history, often described as the most dangerous period since the end of World War II. The global landscape is witnessing a surge in proxy conflicts amidst strategic competition.

Against the backdrop of intensifying major power competitions and the emergence of non-traditional security challenges like climate change and pandemics, the imperative of small states' survival has never been more pressing.

In an increasingly anarchic international system that deviates from the mythos of a rules-based international order, the statecraft of small states becomes paramount. How can small states exercise their agency to maintain their independence, strategic autonomy and realize their core national interests?

The strategic posture of small states can be categorized into balancing, band wagoning, or hedging. Among these, hedging emerges as a nuanced strategy, frequently employed by small states to negotiate the delicate balance between aligning with dominant powers and maintaining autonomy.

Non-formal, issue-focused coalitions serve as facilitators for hedging, enabling small states to navigate between the polarities of balancing and band wagoning. Hedging is easier said than done- it requires agile foreign policy strategy, strategic credibility, and smart diplomatic leadership.

Within the context of rising fluidity, complexity, volatility and multiplicity of the international system, some small states have forged ad hoc informal security alliances to bolster their survival in an anarchic world. These alliances serve as tools for small states to expand their regional influence beyond their inherent capabilities. However, the effectiveness of such alliance's hinges on the convergence of interests between the small state and the dominant actor.

One notable approach is exemplified by the concept of "engaged neutrality," embraced by certain small states. This doctrine advocates for active participation in international security policy and peace operations while retaining the option to abstain

when necessary. Modern neutrality, thus, does not preclude cooperation with alliance members or alliances as long as key issues align

Cambodia stands as a compelling case study in small state security, employing a hedging and diversification strategy to maintain its neutrality and strategic autonomy, while enhancing its agency.

By pursuing cooperative security through formal agreements and norms socialization via multilateral institutions especially ASEAN-led mechanisms, Cambodia seeks stability, predictability, and security guarantees. This is based on a firm belief that diplomacy, dialogue and cooperation are the only way towards peace and prosperity.

Furthermore, Cambodia is striving to build a prosperous and resilient nation through institutional modernization, human capital development, and smart diplomacy. Cambodia's smart diplomacy is anchored on three pillars, namely economic diplomacy, cultural diplomacy, and peace diplomacy.

Economic diplomacy forms the bedrock of Cambodia's diplomatic endeavors. Through economic diplomacy, Cambodia seeks to attract foreign investment, promote trade, and enhance economic integration with regional and international partners. By engaging in bilateral and multilateral trade agreements, Cambodia not only expands its economic opportunities but also strengthens its diplomatic relations with key stakeholders.

Cambodia's rich cultural heritage and traditions serve as powerful tools in its diplomatic arsenal. Through cultural diplomacy, Cambodia showcases its unique identity, history, arts, and traditions to foster mutual understanding, respect, and goodwill among nations. By celebrating its cultural heritage, Cambodia creates opportunities for dialogue, collaboration, and cooperation across borders, thereby fostering lasting friendships and partnerships.

In a world fraught with conflicts and instability, Cambodia plays an active role in promoting international peace and security through peace diplomacy. Through participation in peacekeeping operations, mediation efforts, and confidence-building measures, Cambodia contributes to global peace and stability while upholding its commitment the objectives and principles of the United Nations.

Cambodia firmly adheres to the promotion of open and inclusive multilateralism, cooperative security, along with a commitment to a rules-based international order, as these principles are indispensable to the survival of small states.

In the Asia Pacific region, ASEAN-led regional security architecture such as the East Asia Summit, ASEAN Defense Ministers Meeting Plus, and the ASEAN Regional Forum provide essential platforms for dialogue, confidence building, while strengthening preventive diplomacy and crisis management mechanisms.

Economic security refers to a nation's economic stability and prosperity which are integral to its overall national security. When a country's economy is strong and resilient, it is better equipped to address various internal and external challenges, thus safeguarding its core national interests.

The construction of the Funan Techo Canal is seen as a strategic investment in the country's economic security. It aims to boost transport connectivity, foster industrial and economic development, improve irrigation systems, and enhance resilience to natural disasters, all of which contribute to Cambodia's ability to pursue its development goals and safeguard its national security.

Economic security involves the promotion of social protection and people's wellbeing, the development of secure digital infrastructure and resilient supply chains, diversification of growth sources and a shift towards knowledge-based, innovation-driven economies.

Small neutral and independent states, like Cambodia, must be proactive and engaged on the regional and global stages, leveraging multilateralism, diplomacy, and global partnerships. Thriving on institutional opportunity structures, such as chairing meetings and engaging in international agenda setting, enhances their security and relevancy.

The survival of small states in an anarchic world demands adept navigation through uncharted, dangerous waters. From hedging to engaged neutrality and proactive diplomacy, small states must employ multifaceted and omnidirectional engagement approaches to safeguard their core national interests.

By embracing open multilateralism, strengthening economic security and economic resilience, and prioritizing people-centered defense modernization, small states can fortify their positions amidst increasingly complex and volatile international system.

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Cambodia's Evolving Defense Diplomacy

Cambodia and China are holding their 15-day Golden Dragon 2024 exercises, showcasing a collaborative effort under the banner of “joint counter-terrorism operations and humanitarian relief.”

The naval exercise have just concluded and the one involving the army will finish tomorrow. These exercises involve participation of over 2,000 troops from both nations, with China contributing more than 500 vessels, armored vehicles, and weapons. This demonstrates strong military ties between the two countries based on the principles of mutual respect, mutual understanding, mutual trust, and mutual interest for peace and prosperity.

The US Secretary of Defense Lloyd Austin is scheduled to visit Cambodia in early June following the Shangri-La Dialogue in Singapore. This visit aims to restore strategic trust and promote mutual understanding and cooperation between the defense establishments of the two countries. Both countries used to carry out joint military exercises called Angkor Sentinel before it was postponed in 2017.

These events collectively underscore Cambodia's independent and flexible defense diplomacy, reflecting its ability to build relationships with these competing major powers.

Cambodia's door is always open to the US. The upcoming exchange between the two defense chiefs presents an essential opportunity to address and potentially clear doubts regarding the Ream Naval Base. The US has accused Cambodia of hosting a Chinese naval base at Ream, a claim that Cambodia has consistently and persistently rejected. Despite Cambodia's firm denials, the US remains unconvinced, casting a long, wide shadow over the bilateral relationship.

To foster a constructive dialogue, the US must clarify its intentions and interests in engaging with Cambodia. It is crucial for the US to approach Cambodia as an independent sovereign nation, rather than viewing it through the narrow lens of its containment strategy against China. This shift in perspective is necessary to build mutual trust and respect between the two nations.

Cambodia is not a vassal state of any major powers. Cambodia is pro-Cambodia.

Cambodia's commitment to independence and sovereignty is deeply rooted in its national history and identity. The country has repeatedly emphasized that it does not need to be instructed by other nations on how to maintain its independence. This stance underscores Cambodia's desire to be recognized and respected as a sovereign entity capable of making its own decisions regarding its security and foreign relations.

Cambodia's defense diplomacy is characterized by its commitment to building strong and friendly ties with defense establishments worldwide, especially immediate neighbours. It actively engages in extensive interactions and cooperation with other armed forces, upholding international rules and norms, and emphasizing respect for sovereignty and the rule of law. By establishing a robust network of bilateral relationships, Cambodia fosters understanding, confidence, and practical cooperation to address common security challenges.

Central to Cambodia's diplomatic strategy is its advocacy for an open, inclusive, and flexible regional security framework that encourages constructive dialogue and practical cooperation among stakeholders. This is evident in its active participation in the ASEAN Defense Ministers' Meeting (ADMM), where it contributes to shaping regional security architecture.

Cambodia is a staunch advocate for an ASEAN-led or ASEAN-centric regional security order. This commitment reflects Cambodia's belief in the importance of ASEAN's central role in maintaining stability and fostering cooperation in Southeast Asia. However, the emergence of minilateral arrangements such as AUKUS and the QUAD is perceived as a challenge to ASEAN centrality, potentially undermining its influence in shaping regional security dynamics.

These minilateral initiatives, while aimed at addressing specific strategic concerns, risk marginalizing ASEAN by diverting attention and resources away from the inclusive, multilateral frameworks that ASEAN embodies. Cambodia, along with other ASEAN member states, emphasizes the need for a cohesive and united regional approach, one that prioritizes dialogue, mutual respect, and cooperative security.

Small states like Cambodia often grapple with recurring themes of vulnerability in the realm of security. Understanding the historical and conceptual aspects of "smallness" helps address these security concerns. Cambodia's unique circumstances necessitate strategic thinking, diplomatic agility, and active engagement with the international community.

Despite limited resources, this initial disadvantage can often be circumvented, reduced, and turned into a strategic advantage through reliance on collective solidarity, adherence to the rule of law, a strict focus on limited objectives, and the adoption of creative solutions.

The keen sense of vulnerability that is considered a quintessential Cambodian trait compels defense planners to constantly seek new approaches and opportunities to improve – often with a broader global and regional perspective in mind. This acute awareness of constraints in terms of size and resources can be a driver for innovation in defense planning. Cambodia's ability to navigate these challenges demonstrates its strategic acumen and resilience.

Peace and security are not certainties, particularly when Cambodia's vulnerabilities are intertwined with its acute sensitivities to global shocks and the ongoing global power transitions. However, this does not render a small state like Cambodia helpless against the tide of global change. In the realm of defense diplomacy and collective action, there are ample opportunities for the development of strategies and responses that secure the peace and security of the nation.

Cambodia's approach exemplifies how small states can leverage their unique positions to foster stability and security. By balancing relationships with major powers and participating actively in regional forums, Cambodia ensures its voice is heard and its interests are protected. As global dynamics continue to evolve, Cambodia's strategic navigation in defense diplomacy serves as a model for other small states seeking to enhance their security and international role.

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In Search of Total Diplomacy

Diplomacy is not just the domain of professional negotiators and state officials; it is a multi-layered art form that encompasses all levels of society. At its heart, diplomacy is about a government's strategy in managing international affairs, aligning with the interests of its people, and garnering public support.

State diplomacy remains the cornerstone. As the principal actor in international relations, the state negotiates, manages relationships, and resolves conflicts between nations. With the world becoming more interconnected and global challenges increasingly complex, effective state diplomacy is crucial. It's about building relationships and partnerships, finding common ground, and ensuring peace and prosperity for all nations.

Beyond the state level, parliamentary diplomacy plays a vital role in enhancing international cooperation. Through this, parliamentarians from different countries collaborate to increase mutual understanding, improve government accountability, and boost the democratic legitimacy of intergovernmental institutions. This form of diplomacy is about building bridges and adding a parliamentary perspective to global governance, aiming to promote peace across borders.

Party diplomacy, though less formal, is equally significant. Inspired by the notion that "politics stops at the water's edge," it demands that political parties build consensus on foreign policy issues, enabling the country to present a unified front. This approach fosters strategic political trust between parties from different nations, contributing to international peace and stability.

Then there's military diplomacy, which uses defense resources and military networks to achieve foreign policy objectives peacefully. This strategy aims to co-formulate and implement security policies while establishing stable, long-term international relations in the field of defense.

Military-to-military dialogues and interactions play an increasingly vital role in preventing miscalculation and promoting interoperability between the militaries, while fostering cultural exchange and understanding and offering an opportunity to expand each nation's capabilities.

Lastly, people diplomacy represents the grassroots level of international engagement. This can be a top-down approach, where government-initiated programs

involve citizens pursuing foreign policy objectives. Alternatively, it can be a bottom-up approach, where non-state actors independently develop initiatives without direct alignment with their home country's foreign policy. This form of diplomacy is about promoting mutual understanding and trust among citizens and civil society groups from different nations.

Hence diplomacy in the modern era is a comprehensive, multi-dimensional endeavor. It requires collaboration at all levels—from state to citizen—to foster a more peaceful, secure, and prosperous world. Each form of diplomacy contributes uniquely to this goal, demonstrating that diplomacy is not just the art of negotiation but the practice of building a better world together.

As Cambodia navigates an increasingly complex geopolitical and geoeconomic landscape, enhancing national capacity to implement a holistic “total diplomacy” approach has become imperative.

This strategy integrates various diplomatic forms to bolster Cambodia's standing on the international stage.

Under the leadership of Samdech Hun Manet, Prime Minister, Cambodia has taken significant strides in economic diplomacy. His proactive engagement, through numerous overseas trips and hosting foreign dignitaries from both public and private sectors, underscores a commitment to strengthening Cambodia's economic ties globally.

The Cambodian People's Party (CPP) has been proactively involved in fostering dialogues and consultations with other political parties at both bilateral and multilateral levels. This active engagement plays a pivotal role in establishing confidence-building measures and advancing preventive diplomacy, in some cases promoting crisis management.

Parliamentary diplomacy, too, has seen a surge in activity and focus. Samdech Khuon Sudary, the President of the National Assembly, has been pivotal in this regard, championing initiatives that promote good neighborliness and address critical global issues such as peace, gender equality and sustainable development.

The election of former Prime Minister Samdech Hun Sen as the President of the Senate in April represents a significant milestone in the evolution of Cambodia's parliamentary diplomacy.

Renowned as the architect of the nation's foreign policy, Samdech Hun Sen brings a wealth of experience that will further refine and enhance Cambodia's strategic position in the region.

Samdech Hun Sen is positioning Cambodia as a 'bridging' and 'responsible' actor within the Mekong region. His diligent engagement efforts with Myanmar's leaders aim to cultivate political dialogue and reconciliation amid the country's protracted crisis, with the aspiration of restoring peace and stability not only in Myanmar but across the entire Mekong region.

Additionally, Hun Sen has been a strong proponent of the ambitious Funan Techo Canal mega-project, expected to significantly bolster Cambodia's economy, economic security, and independence. This project exemplifies the strategic utilization of an underexploited waterway to link regional economies, open new avenues for investment, and facilitate international trade, thereby enhancing Cambodia's role as a key player in regional connectivity and development.

In the realm of military diplomacy, the release of the Defense White Paper in 2022 underlines cooperative security, capability development, and international collaboration to tackle non-traditional security threats. This marks a significant advancement in aligning Cambodia's defense strategy with broader regional and international security norms.

Cambodia's evolving defense strategy is characterized by a focus on enhancing small state security through a multifaceted approach. This approach includes cooperative security, robust international cooperation, and comprehensive people-centered defense modernization.

Despite notable progress, Cambodia's people diplomacy encounters significant challenges, largely due to limited resources. Both government-led initiatives and grassroots, bottom-up efforts, including Track-Two diplomacy, have not kept pace with the fast-changing international development.

There is a critical need to invest in the think tank community so that Cambodia can better articulate and share its narrative globally, thereby reinforcing its strategic objectives and strengthening its position on the international stage.

Moving forward, it is crucial for Cambodia to develop an integrated approach to total diplomacy. By leveraging all forms of diplomacy—state, parliamentary, party, military, and people—Cambodia can more effectively advance its core national interests

and agency. This integrated approach will help Cambodia navigate complex geopolitical and geoeconomic landscapes as well as secure a prosperous and stable future for the Kingdom. Building strategic foresight and diplomatic capacity on all fronts is a must.

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Promoting Social Innovation for Inclusive Growth

Social innovation is the development of novel solutions to address social needs and issues. This concept, though broad, fundamentally revolves around improving the situation for underprivileged groups in society, making it an essential tool for fostering social cohesion and tackling societal challenges.

At its core, social innovation is a process where various actors come together to develop new ideas, strategies and organizations to meet social needs or solve social problems while enhancing capabilities, relationships, and better use of assets and resources.

Social innovation promotes sustainable and inclusive growth. By empowering local communities through knowledge co-creation and developing solutions, social innovation fosters a more equitable society. However, it is crucial to acknowledge that social innovation is never neutral; it is always political and socially constructed.

The actors and areas concerned with social innovation typically include individuals, networks, and organizations across all societal sectors: public, private, civil society, and academic. The emphasis on different sectors may vary, but the overarching goal is the same – to improve societal well-being.

One of the keys to successful social innovation is the participation of local communities in developing realistic, holistic solutions. Local issues often require local solutions, and involving the community ensures that the solutions are tailored to specific needs and contexts.

Furthermore, cooperation across sectors is fundamental in identifying and addressing social needs and societal challenges. Social innovation processes should ideally be carried out with people.

This approach is exemplified by “user-driven innovation,” where intended customers actively improve the innovation processes.

Innovation is inherently about challenging norms and finding solutions that lead to new and better social structures and relations. Leadership, governance, and ownership at the local or community level are critical for the success of social innovation initiatives.

These elements help increase the agency and reflective skills among actors in all sectors, enabling them to initiate improvements for individuals, organizations, and society, regardless of their sectorial affiliation.

As stakeholders with different goals, aims, and modes of conduct converge around the same concept, new synergies and solutions to various issues emerge. This convergence is where the true power of social innovation lies. It is useful in identifying the different levels of change and assessing the depth of these changes. Social innovations are not just about introducing new products or services; they are about transforming the way society operates and interacts.

The social aspects of innovations are often seen as accompanying and/or complementary processes alongside technological and economic innovations. They act as ‘enablers,’ facilitating the broader adoption and impact of these innovations. By integrating social innovation into technological and economic advancements, we can ensure that the benefits of innovation are more widely and equitably distributed.

Social innovation is a relatively new concept in Cambodia, both in public policy and academic discourses. Recognizing its potential, it is crucial for the Cambodian government and other development partners to develop a comprehensive policy framework and related legal framework on social innovation to ensure its effective implementation with active participation from all stakeholders.

Social Innovation also aligns with the Pentagonal Strategy Phase One with the emphasis on the approach of Dynamics of Stakeholder System by enhancing synergy, capability, coordination, responsibility, and participation from all stakeholders.

By fostering cooperation across various sectors and embracing user-driven innovation, we can challenge existing norms and establish new social structures and relationships that benefit society.

Leadership and governance at the local level play a pivotal role in this process. They enhance the agency and reflective skills of actors across all sectors, empowering them to initiate improvements for individuals, organizations, and society.

As stakeholders with diverse goals and modes of conduct converge around the concept of social innovation, new synergies and solutions to various issues emerge. This convergence enhances society’s capacity to act, promoting a more equitable and sustainable future.

To harness the full potential of social innovation, it is essential to encourage collaboration between government entities, non-governmental organizations, private sector partners, and communities. By doing so, we can create an environment where innovative ideas are nurtured, tested, and scaled. This collaborative approach not only addresses immediate social challenges but also fosters a culture of continuous improvement and adaptability.

The integration of social innovation into development strategy requires a multi-faceted approach that includes policy development, local leadership, and cross-sector collaboration. Through these efforts, we can unlock new possibilities for social progress, ultimately leading to a more inclusive and resilient society.

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Cambodia-Thailand Relationship at an All-Time High

The Cambodia-Thailand relationship is at an all-time high, marked by the strategic partnership agreement reached in February this year. This significant development has ushered in a new era of cooperation, reaffirming the shared commitment to fostering good neighborly relations and reinforcing our traditional friendly ties.

Next year will mark the 75th anniversary of formal diplomatic relations between the two nations. Since December 19, 1950, the relationship has been anchored in mutual respect, understanding, trust, and benefit. The enhancements in our relations, particularly since 2011, highlight the strength and depth of the partnership.

Our bilateral relationship is founded on a bedrock of political trust and comprehensive cooperation that spans various domains, from economic collaboration to people-to-people exchanges. This robust partnership is guided by the principles of mutual respect, mutual understanding, and mutual interest, ensuring that both nations benefit equally from our close ties.

In 2023, bilateral trade reached \$9 billion, with a target of \$15 billion by 2025. Thai exports to Cambodia include refined fuels, beverages, livestock, and vehicles, while Cambodian exports feature precious stones, fruits, vegetables, and metal products.

Thailand's investment in Cambodia, amounting to approximately \$1.6 billion, places it among the top ten foreign investors in the country. Additionally, Thailand remains a significant source of tourists to Cambodia, with over 1.8 million Thai tourists visiting last year. These economic and cultural exchanges are vital to our bilateral relationship.

To further deepen this relationship, Thai Foreign Minister Maris Sangiampongsa will pay an official visit to Cambodia today. This visit is expected to enhance diplomatic and economic cooperation, paving the way for new initiatives and agreements that will strengthen bilateral ties.

In addition, President of the National Assembly Khuon Sudary will visit Thailand on July 11-12. This visit aims to bolster parliamentary cooperation between the two nations, providing a platform for legislative exchange and collaboration on mutual interests.

These upcoming high-level visits underscore the importance of our people-centered strategic partnership, delivering more concrete outcomes for the two peoples.

Educational and cultural exchanges have also seen remarkable progress. Thailand's generous scholarships to Cambodian students and academics have greatly enhanced people-to-people relations.

Moreover, our cooperation in the labor sector is thriving, with more than one million Cambodian workers currently employed in Thailand.

The launch of the KHQR cross-border payment system by the National Bank of Cambodia (NBC) is another noteworthy development. This initiative promotes local currency usage and facilitates seamless tourism and trade between our two nations, marking an important step forward in our economic cooperation.

Cambodia places great importance on its regional relationships and connectivity, and its strategic location at the heart of the Southern Economic Corridor (SEC) within the Greater Mekong Subregion (GMS) underscores our pivotal role. This corridor connects Cambodia with Thailand, Vietnam, and Laos, facilitating robust economic interactions.

Prime Minister Hun Manet's recent call for Thai investors to explore untapped sectors in Cambodia—tourism, the digital economy, infrastructure development, and agriculture—highlights the vast potential for further economic collaboration.

This call, made during the Cambodia-Thailand Business Forum in Bangkok, emphasizes the strategic advantages of leveraging established trade facilitation and connectivity mechanisms like the GMS and the Ayeyawady-Chao Phraya-Mekong Economic Cooperation Strategy (ACMECS).

Cambodia is positioning itself as the bridging state of the Mekong, serving as both a cultural and economic gateway to the subregion. This strategic vision aims to leverage Cambodia's geographical and cultural assets to foster greater regional connectivity and integration.

One of the most significant projects embodying this ambition is the development of the Techo Funan Canal. This canal is more than just an infrastructure project; it symbolizes Cambodia's aspirations to enhance trade, transportation, and tourism within the Mekong subregion. By providing a direct waterway link, the Techo Funan Canal will facilitate the movement of goods and people, reducing transportation costs and time, and thereby boosting economic activity in the region.

For Thai investors, the Techo Funan Canal presents investment opportunities along the canal including logistics, real estate, tourism, and industrial parks. The canal's development is expected to spur the growth of new economic zones and commercial hubs, making it an attractive proposition for businesses looking to capitalize on the increased connectivity.

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Cambodia and the Global South

As Cambodia navigates an increasingly complex and volatile geopolitical and geo-economic landscape, understanding its place in the world is essential for its survival and continued growth.

Pursuing an independent foreign policy with strategic autonomy and agency, Cambodia has adeptly implemented a “hedging strategy” through robust strategic and economic diversification, promoting open and inclusive multilateralism, and advocating for a rules-based international order.

In the Asia-Pacific region, Cambodia holds a strong conviction in an ASEAN-led regional order or architecture. ASEAN is regarded as a shield that protects and promotes Cambodia’s core national interests, including the protection of sovereignty and territorial integrity, enhancing economic security, and promoting cultural identity.

ASEAN-led extended regional mechanisms such as the East Asia Summit, ASEAN Regional Forum, and ASEAN Defence Ministers’ Meeting Plus provide a platform for Cambodia to engage major powers in multilateral diplomacy, ensuring that its voice is heard in regional discussions and that its interests are safeguarded against external pressures and foreign interference.

In the intricate and often zero-sum game of international politics, small states like Cambodia face a stark reality: if they are not at the table, they will be on the menu. This adage underscores the critical importance for Cambodia to actively engage in global and regional affairs to safeguard its interests and assert its sovereignty.

ASEAN’s significance to Cambodia cannot be overstated. As a member, Cambodia benefits from inclusive cooperative security arrangements and economic integration initiatives that bolster its national resilience, while strengthening its agency and strategic autonomy. ASEAN’s principle of non-interference and consensus-based decision-making aligns with Cambodia’s desire to maintain sovereignty while engaging in regional cooperation.

Being part of the ASEAN-driven Regional Comprehensive Economic Partnership (RCEP) indeed provides Cambodia with significant economic space to maneuver. RCEP is a mega trade agreement involving 15 countries, including ASEAN nations and key partners like China, Japan, South Korea, Australia, and New Zealand.

Cambodia's sense of belonging to the Global South is another crucial aspect of its foreign policy. The term "Global South" refers to a group of developing countries that share common challenges and aspirations. For Cambodia, this identity is tied to a history of colonialism and a shared desire for a more inclusive, fair, and just international system.

The Global South provides a platform for Cambodia to advocate for the rights and interests of developing nations, ensuring that their voices are heard in global forums.

Cambodia's interest in joining the BRICS+ bloc, alongside its neighbors Thailand and Vietnam, underscores its commitment to the Global South. BRICS+, which includes Brazil, Russia, India, China, South Africa, and newly admitted members like Egypt, Ethiopia, Iran, and the UAE, represents the core of the Global South. This grouping seeks to provide an alternative to Western-dominated international institutions, promoting a multipolar world order where the interests of developing countries are more equitably represented.

Like other developing countries, Cambodia aspires to see a more inclusive, fair and just international system. This vision includes ensuring that the voices of developing countries are heard and their interests protected. Cambodia's participation in global forums, its advocacy for multilateralism, and its commitment to world peace and justice all reflect a commitment to this vision.

The Global South is increasingly asserting its influence on the global stage, marked by significant developments such as China's rise to the world's largest economy, the expansion of the BRICS+ grouping, and a resurgence of left-wing governments in Latin America challenging U.S. hegemony. This shift signifies the emergence of a new multipolar world order or a multiplex world, the exact contours of which are still unfolding.

The term "Global South" originated as an organizing principle rather than a rigid grouping of nations. Its roots trace back to the 1955 Bandung Conference in Indonesia, where newly independent nations sought to forge a collective identity and advocate for their interests against the backdrop of a skewed global order.

This movement, proudly termed the Third World, stood apart from the U.S.-aligned West (First World) and the Soviet-aligned Eastern Bloc (Second World). Over the decades, this coalition of African, Asian, Latin American, and Caribbean nations, under banners like the Non-Aligned Movement (NAM) and the Group of 77 (G77), waged struggles against colonialism and neocolonialism.

One of the movement's most significant achievements came on May 1, 1974, when Third World countries, supported by Second World allies and empowered by oil-exporting nations, passed the Declaration and Program of Action on the Establishment of a New International Economic Order (NIEO) at the United Nations General Assembly. This initiative aimed to redress the unfair global economic system and promote development through collective action.

In recent years, the divide between the Global North and South has reemerged prominently on the international stage. In December 2022, the UN General Assembly adopted a resolution calling for a revival of the NIEO, mirroring historical divides between North and South. This renewed focus reflects persistent grievances over the inequities of the global order. Leaders from the Global South, such as Ghana's President Nana Akufo-Addo and Brazil's President Luiz Inácio Lula da Silva, have voiced concerns about the disproportionate impacts of global issues like climate change and economic inequality on their nations.

Despite the shared rhetoric, the Global South is not a monolithic entity. Economic and political fortunes vary significantly among its members. For instance, countries like India and Brazil have gained substantial influence, while others remain economically marginalized. This diversity challenges the notion of a unified Global South and highlights internal dynamics similar to the North-South divide within the grouping itself.

For policymakers in the Global North, understanding the historical and contemporary grievances of the Global South is crucial. Ignoring these perspectives risks perpetuating a hostile dynamic and undermining the legitimacy of the Western-led global order. Moreover, addressing the demands of the Global South could be strategically beneficial in countering the influence of China and Russia. This might involve ceding some control over international institutions and treating Global South countries as equal partners.

The resurgence of the Global South underscores a longstanding desire for a more equitable global order. Recognizing the diversity within this grouping is essential for fostering nuanced and respectful discourse across the North-South divide. The core of the Global South's identity lies in its collective struggle against a global political economy that perpetuates inequality and hierarchy, advocating for a realignment that supports self-determination and equality.

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Cambodia-Vietnam Relationship: A Resilient Partnership

In an era marked by shifting geopolitical dynamics and regional complexities, the relationship between Cambodia and Vietnam has proven to be resilient and flourishing.

Despite occasional disagreements and tensions, particularly with regard to the differences over the Techo Funan Canal, the ties between these two neighboring countries have endured and evolved significantly since the establishment of official diplomatic relations on June 24, 1967.

Mutual understanding between the two countries regarding the canal project have been improved through effective information sharing. Transparency and open communication are critical in fostering trust and building confidence.

Vietnam stands to explore and benefit from numerous economic opportunities associated with the canal project given the provinces along the canal's route are geographically proximate to Vietnam, offering potential advantages in trade, logistics, and economic cooperation.

Notably, over the past 57 years, Cambodia and Vietnam have not only navigated through numerous challenges at the national and international levels but have also deepened their cooperation across a multitude of sectors, from politics and security to economy, culture, education, and beyond.

The foundation of the Cambodia-Vietnam relationship is built on a shared history and mutual interests, underpinned by a commitment to principles such as multilateralism and adherence to the United Nations Charter.

This robust bilateral relationship is encapsulated in the slogan “Good neighborliness, traditional friendship, comprehensive and long-term sustainable cooperation.” This guiding principle reflects the strategic importance both countries place on each other within their foreign policies. Cambodia, while pursuing an independent foreign policy, consistently prioritizes immediate neighbors in its diplomatic agenda.

The institutional framework supporting Cambodia-Vietnam relations is extensive and well-structured. Vietnam maintains consulates general in Battambang and Sihanouk provinces, facilitating diplomatic and consular activities.

In November 2000, a landmark joint statement between the two nations outlined key principles for their bilateral relations, focusing on defense, security, economic trade, education, culture, and health sectors. This statement underscored the commitment to friendly cultural exchanges, sports cooperation, and mutual assistance across various levels of government and civil society.

Recent high-level engagements, such as the 20th Joint Committee Meeting on March 21, 2023, have further solidified this relationship. Key agreements from this meeting include increasing the frequency of Joint Task Force meetings and exploring the establishment of a Phnom Penh – Bavet – Moc Bai – Ho Chi Minh City rail link.

The groundbreaking of the Phnom Penh-Bavet expressway project on June 7, 2023, with expected completion in 2027, marks a significant milestone in infrastructure connectivity between the two nations.

Economic cooperation between Cambodia and Vietnam has seen remarkable progress since the Vietnam-Cambodia Economic and Trade Agreement in 1998. The bilateral trade turnover is ambitiously targeted to reach US\$20 billion in the near future.

Vietnam is a major investor in Cambodia, with 205 projects totaling \$2.94 billion in registered capital, making it the leading ASEAN investor and one of the top five foreign direct investors in Cambodia. This investment influx has contributed significantly to Cambodia's economic development, raising incomes, promoting infrastructure development, and creating employment opportunities for Cambodian workers.

The relationship between Cambodia and Vietnam is further strengthened through their active participation in regional and subregional cooperation mechanisms such as ASEAN and Mekong-related cooperation frameworks.

The Cambodia-Laos-Vietnam Development Triangle (CLV-DTA) is a prime example of their collaborative efforts. At the 13th Meeting of the Joint Coordination Committee on CLV-DTA, significant strides were made towards concluding the draft Master Plan for Socio-Economic Development up to 2030, which is slated for review and adoption at the 12th CLV-DTA Summit in Cambodia in late 2024.

Building on their strong political ties, Cambodia and Vietnam are poised to continue enhancing their bilateral cooperation. Both countries are committed to a shared vision of national development, with Cambodia aiming to become a developed nation by 2050 and Vietnam by 2045. This ambitious vision underscores the importance of their partnership in achieving sustainable development and prosperity for their peoples.

The Cambodia-Vietnam relationship exemplifies a resilient and dynamic partnership that has withstood the test of time. Through strategic cooperation, mutual respect, and a shared commitment to peace and development, both countries are well-positioned to navigate future challenges and seize opportunities for mutual benefit.

As they look towards the future, the bonds between Cambodia and Vietnam will undoubtedly continue to strengthen, fostering peace, stability, and prosperity in the region. Attempts by hostile forces to undermine the friendship between the two countries are destined to fail.

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Cambodia-Japan, A heart-to-heart relationship

The relationship between Cambodia and Japan exemplifies a genuine heart-to-heart connection, defined by mutual respect, trust, and a shared vision and interests.

Marking the 70th anniversary of their formal diplomatic ties last year, both countries elevated their relationship to a 'comprehensive strategic partnership'. This underscores the deep trust and comprehensive cooperation between the two nations.

The recent official visit of Japanese Foreign Minister Yoko Kamikawa to Cambodia demonstrated the robust political will and concrete efforts to achieve tangible outcomes from this partnership.

Japan's emphasis on social infrastructure development, such as water treatment and supply in Phnom Penh, highlights its commitment to improving the quality of life in Cambodia. Moreover, Japan's interest in deepening cooperation in digital transformation, cybersecurity, maritime security, and humanitarian demining efforts signifies a forward-looking and multifaceted partnership.

Japan has been instrumental in Cambodia's journey towards peace and development. It has played a critical role in peacemaking, peacekeeping, peacebuilding, and national reconstruction.

Japan is undeniably Cambodia's most trustworthy friend. The Cambodian people hold a deep affection for Japan, reflecting a truly heart-to-heart relationship. Despite the ever-changing geopolitical landscape, our trust-based and people-centered bilateral partnership remains strong and resilient.

Both countries have worked closely together to navigate international geopolitical turbulence and to strengthen open and inclusive multilateralism and a rules-based international order.

Cambodia was the first Southeast Asian country to support Japan's Free and Open Indo-Pacific initiative, recognizing its inclusivity and complementarity with ASEAN-led regional initiatives.

Notably, Cambodia welcomes all regional and international efforts that contribute to peace and prosperity without targeting any third country, thereby strengthening the ASEAN-led regional architecture.

Our economic ties are also flourishing, with bilateral trade volume reaching \$1.8 billion in 2023. Cambodian exports to Japan totaled \$1.17 billion, marking a 2% increase. Japan is our fifth-largest trading partner.

Japan ranks as the fourth-largest investor in Cambodia, with investments in finance, construction, manufacturing, and real estate. Since 1994, Cambodia has hosted 210 Japanese investment projects totaling \$3.1 billion.

Educational and cultural cooperation between our countries is remarkable. Japan has provided numerous scholarships to Cambodian students, whose contributions to socio-economic development in Cambodia, whether in the public or private sector, are invaluable.

Human capital development is a top priority for the Cambodian government, and Japan's competitive advantage in technology and skill development aligns perfectly with our goals.

Japan's strength in Science, Technology, and Innovation diplomacy can be further leveraged to advance Japan's soft power in Cambodia.

Japan has also played a crucial role in preserving Cambodia's historical and cultural heritage, from the Angkor temple complex to Preah Vihear and Sambor Prei Kuk temples.

Japan has played a crucial role in International Coordinating Committee for the Safeguarding and Development of the Historic Site of Angkor (ICC-Angkor) and ICC-Preah Vihear. These cooperation mechanisms are the successful model in partnership building, resource mobilization, and knowledge sharing.

Individuals like Professor Yoshiaki Ishizawa, former President and Director of the Sophia Asia Center for Research and Human Development of Sophia University, have made significant contributions to the preservation and restoration of these heritage sites.

Looking ahead, both countries should invest more in social infrastructure development, such as water treatment and supply projects and healthcare infrastructure especially in rural areas.

Gender-inclusive and gender-sensitive infrastructure development should be further promoted.

Improved healthcare infrastructure will ensure that even the most remote areas have access to quality medical care. Japan's experience and technological

advancements in the medical field can greatly contribute to the development of a robust healthcare system in Cambodia.

In the realm of digital transformation, Japan can assist Cambodia by offering extensive training programs focused on digital start-ups and innovation. These training programs should cover a range of critical areas, including digital literacy, entrepreneurship, technology management, and advanced IT skills.

By doing so, Japan can help cultivate a new generation of Cambodian entrepreneurs and tech professionals who are well-equipped to lead the country's digital transformation.

Social innovation, with a particular emphasis on supporting small and medium-sized enterprises (SMEs) in building their innovation capacity, represents a promising area for cooperation between the two nations. SMEs are the backbone of Cambodia's economy, and enhancing their ability to innovate can drive economic growth and create new job opportunities.

Japan should play a pivotal role in supporting Cambodia's transition to green energy, particularly through the development of solar farms to supply energy to industries. For this to be effective, the Cambodian government needs to implement regulations that permit renewable energy producers to sell directly to factories, thereby ending the monopoly of Electricite du Cambodge (EDC).

Presently, there is considerable interest from the private sector in investing in solar energy. However, they encounter significant structural constraints due to existing rules and regulations.

Addressing these barriers will be crucial to unlocking the potential of renewable energy investments and ensuring a sustainable energy future for Cambodia.

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How small states exercise their agency

Naturally and structurally, small states are vulnerable to external threats and foreign intervention. However, size is not synonymous with strength or influence.

Through agile and innovative strategies, small states can assert their agency on the international stage, making them relevant in shaping the evolving new World Order.

Here are some strategies that small states can consider:

First, developing niche diplomacy. Small states can significantly impact by focusing on specific areas where they possess expertise or unique perspectives.

For instance, Qatar has skillfully wielded soft power through Al Jazeera, a global news network it established. Singapore has transformed itself to be a regional knowledge and innovation hub.

Second, building networked diplomacy. One of the most effective strategies for small states to amplify their influence is through networking and alliances.

By building strong regional alliances, small states can pool resources, share expertise, and present a united front on critical issues.

Collaborating with other countries allows them to amplify their voices and exert greater influence on the global stage.

These networks are instrumental in addressing common challenges, such as climate change, economic development, and security concerns.

In Southeast Asia, ASEAN plays a critical role in building collective agency and developing a shelter for small and medium-sized countries against external pressures while strengthening internal resilience.

Third, turning smallness into strength. Crafty strategies can turn smallness into strength, enabling smaller states to establish credibility and trust on the global stage despite the dominance of larger nations.

Small states can develop state-branding strategies, which allow them to gain relevance in the international system in key areas.

By adopting innovative approaches to diplomacy, small states can effectively navigate the complexities of international relations.

For instance, small states can focus on specific issue areas and invest in expertise to enhance their credibility and influence.

By prioritizing particular sectors, such as renewable energy, digital innovation, or humanitarian efforts, small states can carve out niches that contribute to addressing global challenges.

Fourth, promoting multilateral diplomacy. Small states recognize the value of multilateral diplomacy in enhancing their engagement and amplifying their voices.

Despite limited resources, they can leverage collective solidarity and the rule of law to their advantage. By participating actively in multilateral forums, small states can influence international debates and shape the global agenda.

Through multilateral diplomacy, small states can counter the narrative that they are irrelevant, weak, or tend to neutralize themselves.

By voicing their opinions on vital issues, such as climate change, economic development, and security, small states can challenge the dominance of larger nations and assert their relevance in the international community.

This proactive engagement is essential for securing their interests and ensuring their survival in an increasingly interconnected world.

Fifth, upholding rules-based international order. The increasing concerns over great-power rivalry have led to calls for a shift from a power-based to a more participatory rules-based order, especially among small and medium-sized countries.

The perspectives and roles of middle powers and small states are particularly significant in the multi-layered web of regional governance rules and institutions, as well as emerging minilateral mechanisms.

A notable example of this influence is the normative power of ASEAN in shaping regional architecture. When small and medium-sized countries collaborate, they can exert a substantial impact on regional and global governance. This demonstrates how these countries can shape and contribute to a more balanced and inclusive international system.

Sixth, leveraging strategic relevance. Supporting local actors with legitimacy and shared interests can help stabilize fragile states. Small states can contribute to peacebuilding efforts and conflict resolution by prioritizing specific issue areas and

investing in expertise. For instance, Switzerland has provided good offices for the benefit of peace.

By harnessing their economic potential and leveraging their strategic location, small states can increase their influence and relevance in international affairs. However, this requires careful management of their resources and strategic investments to maximize their impact.

Seventh, enhancing domestic resilience. Small states can make domestic arrangements to protect against their external vulnerabilities. Good economic management, administrative competence, and efforts to promote national unity and resilience are essential for buffering from within.

By strengthening their domestic institutions and fostering social cohesion, small states can enhance their capacity to withstand external threats and shocks.

In addition to seeking military, diplomatic, and economic relations, small states also emphasize social and cultural relations. Cultural diplomacy is a powerful tool for small states to avoid isolation while fostering international networks.

By promoting their cultural heritage and engaging in cultural exchanges, small states can enhance their identity and international visibility, and strengthen their diplomatic ties.

Eight, adapting to changing environment. International uncertainties and threats can pose grave dangers to the economies, societies, and very existence of small states.

Their inherent vulnerabilities require them to be nimble, agile and adaptable in responding to changing circumstances.

Small states can respond more nimbly as their governance structures are often streamlined, allowing for quicker decision-making and more focused strategies.

Small states are not merely passive players in international relations. They have the potential to shape the global agenda, contribute to addressing global challenges, and assert their agency in the face of global power transition and the unfolding new world order.

Through strategic empowerment, domestic resilience, and adaptive governance, small states can turn their size into diplomatic relevance and leverage.

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Funan Techo Canal: Connecting the Past, Present and Future

The Funan Techo Canal project is the symbol of national pride and progress, harkening back to the historical glory of the Khmer civilization during the Funan era. This era marked a golden age when Cambodia was the key commercial and cultural gateway of the Mekong region, facilitating trade and cultural exchanges that enriched the region and the world.

By undertaking the Funan Techo Canal project, Cambodia aims to revive and build upon this glorious history. This ambitious endeavor is not just an infrastructure project; it is a symbol of our nation's enduring spirit and potential- it can be regarded as a national rejuvenation project.

The canal seeks to recreate the dynamic role that ancient Funan played, transforming Cambodia once again into a pivotal hub of commerce, culture, and innovation. The project's vision is rooted in a deep respect for our history and an unyielding commitment to our future.

This transformative project rests on four fundamental pillars: national pride, economic interests, political independence, and national unity.

❖ Promoting National Pride and Historical Glory

The Funan Techo Canal project is a testament to the ingenuity, resilience, and rich cultural heritage of the Khmer civilization which is mainly based on river system and waterway.

It serves as a living monument to our ancestors' achievements, reminding us of the times when Cambodia was a center of trade, culture, and influence.

By reviving this historical glory, the canal project aims to instill a sense of pride among the Cambodian people. It reinforces our national identity, celebrating our unique heritage and historical contributions.

The project is a clarion call to embrace and honor our past while paving the way for future generations to take pride in their roots and the progress they contribute to the nation.

❖ Economic Interests and Development

The economic potential of the Funan Techo Canal project is relatively high. By creating a direct link between our inland waterways and the sea, the canal will revolutionize logistics and transport in Cambodia.

This enhanced connectivity will not only facilitate smoother and more efficient movement of goods but also attract significant investment. The development of economic zones and industrial parks along the canal will spur industrial growth, leading to the creation of numerous job opportunities.

This, in turn, will drive urbanization, bringing modern infrastructure, better services, and an improved quality of life to local communities. The canal is envisioned as a catalyst for sustainable economic growth, ensuring that the benefits of development are widely shared across the communities living along the canal.

Strengthening Political Independence

The Funan Techo Canal project is a strategic initiative that enhances Cambodia's political independence.

By developing our own waterway transport system, we reduce our reliance on external entities and increase our self-reliance.

This move towards self-sufficiency strengthens our sovereignty, enabling us to assert greater control over our national infrastructure and resources.

The canal project embodies our commitment to national ownership and the principle of self-determination. It is a bold statement of our ability to chart our own course, safeguard our interests, and navigate the complexities of global politics with confidence and autonomy.

❖ Inspiring National Unity and Strength

Perhaps one of the most profound impacts of the Funan Techo Canal project is its potential to inspire national unity and strength.

This project is a collective endeavor that transcends regional and social divides, bringing together people from all walks of life in a shared vision of progress and prosperity.

It serves as a powerful symbol of what we can achieve when we unite with a common purpose- it is part of institutional imagination.

The canal project is a source of hope and pride, fostering a sense of belonging and shared destiny. As we work towards the successful completion of this project, we are reminded of our national strength and the boundless potential that lies within our unity.

The Funan Techo Canal is more than just an infrastructural development; it is a visionary project that encapsulates the spirit of Cambodia's past, present, and future.

By promoting national pride, driving economic development, strengthening political independence, and fostering national unity, the canal stands as a testament to what we can achieve as a nation.

As we embark on this journey, let us draw inspiration from our history and look forward to a future of prosperity and strength, united in our shared vision for a better Cambodia.

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Cambodia's Green Energy Transition Needs Reforms

Cambodia is at a critical juncture in energy transition. The nation faces rapid energy demand growth and high electricity prices due to its reliance on fuel imports. Simultaneously, Cambodia's vulnerability to climate change, particularly from increased flooding risks, threatens critical infrastructure.

Cambodia has embarked on a clean and resilient energy transition, led by the power sector. However, significant constraints remain: the institutional capacity for long-term, data-driven energy sector planning and target-setting, particularly concerning climate risks, is still developing, and some institutional and technical constraints relating to the development of solar and wind energy.

In 2004, Cambodia's electricity grid was a bastion of fossil fuels, primarily relying on heavy-fuel oil and diesel. However, by 2013, a remarkable transformation took place, with 82% of the nation's electricity coming from renewable sources, predominantly hydropower.

This significant shift marked a milestone in Cambodia's energy sector, highlighting the country's potential for green energy leadership. However, there are remaining challenges to need to be addressed.

Regulatory frameworks necessary for new solutions are lacking, and the energy transition has not yet permeated sectors such as transport, industry, and buildings. Additionally, technical capacities to adopt climate-resilient and clean energy technologies are only just emerging.

The solution lies in mainstreaming renewable energy and energy efficiency while adopting innovative technologies and business models. The Energy Transition Sector Development Project, approved for financing by the Asian Development Bank (ADB) in December 2022, represents Cambodia's first comprehensive policy reform package for the energy sector.

This project aims to help the energy sector mainstream renewable energy and efficiency, transition away from fossil fuels, adopt data-driven regulation, and plan for a flexible and resilient power system.

By combining policy issuance, efficiency standards, and guidelines with government-led programs and investment projects, the program seeks to accelerate the

transition toward an energy-efficient economy, reduce greenhouse gas emissions, and create green jobs.

The goals are ambitious: a 25% increase in renewable energy generation and an 8.6% reduction in annual electricity demand through improved efficiency, all by 2027.

Renewable energy is not just viable for Cambodia; it is essential. With up to eight hours of sunlight per day, Cambodia boasts some of the richest solar resources in Southeast Asia.

A bottom-up energy transition is already underway, with farmers and business owners in rural areas adopting solar power to enhance productivity and incomes. Yet, a stronger policy push from the government is necessary to fully tap into the country's high solar potential.

Programs like EnergyLab's SWITCH to Solar support Cambodian entrepreneurs and startups, promoting solar power in the agriculture and fishery sectors and connecting them to farmers and rural businesses.

Such initiatives have already yielded significant results, with solar companies selling products worth over \$1.4 million and promoting solar technologies to more than 3,000 micro, small, and medium-sized enterprises.

However, to maximize the use of clean energy, more policy changes are needed.

According to the EnergyLab study, increased adoption of Solar PV over conventional generation technologies could yield significant economic benefits for Cambodia.

Modelling shows that replacing conventional plants with a higher uptake of Solar PV could reduce the overall cost of generating electricity, lower associated externality costs, and stimulate GDP growth.

An ambitious scenario replacing some coal, gas, and hydro with 9,702 MW of Solar PV backed by 2,500 MW of Battery Energy Storage System could save Cambodia \$2.04 billion by 2040 and reduce power system emissions by 117 megatonnes of CO₂.

Even a realistic scenario of 14% solar PV generation could save \$250 million in total power system costs and reduce externality costs by \$1.5 billion, translating to a cumulative GDP gain of 0.82% over 20 years.

Cambodia's robust solar PV resources remain largely untapped and can be rapidly developed with significant economic benefits. The time to act is now. By embracing renewable energy and energy efficiency, Cambodia can secure a sustainable and prosperous future, reducing its reliance on imports and ensuring greater energy security.

The path is clear: a greener Cambodia is within reach, and the government must take decisive steps to realize this vision.

Yet, the development of solar energy faces certain regulatory and bureaucratic challenges, including difficulties in obtaining licenses for solar energy farms and a lack of legal support to encourage direct solar energy investments for factory supply.

In neighboring Vietnam, the government has issued a new decree allowing factories to directly purchase electricity from power suppliers. This move aims to harness the country's abundant renewable energy potential.

Under the new regulations, power consumers can buy electricity directly from renewable energy generators via private transmission lines at negotiated prices, according to a government statement.

Vietnam, a regional manufacturing hub, has been striving to increase the share of solar and wind power in its energy mix. By allowing more space and flexibility for the private sector to get involved in the production and distribution of electricity, Vietnam can attract more foreign direct investments.

Cambodia can learn from Vietnam's regulatory reforms to boost its own renewable energy production. This would facilitate easier access to clean power sources for multinationals, which is particularly important for exporters to avoid higher tariffs and meet environmental, social, and governance (ESG) requirements.

As a result, Cambodia-based manufacturers could purchase electricity directly from producers, effectively ending the monopoly of Electricite du Cambodge (EDC).

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Cambodia's Path Forward: Embrace Futures Thinking

In an era marked by rapid change and global uncertainties, Cambodia stands at a pivotal juncture. To foster meaningful and sustainable development, our nation must embrace a forward-thinking strategy that reimagines the future to reshape the present.

While the past is immutable, our current actions hold the power to define tomorrow. The traditional approach of addressing current challenges by relying on past experiences has served us well, but it limits our capacity to innovate and adapt in an increasingly complex world.

❖ Why Futures Thinking Matters

Futures thinking is more than a theoretical exercise; it's a practical approach that equips us to anticipate emerging issues, navigate uncertainties, and craft resilient strategies.

This method involves identifying trends, exploring various scenarios, and building a shared vision for the future through inclusive dialogue. By focusing on what could be, rather than just what is, futures thinking fosters innovation and helps design policies that are adaptable to change.

Foresight, the actionable component of futures thinking, employs tools and methodologies to project potential futures, manage risks, and seize opportunities.

This proactive stance allows us to create strategies that are not just reactive but anticipatory, positioning Cambodia to better handle the challenges and opportunities of a dynamic global landscape.

❖ Design Thinking and Systems Thinking: Essential Tools

To complement futures thinking, we must integrate design thinking and systems thinking. Design thinking offers a user-centered, iterative approach to problem-solving, encouraging us to question assumptions, redefine challenges, and develop creative solutions through continuous experimentation. This approach is crucial for crafting practical and innovative pathways to our desired future.

Systems thinking provides a holistic perspective, focusing on how different elements of a system interact and impact each other over time. It emphasizes

understanding the interconnectedness within systems rather than isolating components. This comprehensive view is vital for addressing complex issues that cut across multiple sectors and governance levels.

❖ **Beyond Traditional Forecasting**

Futures thinking and foresight go beyond merely analyzing historical data and trends; they also incorporate diverse perspectives and imaginative inputs from a wide range of stakeholders, including government officials, industry leaders, civil society members, and academics.

Unlike traditional forecasting, which often focuses narrowly on what is feasible, futures thinking emphasizes what is aspirational and desirable. This participatory approach not only fosters stronger cross-sectoral connections but also promotes integrated solutions and empowers individuals to shape their preferred future.

By expanding the scope to include emerging issues and trends and exploring various future scenarios, futures thinking encourages the development of innovative solutions and robust policies.

This forward-looking approach ensures that projects and programs are designed with tools and insights that will remain relevant and effective in the future.

❖ **The Role of Innovation Labs**

Globally, innovation labs have emerged as vital hubs for tackling policy challenges with fresh approaches. These labs act as experimental arenas where new models can be tested, helping to avoid short-term, narrow-minded policies and investments. They apply futures thinking and foresight to map evolving landscapes, analyze uncertainties, and uncover development opportunities.

In Cambodia, the upcoming InnoLab, spearheaded by Angkor Social Innovation Park (ASIP) and Sequoia Group, represents a strategic move towards embracing futures thinking. Focused on Healthcare and Wellbeing, Sustainable Food Systems, and Inclusive Digital Transformation and Women Empowerment, InnoLab will also provide training in futures thinking, design thinking, systems thinking, leadership for innovation, and change management.

❖ **InnoLab's Vision and Core Values**

InnoLab will drive progress in key areas: (1) Healthcare and Wellbeing enhances preventative healthcare to improve public health outcomes; (2) Sustainable Food Systems advances agricultural practices that are environmentally sustainable and socially equitable; (3) Inclusive Digital Transformation and Women Empowerment aims to address the digital gender gap and empowering women through technology.

Guided by the values of Resilience, Resourcefulness, Community, and Continuity (2R2C), InnoLab celebrates the strength of the Cambodian people, fosters creativity and adaptability, emphasizes collaborative progress, and aims to create a lasting positive legacy.

❖ **Aligning with Cambodia Vision 2050**

InnoLab's initiatives are closely aligned with Cambodia Vision 2050, which envisions a nation that is robust, prosperous, and high-income by mid-century. This vision includes: a vibrant society, a resilient, high-income economy, a populace with knowledge and skills, a commitment to dignity, equality, and social protection, and a balanced approach to development and environmental conservation.

By anchoring its work in this vision, InnoLab aims to catalyze enduring positive change. The process of exploring, discovering, and co-creating solutions will not only enhance civic engagement but also build a collective commitment and multi-stakeholder partnerships to shape and realise Cambodia's future.

Embracing futures thinking and foresight is not just an option for Cambodia; it is an imperative. By doing so, we position ourselves to navigate uncertainty, drive innovation, and build a resilient future for our nation.

This article was first published in Khmer Time on 03 September 2024.

Cambodia's Path to Innovation: Inspirations from China

In recent years, China has undergone a monumental shift in its economic strategy, transitioning from a growth-maximizing model to an innovation-led approach.

This evolution, marked by the introduction of the “Innovation-Driven Development Strategy” in 2012, emphasizes the need for technological advancement to sustain long-term growth.

As Cambodia looks toward achieving upper-middle-income status by 2030 and a high-income country by 2050, there are valuable lessons to be drawn from China's model of innovation-led growth.

China's innovation journey can be broken down into three major stages.

In the late 20th century, China focused on leveraging technological advancements to modernize industries. This phase aimed to enhance productivity and create a more diversified economy by moving away from reliance on traditional heavy industry.

In the early 2000s, China pivoted towards making innovation the centerpiece of economic growth. The 2005 Medium- and Long-Term Plan for Science and Technology Development emphasized indigenous innovation, marking China's move towards technological self-sufficiency. Sectors such as energy, biotechnology, and information technology were identified as critical for the future.

In 2012, the formal Innovation-Driven Development Strategy was launched. China acknowledged that economic growth could no longer rely solely on low-cost manufacturing and exports. Instead, the country sought to become a leader in cutting-edge industries like biotechnology, renewable energy, and artificial intelligence. By focusing on disruptive technologies, China positioned itself at the forefront of global innovation, with the goal of becoming a world leader in science, technology and innovation by 2050.

The Chinese government has been instrumental in promoting innovation by channeling resources into specific sectors, offering financial incentives, and fostering collaboration between the public and private sectors.

This focus on “lead innovation”—which emphasizes the development of high-tech industries capable of transforming existing markets—has enabled China to evolve from a manufacturing hub into a global leader in technological innovation.

President Xi Jinping has emphasized the critical role of scientific and technological advancements in achieving Chinese modernization and promoting high-quality development. He has advocated for comprehensive planning and high-level scientific independence to help China reach its goal of becoming a world leader in science and technology by 2035.

In recent years, China has made significant progress in frontier research, advanced in strategic high-tech areas, and seen innovation-driven results contributing to its overall development.

Additionally, the country has taken steps to reform its science and technology systems while enhancing international cooperation in these fields.

Cambodia has experienced impressive economic growth over the past few decades, but it remains largely reliant on traditional sectors like garment manufacturing and agriculture. To secure long-term prosperity and achieve the ambitious goal of becoming an upper-middle-income economy by 2030, Cambodia must embrace an innovation-led development model similar to China's.

Here's how Cambodia can apply China's lessons.

First, Cambodia should develop a similar “innovation-driven development strategy”, taking into consideration national context. In 2019, Cambodia adopted the National Science, Technology, and Innovation (STI) Policy 2020–2030, which aims to strengthen the country's innovation capacity. Cambodia should focus on targeted sectors such as advanced manufacturing, modern agriculture, digital economy, and green economy, which have the potential to drive future economic growth.

Second, Cambodia should encourage the development of cutting-edge technologies. China's focus on lead innovation helped it become a global leader in industries like artificial intelligence and electric vehicles. Cambodia can similarly identify and promote technologies that have the potential to create new markets and disrupt traditional industries. For instance, investing in agritech and green energy could provide Cambodia with a competitive edge while promoting sustainability.

Third, China's innovation success is due, in large part, to effective collaboration between the government, private enterprises, and research institutions. Cambodia's government should foster similar partnerships to accelerate technological advancements and invest more resources in research and development. This can include initiatives like creating innovation clusters, where universities, startups, and established companies collaborate to develop new technologies, products, and services.

Fourth, China's rise as a global innovation leader would not have been possible without a strong emphasis on education and research. Cambodia needs to invest heavily in its education system, especially in science, technology, engineering, and mathematics (STEM) fields, to cultivate a skilled workforce capable of driving innovation. Scholarships, research grants, and partnerships with foreign institutions can help improve the quality of education and research in Cambodia.

Fifth, China's innovation ecosystem is supported by a centralized structure that coordinates efforts across different sectors. Cambodia's Ministry of Industry, Science, Technology, and Innovation (MISTI) plays a similar role, but there is room for improvement. Creating a more robust national innovation system that encourages collaboration and knowledge sharing will be essential for achieving the country's innovation goals.

Cambodia has made significant strides in its economic development, but to reach the next level, it must transition from a reliance on traditional sectors to becoming an innovation-driven economy. China's experience offers valuable lessons, particularly in the areas of government leadership, public-private partnerships, and investment in high-tech industries.

By adopting a focused innovation-led strategy, Cambodia could achieve its development vision 2030 and 2050. Strengthening the national STI ecosystem, investing in human capital, and investing in research and development will be essential in this transformation. The future of Cambodia's economy lies in its ability to innovate.

This article was first published in Khmer Time on 11 September 2024.

Ten Pillars of Hun Sen's Peace Theory

Former Prime Minister Samdech Techo Hun Sen, now serving as the President of the Senate, has been awarded 24 honorary doctorates from institutions around the world in recognition of his contributions to peace, leadership, and development. These accolades are based on objective assessments of his impact on Cambodia's history and future.

Peace is often understood in its simplest form as the absence of war or conflict, known as negative peace. However, a deeper and more comprehensive view transcends the mere cessation of violence. This broader concept, called positive peace, involves the active pursuit of justice, equality, and the well-being of society. Positive peace seeks to address structural inequities and injustices, creating conditions where all individuals can thrive.

In Cambodia, both negative and positive peace have been achieved largely due to the leadership of Hun Sen and his visionary Win-Win policy. This policy not only ended decades of civil war but also laid the foundation for sustainable peace through national reconciliation, unity, and development.

The 1991 Paris Peace Agreement was a crucial turning point for Cambodia, as it established a framework to end decades of war and conflict. However, it did not fully bring about lasting peace.

True and enduring peace was only realized in the late 1990s, following the implementation of Hun Sen's Win-Win policy. This policy effectively dismantled the remaining Khmer Rouge forces, fostering national reconciliation and leading to total peace in the Kingdom.

The success of the Win-Win policy was anchored in dialogue, trust-building, and strategic guarantees that facilitated the full dissolution of the Khmer Rouge and the reintegration of its forces into the Royal Cambodian Armed Forces by 1999.

Three key guarantees—protection of defectors' lives and safety, assurance of employment and livelihoods, and respect for personal property—were instrumental in addressing the fundamental human security needs of former combatants. These guarantees allowed the Khmer Rouge's military and political structures to be peacefully dismantled, offering defectors a path to reintegration into society.

Moreover, Hun Sen recognized that the lack of infrastructure in remote areas was a major factor in sustaining insurgencies. In response, he led efforts to build roads, bridges, and other essential infrastructure in former Khmer Rouge strongholds. As he often highlighted, the aim was “to connect these areas to the central administration of the country,” ensuring that even the most isolated regions were integrated into national development. This holistic approach is grounded in a profound understanding of what true peace entails.

As Johan Galtung’s concept of “structural violence” suggests, true peace involves more than simply halting active conflict; it requires addressing the underlying inequities and power imbalances that perpetuate unrest. Hun Sen’s Win-Win policy did exactly that, promoting national unity and giving former adversaries a stake in Cambodia’s future.

Hun Sen’s peace theory is built on ten conceptual pillars, extending beyond military disarmament and the cessation of violence. It includes strategies for social and economic integration, as well as fostering justice and international cooperation. His theory embodies both negative and positive peace.

First, ending the war through dialogue. Despite having the upper hand over his enemies, Hun Sen prioritized dialogue and trust-building as the foundation of his strategy. Through the DIFID approach—‘Divide, Isolate, Finish, Integrate, and Develop’—he successfully divided and defeated opposing forces, ultimately fostering national reconciliation.

Second, promoting social and economic integration. The Win-Win policy emphasized that peace is not just about ending violence, but also about integrating all factions into a cohesive society.

Former Khmer Rouge fighters were welcomed back and provided with opportunities for livelihoods. This social and economic integration has been crucial to Cambodia’s long-term stability, preventing the Kingdom from relapsing into conflict.

Third, promoting political and military integration. Genuine peace requires addressing the root causes of conflict. By incorporating the Khmer Rouge’s political ideology and military forces into the broader national framework, Hun Sen ensured these factions would have a place in Cambodia’s future, minimizing the risk of future conflict.

Fourth, forging the peace-development nexus. Hun Sen’s peace theory is inextricably linked to economic growth. Cambodia’s aspirations to become an upper-middle-income country by 2030 and a high-income country by 2050 demonstrate that

peace and development are mutually reinforcing. A stable society attracts investment, spurs development, and improves living standards, which in turn strengthens social cohesion.

Sixth, connecting peace with social harmony. The successful integration of former adversaries has allowed Cambodia to rebuild its social fabric. By ensuring that all citizens, regardless of past affiliations, races or religions, have a place in the new Cambodia, Hun Sen's policies have fostered a sense of national unity and social harmony.

Seventh, connecting peace and transitional justice. The Extraordinary Chambers in the Courts of Cambodia (ECCC) was established to hold accountable those responsible for gross human rights violations committed between 1975 and 1979, during the Khmer Rouge regime. Transitional justice, combined with remembrance, is essential for peacebuilding in post-conflict Cambodia, fostering reconciliation and healing among survivors and future generations.

Eight, promoting international cooperation for peace. Peace is not solely a domestic issue. Cambodia's stability has been bolstered by international cooperation, particularly through multilateral engagement and international development partnership. Cambodia has actively sought to cultivate relationships with international friends and partners, ensuring that Cambodia's peace is supported by the international community.

Ninth, promoting multilateralism for peace. Hun Sen's vision for peace extends beyond Cambodia's borders. Through active participation in multilateral forums and advocating for peaceful solutions to regional issues, Cambodia has become a proponent of an open and inclusive multilateralism that strengthens regional stability and reinforces Cambodia's peace.

Tenth, promoting international law for peace. A key aspect of Hun Sen's strategy is the emphasis on adherence to international norms and laws. In a world where conflicts often stem from the violation of global rules, Cambodia's alignment with a rules-based international order plays a vital role in sustaining its long-term peace and stability.

As Cambodia envisions to become a high-income country by 20250, the lessons of the Win-Win policy will remain essential. The country's ability to maintain peace while fostering development stands as a model for other post-conflict societies and nations striving to build a more just and prosperous future.

Hun Sen's peace theory offers a universal wisdom and value: peace is not simply an end; it is a continuous process that requires political integration, justice, the rule of law, social harmony, economic opportunities, international cooperation, and a shared commitment to building a better future for all.

This article was first published in Khmer Time on 18 September 2024.

A New Chapter of Cambodia-China Parliamentary Cooperation

Cambodia-China relations stand as a model of international cooperation between a large and small country based on the principles of mutual respect, non-interference, and equality.

As Cambodia and China move forward in building their community with a shared future, the deepening of parliamentary cooperation will play an increasingly important role in fostering people's participation and people-centred strategic partnership.

National Assembly President Khuon Sudary's visit to China has opened a new chapter in this historic milestone of the parliamentary cooperation and diplomacy, illustrating deep strategic trust and friendship.

Both nations have reaffirmed their political will to enhance bilateral cooperation, further aligning their efforts toward realizing a people-centered Community with a Shared Future, guided by the consensus of the leadership of the two countries.

A central focus of Sudary's visit was the further strengthening of parliamentary diplomacy between Cambodia and China.

During the bilateral meeting, Zhao Leji emphasized that the National People's Congress is ready to work closely with Cambodia to coordinate various forms of parliamentary cooperation, exchange experiences in legislation and supervision, and provide the legal framework necessary for pragmatic cooperation.

Zhao, Chairman of the Standing Committee of the National People's Congress, highlighted that the construction of a China-Cambodia community with a shared future has entered a new era of high-quality, high-level, and high-standard cooperation. This transformation is guided by the strategic vision of both countries' leaders, further deepening the bond between Cambodia and China.

Noting that China has always placed Cambodia in a special, important position in its neighborhood diplomacy, Zhao said China is willing to maintain high-level strategic communication and work with Cambodia to support each other firmly on issues concerning the two countries' core interests.

Wang Huning, Chairman of the the Chinese People's Political Consultative Conference (CPPCC) National Committee, said that China is willing to work with

Cambodia to implement the important consensus reached by the leaders of the two countries and continuously consolidate their ironclad friendship.

The CPPCC National Committee is willing to strengthen exchanges and cooperation with Cambodia and make positive contributions to promoting greater development of the China-Cambodia community with a shared future, Wang added.

Sudary stressed that the comprehensive strategic partnership and ironclad friendship are built on a strong, resilient foundation. Despite changes at the regional and international levels, ironclad friendship is unbreakable, unshakeable.

Cambodia's commitment to this partnership is exemplified by its consistent support for China on critical issues, including the consistent, firm upholding of the one-China policy and one-China principle.

Cambodia is a strong supporter of China's Belt and Road Initiative (BRI) and other China's global initiatives, including the Global Development Initiative, the Global Security Initiative, and the Global Civilization Initiative as these initiatives reflect shared values of peaceful co-existence, harmony, shared prosperity—principles that Cambodia has embraced in its foreign policy.

Cambodia views China as an indispensable strategic partner, playing a vital role in its socio-economic development as well as the protection of its sovereignty and political independence.

China regards Cambodia as a trustworthy and reliable friend and neighbor.

China is committed to aligning its engagement strategies with Cambodia's priorities, ensuring that both nations benefit mutually from their cooperation such as the promotion of strategic synergies between the BRI with Cambodia's Pentagonal Strategy and the alignment of Cambodia Vision 2050 with China Vision 2049.

The "Diamond Hexagon" framework is central to the China-Cambodia partnership and provides a roadmap for collaboration in key areas such as politics, agriculture, energy, production capacities, and people-to-people exchanges.

The "Industrial and Technological Corridor" and "Fish and Rice Corridor" are other practical cooperation frameworks that need more efforts and resources.

In the exclusive interview with China Global Television Network, Sudary emphasized Cambodia's deep admiration for China's remarkable achievements in

national governance, particularly in the areas of socio-economic development and poverty reduction.

She underscored that democracy cannot be imported or copied from one country to another, as each nation's democratic model must be rooted in its own unique cultural, historical, and social contexts.

She noted that China's whole-process people's democracy is a system tailored to its own realities, demonstrating that there is no one-size-fits-all approach to governance and that each country must find its own path to meet the needs and aspirations of its people.

Moving forward, parliamentary cooperation and diplomacy will add more values and impetus to the realization of a people-centered Cambodia-China Community with a shared future.

This article was first published in Khmer Time on 30 September 2024.

Cambodia's Peace Diplomacy

Cambodia's foreign policy has undergone a remarkable development over the past decade, marked by an increasingly robust and proactive approach to economic diplomacy and peace diplomacy.

These two pillars of modern Cambodian diplomacy reflect the country's transformation from a war-torn nation to an advocate for peace and development, underpinned by the principles of mutual respect, mutual understanding, mutual trust, and mutual interest for peace and prosperity.

Independent foreign policy based on international law and the commitment to open and inclusive multilateralism and a human-centred approach remains central to Cambodia's foreign policy.

Cambodia's peace journey offers valuable lessons for the Mekong region and the broader international community.

One must remember that peace is not given; it needs to be earned. Dialogue is key to the peace process.

❖ From Conflict to Peace Advocacy

Once a victim of war and conflict, Cambodia has become a promoter of peace on regional and international stages.

The recent hosting of the 11th Plenary Session of the International Parliament for Tolerance and Peace is a case in point.

The event concluded with the adoption of the Phnom Penh Declaration and the Universal Peace Charter, a milestone in fostering global dialogue and cooperation on peace.

Cambodia's role as a convener of peace-focused discussions is unique. It provides a safe and open platform for dialogue among governments, parliaments, political parties, experts, and community leaders.

This approach reflects a core belief that peace can be built through diplomacy and dialogue. By positioning itself as a "bridge of trust and cooperation" in the Mekong region and beyond.

❖ The Mekong Region: A New Growth Centre

The Mekong region is emerging as one of the world's new growth centers, offering immense potential for cooperation, connectivity, and prosperity.

Cambodia's peace diplomacy aligns seamlessly with this dynamic, emphasizing collaboration over conflict and shared development over division.

Concerning border negotiations and demarcation with neighboring countries, Cambodia remains committed to upholding international law and fostering a spirit of friendship and cooperation.

By fostering trust and cooperation in the Mekong, Cambodia seeks to unlock the region's potential while contributing to international peace and development.

Cambodia has adopted a proactive stance within the ASEAN framework, actively contributing to efforts aimed at achieving a political settlement and delivering humanitarian assistance in Myanmar.

❖ A Commitment to Global Peace

Since 2006, Cambodia has underscored its commitment to global peace and security by deploying nearly 10,000 peacekeepers to United Nations missions in ten countries. These contributions not only highlight Cambodia's dedication to peace but also enhance its international stature as a responsible and proactive member of the global community.

❖ Leadership and the Win-Win Policy

Central to Cambodia's peace diplomacy is the legacy of Hun Sen, often regarded as the architect of peace in Cambodia. His Win-Win Policy is a cornerstone of Cambodia's modern history, combining peace negotiation, peacebuilding, and national reconciliation. At its heart are trust and confidence-building measures, underpinned by Buddhist values of forgiveness, tolerance, and peaceful coexistence.

Strategic pragmatism has been critical to the success of the Win-Win Policy. By being flexible in tactics while remaining firm on principles, Cambodia achieved a durable peace that has laid the foundation for its development and international engagement. This approach offers a source of inspiration for other nations grappling with conflict and post-conflict challenges.

❖ Transitional Justice and the Rule of Law

The Extraordinary Chambers in the Courts of Cambodia (ECCC), also known as the Khmer Rouge Tribunal, illustrates Cambodia's commitment to transitional justice.

By blending international and Cambodian judicial expertise, the ECCC has set a global standard for post-conflict justice. Its public outreach programs, which include film screenings, study tours, and school lectures, have engaged hundreds of thousands of Cambodians, ensuring that the lessons of the past are preserved for future generations.

The tribunal's live broadcasts and accessible public gallery have made it a model for transparency and civic engagement. Without the Khmer Rouge Tribunal, Cambodia would not have been able to record and preserve the history of the Khmer Rouge regime, nor establish the critical foundation for the rule of law that now underpins its society.

❖ Peace Above All Else

Cambodia's peace diplomacy is rooted in a fundamental principle: peace must be placed above all else. This ethos, shaped by the country's painful history, informs its foreign policy and domestic governance. By understanding, embracing, and implementing the values of peace, Cambodia has charted a path that other nations can follow.

❖ Looking Ahead

As Cambodia's foreign policy continues to evolve, its commitment to peace diplomacy will remain central.

By promoting dialogue, building trust, and emphasizing diplomacy and cooperation, Cambodia is not only securing its own future but also contributing to the stability and prosperity of the Mekong region and beyond.

In an era of increasing geopolitical tensions, Cambodia's model of strategic pragmatism, grounded in the values of peace and diplomacy, offers a useful lesson of how nations can transform tensions and conflicts into opportunities for peace.

This article was first published in Khmer Time on 20 October 2024.

Cambodia's Parliamentary Diplomacy within ASEAN

The President of Cambodia's National Assembly, Samdech Khuon Sudary, led a delegation to the 45th General Assembly of the ASEAN Inter-Parliamentary Assembly (AIPA) in Vientiane, from October 17 to 23. The focus of the General Assembly is to promote parliamentary dialogue and cooperation on regional and international issues, with a special emphasis on building a people-centered ASEAN Community.

The theme of this year underscores the critical role of parliaments in strengthening connectivity and fostering inclusive growth across ASEAN. As the region navigates an increasingly complex, volatile geopolitical landscape, Cambodia's parliamentary diplomacy has gained renewed momentum, working closely with other legislative bodies to promote peace and development for humanity underpinned by the values of mutual respect and trust, ensuring that regional cooperation benefits all members of ASEAN fairly.

Looking ahead, Cambodia will demonstrate her proactive parliamentary diplomacy by hosting the 11th Plenary Session of the International Parliament for Tolerance and Peace (IPTP) next month- it will serve as a platform for multi-stakeholder dialogue on peace, while strengthening open and inclusive multilateralism and reinforcing respect for international law. A Peace Charter, initiated by Samdech Techo Hun Sen, will be elaborated and adopted as a complementary framework to the United Nations Charter, further embedding peace as a core value in Cambodia's international engagement.

Notably, Cambodia's approach to parliamentary diplomacy has evolved significantly since the start of the seventh legislature, embracing a proactive stance on key issues and challenges facing the region. Rooted in principles of mutual respect, trust, and common interests, this approach has enabled Cambodia to build stronger international cooperation and partnerships, contributing to shape and mold the fast-evolving regional architecture.

At the heart of Cambodia's parliamentary diplomacy are core principles such as peaceful co-existence, non-interference in internal affairs, equality, inclusiveness, and openness. These values resonate with ASEAN's broader goal of fostering peace, stability, integration, connectivity, and shared prosperity. Central to Cambodia's strategy is the promotion of a people-centered ASEAN Community, ensuring that the interests and aspirations of the people are at the core of the regional integration agenda.

In today's rapidly changing world, where geopolitical competition between major powers is intensifying, Cambodia's parliamentary diplomacy highlights the importance of promoting open and inclusive multilateralism, a rules-based international order, and constructive engagement through dialogue.

Parliamentary diplomacy has become a vital platform for fostering mutual understanding and trust—not only within the ASEAN community but also with ASEAN's external partners. It serves as a crucial mechanism for bridging divides, reinforcing the habit of dialogue and cooperation, and ensuring that regional interests are safeguarded amid rising global uncertainties and tensions.

Cambodia has consistently taken a pragmatic stance on pressing issues like Myanmar, advocating for the swift and effective implementation of ASEAN's Five-Point Consensus while upholding ASEAN Unity and Centrality. Cambodia's diplomatic approach ensures that ASEAN remains at the forefront of addressing the Myanmar crisis through peaceful and diplomatic solutions, underscoring the importance of ASEAN's agency in resolving regional conflicts.

In her address to the 45th AIPA General Assembly, Samdech Khuon Sudary emphasized ASEAN's centrality in navigating the complex geopolitical tensions that have challenged global governance and the international order. She urged ASEAN parliamentarians to stay vigilant in defending regional interests, promoting peaceful co-existence, and reinforcing ASEAN's convening power and normative influence in shaping the future of the region.

Samdech Sudary also highlighted the importance of ASEAN unity and collective action in addressing common issues and challenges. Among her priorities were upholding open and inclusive regionalism, leveraging the Regional Comprehensive Economic Partnership (RCEP) to deepen regional integration, and advancing emerging critical areas of growth, such as the green and digital economies. Additionally, she emphasized the need to prioritize climate action and gender equality—both crucial to ASEAN's sustainable development and inclusive growth.

Samdech Sudary also advocated for enhanced ASEAN connectivity, not only through physical infrastructure but also institutional frameworks. She proposed concrete steps to bolster connectivity for inclusive growth, such as coordinating policies to strengthen regional integration, harnessing digital transformation, and ensuring that the benefits of economic growth are equitably shared across ASEAN's diverse populations.

Samdech Sudary underscored that parliamentary diplomacy and cooperation remain essential instruments in promoting regionalism and multilateralism. These efforts align with ASEAN's core principles, shared values, and norms, as outlined in the ASEAN Charter, the Treaty of Amity and Cooperation, and the ASEAN Outlook on the Indo-Pacific. As ASEAN looks towards the future, Cambodia's active participation in forums like AIPA will continue to strengthen the region's ability to tackle both current and emerging challenges, ensuring that ASEAN remains a pillar of stability, cooperation, and growth in an interconnected world.

Cambodia's role within ASEAN, demonstrated through its parliamentary diplomacy, reaffirms the Kingdom's international responsibility and commitment. As the region faces an increasingly complex and volatile geopolitical landscape, Cambodia's proactive engagement through parliamentary channels will remain a crucial element in safeguarding her core national interests.

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Cambodia Needs to Invest in Leadership Development

Since achieving lasting peace in the late 1990s, Cambodia has made remarkable progress in human resource development.

As emphasized in the Pentagonal Strategy Phase One, human capital development is central to Cambodia's goal of becoming a high-income country by 2050.

Achieving this vision requires not only the growth of skills and knowledge within the workforce but also the establishment of a supportive ecosystem that fosters continuous learning, leadership, and innovation.

For this transformation to be effective, the Cambodian government must prioritize strategic investments that cultivate this ecosystem, which goes beyond conventional educational and vocational training programs to develop comprehensive pathways that incorporate leadership training, critical thinking, and entrepreneurial skills.

The Ministry of Education, Youth and Sports, along with the Ministry of Labour and Vocational Training, has initiated a range of targeted programs aimed at realizing this strategic goal. These initiatives, which focus on STEM education, vocational training, and skill development, have produced laudable tangible outcomes.

But in terms of leadership development, Cambodia needs to invest much more. In many ways, leadership development is an essential complement to Cambodia's broader human resource initiatives.

Where technical skills and industry knowledge create the foundation, leadership skills fuel the transformative potential of individuals to drive change and innovation within organizations and communities.

Leadership development equips people to navigate challenges and solve problems, while strengthening national resilience from the inside out.

Key aspects of leadership development include a deep understanding of organizational dynamics and behavior insights, the ability to build and lead cohesive and innovative teams, and the capacity in navigating complex interpersonal and structural dynamics.

Effective leadership development programs should go beyond theoretical learning. They should offer practical, hands-on workshops designed to foster self-awareness,

address personal weaknesses, and build on strengths through structured coaching and interactive learning sessions.

These programs should also integrate the expertise of behavioral and leadership consultants to help participants identify and overcome internal and external challenges. Building these capacities prepares individuals to drive meaningful change in their workplaces and communities by aligning their actions with a broader vision.

At its core, leadership begins at the individual level. A country's transformation—whether in the public sector, private sector, or social sector—depends on empowered, visionary individuals who are equipped to think critically, act strategically, and foster environments of innovation and accountability.

To drive meaningful and sustainable development, the Cambodian government should establish a dedicated fund specifically for leadership and professional development programs targeted at public servants at both national and sub-national levels.

Currently, Cambodia has a critical gap in the resources available for cultivating leadership skills among those public servants tasked with driving, implementing national and sub-national policies.

The public servants lack the structured support necessary for developing their leadership skills and adaptive capacities needed to address Cambodia's evolving social, economic, and administrative challenges.

To effectively realize Cambodia's Pentagonal Strategy, with good governance at its core, public servants and leaders at all levels must be equipped with a robust set of leadership skills.

These might include team building, futures thinking, coaching, facilitation skills, and the ability to foster cross-agency collaboration. Each of these qualities contributes to creating a dynamic, agile, and forward-thinking public sector capable of responding to complex challenges and driving long-term state building.

By creating a special fund on leadership development for the public servants, the government could support a variety of programs aimed at strengthening leadership competencies across key areas such as decision-making, team building, governance, and innovative problem-solving.

Structured training sessions, hands-on workshops, and coaching with seasoned professionals would provide public servants with opportunities to cultivate skills that are not typically acquired through traditional job training or university education.

Such a focus on professional growth within the public sector would empower leaders at every level to take on more complex roles and address challenges with confidence and insight.

Public sector leaders who are well-equipped with leadership skills can act as catalysts for change, fostering a culture of life-long learning within government institutions.

By building a sustainable public program or initiative that prioritizes ongoing learning and skill development, Cambodia would not only strengthen its public institutions but also inspire greater public trust and engagement in government initiatives.

In the long run, this investment would create a ripple effect throughout Cambodian society. Stronger leadership capacity within the government would lead to more effective policies, greater public service delivery, more accountable and transparent governance, and a more agile response to wicked issues or problems.

As Cambodia strives to elevate its place in the international arena, investing in the leadership potential of its public servants is a critical step toward realizing this vision.

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Connecting Khmer Civilization

The Khmer Empire ruled vast areas of mainland Southeast Asia from around 802 CE to 1431 CE, reaching its peak between the 11th and 13th centuries. Also known as the Kingdom of Angkor, it succeeded the earlier Funan and Chenla kingdoms, shaping much of the region's culture and history.

Most Khmer people today practice Buddhism, which was first introduced by Indian missionaries in the 3rd century BCE, with a significant rise in influence by the 5th century CE, coexisting with Hinduism.

During the Khmer Empire (9th to 15th centuries), Buddhism flourished alongside Hinduism. King Jayavarman VII (1181-1218) was a significant proponent, establishing Mahayana Buddhism as the state religion.

By the 13th century, Theravada Buddhism had become the dominant faith in Cambodia, eventually establishing itself as the country's official religion and profoundly shaping Khmer culture, art, and architecture.

The 1993 Cambodian Constitution enshrines Buddhism as the state religion, reflecting its central role in national identity. As of now, four countries officially recognize Buddhism as their state religion: Bhutan, Cambodia, Myanmar, and Sri Lanka.

Today, traditional Buddhist festivals like the Kathina festival – originating 2,500 years ago – are celebrated by Cambodian Buddhists. Held annually in October and November, Kathina is the largest alms-giving ceremony in the Buddhist calendar, marking the end of the Vassa, or monsoon retreat, when laypeople offer cloth and other necessities to monks.

Following the decline of the Khmer Empire in the mid-15th century, Khmer territories gradually contracted as neighboring powers such as Siam (present-day Thailand) and Annam (present-day Vietnam) expanded their influence in the region. This geopolitical shift led to a dispersal of Khmer communities beyond the borders of present-day Cambodia.

Today, Khmer communities can be found in areas such as southern Vietnam, where they are known as Khmer Krom ("Lowland Khmer"), and in parts of Thailand, where they are called Khmer Loeu ("Upland Khmer"). These communities have maintained unique cultural and linguistic ties to Cambodia, preserving aspects of Khmer

heritage despite living under different political systems and often facing pressures to assimilate.

The spread of Khmer communities across the region has created a cultural diaspora, linking Cambodian identity with a broader historical region. These dispersed communities continue to play an important role in preserving Khmer traditions, language, and religious practices, and they form a cultural bridge between Cambodia and its neighboring countries.

The prolonged civil war in Cambodia hindered strong ties between Khmer communities across the region. However, following the country's achievement of total peace in late 1998, efforts to rekindle cultural and ancestral bonds are thriving. In a recent Kathina ceremony organized at pagodas in the Khmer Krom region of southern Vietnam on October 5-6, Cambodian leaders made a clear commitment to preserving and revitalizing Khmer cultural heritage and strengthening ties with the Khmer Krom people.

Through the recent Kathina ceremony, led by Samdech Bun Rany Hun Sen, the President of the Cambodian Red Cross, Wat Po Kiri Vongsaram, also known as Wat Svay Siem Thmey, in Tra Vinh in Southern Vietnam on 5 November 2024, Cambodia has opened a meaningful new chapter in its bilateral relations with Vietnam, underscoring the values of mutual respect and traditional friendship, allowing Cambodia to honor the shared spiritual and cultural ties with Khmer Krom.

It symbolizes Cambodia's commitment to fostering people-centered development and reconnecting with the Khmer diaspora. By supporting the preservation of Khmer culture, language, and heritage, Cambodia is emphasizing these as core pillars of its national identity, while also using them to strengthen regional partnerships. This initiative aligns with Cambodia's broader diplomatic approach of using cultural and historical ties to build goodwill and harmony with neighboring countries.

The Khmer Krom, who have long preserved Khmer traditions in southern Vietnam, serve as a vital cultural bridge between Cambodia and Vietnam. Their role in maintaining Khmer heritage makes them central to Cambodia's efforts in cultural diplomacy, highlighting the interconnectedness of people across borders. By respecting the Khmer Krom's contributions and strengthening these cultural bonds, Cambodia reaffirms its vision of being a good neighbor, friend, and partner of Vietnam.

The success of the Kathina ceremony demonstrates that Cambodia's people diplomacy is at work, promoting cultural connectivity and corridor. It showcases Cambodia's approach of placing cultural and human values at the center of its diplomatic engagements, helping to enhance regional understanding and cooperation.

This article was first published in Khmer Time on 13 November 2024.

Empowering Science, Technology and Innovation for Peace

As Cambodia prepares to host a landmark peace forum in Phnom Penh this month, bringing together leaders from the legislative and executive branches, political parties, international organizations, and peace experts, we must consider a crucial question: how can science, technology, and innovation support peace-building efforts in an increasingly interconnected, complex, and turbulent world?

Peace is more than the absence of violence; it is the presence of harmony, social well-being, and opportunity.

Peace serves as the foundation of economic development and social progress, yet achieving and sustaining it requires constant efforts. We should never take peace for granted.

In the current era of technological revolution and digital transformation, building a resilient “ecosystem of peace” demands that we harness science, technology and innovation to support the foundation of peace.

The synergy between peace and technology grows more pressing each day, especially as conflicts multiply and intensify across the globe.

Science, technology, and innovation hold immense potential to aid in building peace – but if used without care, they could also aggravate divisions and vulnerabilities. Technology is a double-edged sword.

❖ Building a Framework for Science and Technology in Peacebuilding

A recent study published in the Communications Engineering offers four principles essential to creating peace-focused technologies: adopting a common language, prioritizing needs-driven innovation, involving diverse stakeholders, and adhering to the “do-no-harm” principle.

These principles offer a practical roadmap to ensure that technology serves as a tool for peace, not a source of further harm.

First, adopting a common language is critical. Too often, researchers, policymakers, and peacebuilders speak in silos, hindered by differences in jargon and perspective.

By creating a shared language around peace, we can foster solutions that address the complex realities of conflict while bridging the divides between disciplines. This common understanding allows us to avoid misunderstandings and work together effectively.

Second, promoting needs-driven innovation that centers on designing peacebuilding technologies that genuinely serve affected communities.

When innovation is detached from the lived experiences of those impacted by violence, solutions risk being ineffective or even harmful.

To develop tools that foster peace, we must engage directly with local populations and organizations, ensuring our technologies are responsive to real challenges on the ground.

Third, engaging diverse stakeholders. This highlights the importance of collaboration. Peacebuilding is a collective effort, requiring insights from international organizations, local NGOs, governments, and community leaders.

Bringing these voices into the design and development stages of peace technology ensures that solutions are inclusive, context-sensitive, and scalable. In doing so, we draw on the expertise of those who understand the unique dynamics of conflict in each community.

Fourth, commitment to the “do-no-harm”. Emerging technologies can empower, but they can also polarize, increase vulnerabilities, and exacerbate violence.

By conducting thorough risk assessments and implementing ethical safeguards, technologists and peacebuilders can work to ensure that new innovations do not inadvertently put communities at greater risk. This principle is essential to building trust in technology as a force for good.

❖ The Growing Field of PeaceTech

The emerging field of PeaceTech – the use of technology specifically designed to prevent violence and support peace – has the potential to transform peacebuilding.

From artificial intelligence that predicts conflict hotspots to digital platforms enabling inclusive peace processes, technological tools are expanding the possibilities for effective intervention.

However, along with these possibilities come challenges. We must ensure data privacy and security, establish ethical oversight, and address the motivations of companies developing these tools to prevent their misuse.

A new approach, “Peace Innovation,” calls for partnerships across disciplines, bringing together researchers, policymakers, technologists, and community leaders to design solutions that are informed by context and culture.

By working across boundaries, peacebuilders and innovators can create technologies that address real-world issues, respect cultural sensitivities, and deliver tangible results.

For example, Peace Innovation has already made cities safer through smart city technologies that use IoT-enabled infrastructure and data analytics to identify and reduce violence in high-risk areas.

Technology has also enhanced humanitarian efforts, with real-time data collection on displacement patterns enabling faster, better-informed responses for those fleeing conflict zones.

Additionally, secure digital platforms are now being used to document and report incidents of identity-based violence, providing survivors with safe tools for seeking justice.

❖ **Building a Peaceful and Just Future**

As we consider the future, we must remember that peace is not merely the absence of conflict; it is the presence of justice, equity, and security for all. This vision of peace requires addressing the root causes of conflict, bridging divides, and promoting opportunity for everyone.

Science and technology can be our allies in this journey, but only if we pursue peace in a way that is ethical, inclusive, and deeply attuned to the needs of those we aim to serve.

Let us commit to action, working together to make science, technology, and innovation central to our peace efforts. Cambodia can play an important role in this regard by promoting international dialogue and knowledge sharing on STI for Peace.

This article was first published in Khmer Time on 14 November 2024.

An Enduring, Resilient Friendship

This week, the Chairman of the National Assembly of the Socialist Republic of Vietnam, **H.E. Tran Thanh Man**, will embark on a four-day official visit to Cambodia.

His visit signifies a milestone in strengthening bilateral parliamentary cooperation and advancing the deep-rooted ties between the two nations.

During his time in Cambodia, he will have a bilateral meeting with Samdech Khuon Sudary, President of the National Assembly, inaugurate the new administrative building of the National Assembly, a generous gift from Vietnam, and participate in two major international forums in Phnom Penh.

This visit is particularly significant as it marks H.E. Tran Thanh Man's first official trip to Cambodia in his capacity as Chairman of the National Assembly, following his assumption of the role in May this year.

The new administrative building, funded by a USD 25 million grant from Vietnam, stands as a symbol of the enduring friendship and comprehensive cooperation between the two nations. The building reflects the long-term solidarity and friendship shared by the two peoples.

❖ A Strong and Resilient Partnership

Cambodia and Vietnam share a stable, healthy, and dynamic relationship characterized by deep mutual trust and robust cooperation.

As good neighbors, trusted friends, and strong partners, the two nations have consistently supported one another in all circumstances.

Economic ties between Cambodia and Vietnam continue to grow at a remarkable pace. Bilateral trade is expected to surpass USD 10 billion this year, underscoring the vibrant commercial linkages between the two countries.

Vietnamese investment in Cambodia has reached approximately USD 2.6 billion, with notable contributions from enterprises such as Metfone, a subsidiary of Viettel. As Cambodia's leading telecom and digital services provider, Metfone generates over USD 100 million annually in tax revenue and employs more than 3,000 local staff, further solidifying Vietnam's economic footprint in the Kingdom.

Tourism is another pillar of cooperation. Vietnam ranks as the second-largest source of international visitors to Cambodia, with slightly more than one million Vietnamese tourists recorded last year.

❖ **Fostering People-to-People Connections**

Cultural and educational exchanges form the foundation of the strong people-to-people ties between the two nations. Vietnam annually awards 120 scholarships to Cambodian students, while Cambodia reciprocates with 34 scholarships for Vietnamese students.

Educational exchanges deepen mutual understanding and foster long-term relationships between future generations.

❖ **Strengthening Trilateral Cooperation**

While Cambodia recently decided to withdraw from the Cambodia-Laos-Vietnam Development Triangle Area (CLV-DTA), its partnership with Vietnam and Laos remains unwavering.

The leadership of the three countries understands that their unity is essential for maintaining peace and stability, promoting economic development and poverty reduction especially along border areas.

The metaphor of a tripod aptly captures the interdependence and interconnectedness of the three nations – working together ensures collective strength and resilience.

Despite the dynamic changes unfolding at the national, regional, and international levels, the trilateral relationship continues to stand firm, characterized by deep trust, shared vision, mutual respect, and common interest.

As the two nations continue to deepen their ties, this new era of parliamentary cooperation holds promise for even greater achievements in the years to come.

While significant progress has been achieved in Cambodia-Vietnam relations, there remain untapped potentials that both nations should explore to further deepen their partnership. The following recommendations outline key areas for enhanced collaboration:

First, investing in the younger generation is essential to fostering mutual understanding and building lasting trust and friendship.

Both countries should expand opportunities for youth exchanges, particularly for university students and young leaders.

Initiatives such as joint academic programs, leadership summits, and cultural immersion activities can help bridge generational gaps and cultivate a sense of shared destiny.

Strengthened person-to-person ties are the foundation of a resilient and dynamic relationship between the two nations.

Second, expanding cultural cooperation – through joint celebrations, exhibitions, and the study of each other’s rich heritage – will further enrich bilateral relations.

Exploring the historical connections of Khmer civilization and its influence in the region can serve as a unifying narrative that reinforces cultural solidarity.

Third, unlocking the full potential of cross-border trade, investment, and tourism, both governments must work to eliminate existing barriers and obstacles.

Streamlining customs procedures, harmonizing regulations, and enhancing border infrastructure will facilitate smoother economic exchanges.

Policies that encourage private-sector partnerships and innovation can also drive greater economic integration and growth.

Fourth, jointly addressing transnational crimes such as online fraud, human trafficking, and drug smuggling.

Cambodia and Vietnam should intensify their collaboration through joint task forces, intelligence sharing, and capacity-building programs to effectively address these threats.

Enhanced cooperation in law enforcement and judicial coordination is crucial in this regard.

Fifth, cooperating on international issues. In an increasingly complex geopolitical landscape, Cambodia and Vietnam must deepen their coordination on regional and international matters.

By working together to advocate for open and inclusive multilateralism, a rules-based international order, and the Global South, the two nations can amplify their voices on the global stage.

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Towards 2050, Cambodia Needs a Leapfrog Strategy

As Cambodia aspires to become a high-income country by 2050, it must adopt a leapfrog strategy centered on innovation and technology.

While the government has set ambitious milestones, including graduating from Least Developed Country (LDC) status by 2029 and achieving upper-middle-income status by 2030, the one-year gap between these targets highlights a critical challenge.

Realizing the 2050 vision requires Cambodia to overcome the middle-income trap—a complex, structural phenomenon that has stalled many nations on their path to prosperity.

❖ The Middle-Income Trap: A Challenge to Growth

The middle-income trap arises when a country loses its competitive edge in low-cost, labor-intensive goods but fails to transition into higher value-added industries. This stagnation leads to sluggish growth, stagnant or declining wages, and an expanding informal economy.

To break free, Cambodia must address the structural issues that underpin this trap. Lessons from other countries offer a roadmap:

- **Fostering Innovation:** Transforming industries through advanced technologies and restructured enterprise practices.
- **Promoting Entrepreneurship:** Empowering entrepreneurs to drive economic diversification and resilience.
- **Enhancing Education:** Expanding access to secondary and tertiary education to build a skilled workforce.
- **Building Top-Tier Universities:** Establishing world-class institutions to advance research and development.
- **Strengthening Institutions:** Creating fair, transparent, and accountable governance structures.
- **Encouraging Prudent Risk-Taking:** Cultivating a culture that embraces calculated risks for growth.
- **Prioritizing Sustainability:** Embedding environmental considerations into economic planning.

- **Upholding the Rule of Law:** Transitioning from personalized governance to rule-based institutional frameworks.

Cambodia's path forward demands a concentrated focus on two transformative pillars: innovation-driven growth and Artificial Intelligence (AI).

❖ Innovation-Driven Growth

Innovation lies at the heart of escaping the middle-income trap. However, Cambodia's innovation capacity remains limited. According to the Global Innovation Index (GII) 2024, Cambodia ranks 103rd out of 133 economies, lagging behind regional peers like Thailand (41st) and Vietnam (44th). This highlights the urgency for a robust national innovation strategy.

To strengthen its innovation ecosystem, Cambodia can draw lessons from global best practices:

- **Identifying Institutional Structures:** Establishing frameworks that prioritize innovation outcomes.
- **Developing Common Innovation Infrastructure:** Supporting research, higher education, and the accumulation of technological knowledge.
- **Strengthening Industry-Science Linkages:** Bridging the gap between academia and industry to accelerate innovation.
- **Enhancing Efficiency of Support Institutions:** Providing entrepreneurs with resources to commercialize innovations.
- **Learning from Global Leaders:** Adapting successful models from countries with high innovation capacity.

By aligning policies and investments with these priorities, Cambodia can better position itself in regional and international supply chains and value chains.

❖ Artificial Intelligence

Artificial Intelligence presents an unparalleled opportunity for Cambodia to leapfrog its development.

Whether a nation fails or grows depends very much on the capacity to develop, manage, and govern AI. Southeast Asian countries are competing to become the region's top AI hub. Currently Singapore is leading the race.

Nations leading in AI view it as a strategic tool to address fragmented yet interconnected global supply chains. AI is a catalyst of growth.

For developing countries, AI offers a pathway to accelerate progress in core development areas and improve citizens' lives.

A well-defined AI strategy should align with Cambodia's unique strengths, challenges, and strategic priorities. Key considerations include:

- **Workforce Development:** Addressing STEM talent shortages through re-skilling, up-skilling, and education reform.
- **Sectoral Prioritization:** Targeting AI investments in sectors like agriculture, where precision farming can drive productivity, or manufacturing, where automation can enhance competitiveness.
- **Ethics and Regulation:** Developing a robust regulatory framework that integrates data protection, privacy laws, and AI ethics to foster trust and accountability.
- **Research Collaboration:** Strengthening partnerships between academia, industry, and government to create a thriving AI ecosystem.

International and multi-stakeholder collaboration will also be essential. By learning from global leaders and engaging with regional and international partners, Cambodia can accelerate its journey toward becoming an AI-ready nation.

To achieve its 2050 vision, Cambodia must make bold, forward-looking investments in innovation and AI. These pillars offer not only a means to overcome the middle-income trap but also a foundation for long-term, sustainable growth.

With a clear strategy and long-term commitment, Cambodia can position itself as a high-income country by 2050. It is urgent and imperative for the Cambodian government to develop national strategies on innovation and AI.

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Cambodia's Economic Outlook

Cambodia's economic performance in 2024 has shown resilience, with an estimated growth rate of approximately 6 percent. While there are slight variations in growth rate estimates, the overall outlook remains positive. According to the World Bank, the primary drivers of this growth include the revival of goods and services exports, a rebound in tourism, and the recovery of private consumption, all of which have underpinned a stronger domestic economic recovery.

The manufacturing sector continues to play a pivotal role in Cambodia's growth, with notable contributions from the garment, footwear, and travel goods industries. These sectors have not only powered economic expansion but also supported employment and export earnings. In agriculture, growth was recorded at 1.2 percent in 2024, with projections suggesting a modest increase to 1.3 percent in 2025. The services sector performed strongly with a 5.4 percent growth rate in 2024, though it is anticipated to slightly decelerate to 5.2 percent in 2025. Conversely, the real estate and property investment sectors remain subdued, reflecting broader global economic uncertainties.

Looking ahead, Cambodia's economic growth is expected to slightly exceed 6 percent in 2025, buoyed by continued recovery in key sectors. However, this positive trajectory faces several risks. The Asian Development Bank (ADB) has highlighted vulnerabilities stemming from weaker growth in major global economies such as the People's Republic of China, Europe, and the United States.

Additional challenges include high levels of private debt, volatile global fuel prices, and the severe impacts of extreme weather events driven by climate change.

At the core of Cambodia's economic challenges lies relatively low productivity, which is hampered by several structural issues. These include weak governance systems, insufficient innovation, a shortage of skilled labor, low levels of technological adoption, and limited integration into both national and international production networks. Furthermore, Cambodia's high ranking on corruption indices, compared to other Southeast Asian nations, has deterred some foreign investors. The absence of robust and transparent institutions, particularly within the justice system and law enforcement agencies, exacerbates this problem.

Additionally, Cambodia faces competitiveness challenges due to high electricity and logistics costs, which remain uncompetitive compared to neighboring countries. The

skills gap in the labor market further compounds these issues, limiting the country's ability to attract and retain high-value investments. Addressing these structural weaknesses is imperative for Cambodia to sustain and enhance its economic growth trajectory.

To strengthen its economic outlook, Cambodia must prioritize reforms in governance, improve institutional transparency, and enhance its investment and business climate. By addressing infrastructure bottlenecks, investing in skill development, and fostering innovation, the country can unlock its economic potential and secure long-term growth amidst a challenging global economic environment partially caused by protectionism, isolationism and unilateralism.

Concerning governance reforms, several critical factors must come into play to ensure meaningful progress: strategic guidance, strategic focus, bold leadership, effective public service delivery, and a sound Monitoring and Evaluation (M&E) mechanism.

Governance reforms cannot be piecemeal or superficial; they require a comprehensive and transformative approach. Strategic guidance ensures that reforms are aligned with long-term national goals, while strategic focus prioritizes key areas that yield the greatest impact for the people.

Without bold leadership, reforms risk being derailed by entrenched interests, bureaucratic inertia, or fear of challenging the status quo. Effective public service delivery must be the centerpiece of these efforts, as the quality of governance is ultimately judged by its tangible impact on citizens' daily lives. A robust Monitoring and Evaluation mechanism is essential for tracking progress, identifying bottlenecks, and ensuring accountability at every level of implementation.

It is time to conduct what can be described as “institutional surgery”—a deliberate, targeted, and courageous restructuring of governance systems to remove inefficiencies, eliminate corruption, and enhance performance. This requires leaders with bold and courageous vision, who are willing to champion reforms even in the face of resistance. Institutional surgery must prioritize the principles of meritocracy, ensuring that appointments and promotions are based on competence, integrity, and performance. It must also focus on building institutions that are strong, smart, and clean, capable of adapting to changing demands, leveraging innovation, and upholding ethical standards.

At the heart of these reforms lies the imperative to improve public service delivery. Improved livelihoods, justice, and better public services are not mere aspirations—they are fundamental rights of the people. Citizens deserve access to services that are efficient, inclusive, and equitable, whether in healthcare, education, infrastructure, or social protection.

Political leaders at both the national and sub-national levels must take decisive action to address these demands. They bear the ultimate responsibility to improve people's lives, promote social justice, and ensure that governance serves its highest purpose: the well-being of the Cambodian people. This requires not only vision and policy innovation but also the ability to inspire and mobilize all stakeholders—public officials, private sector partners, and civil society actors—toward a shared mission of delivering results for the people.

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Part II: the Asia-Pacific

ASEAN-China Partnership in a New Era

Geographical proximity, civilizational connectivity, economic interdependence and common security ensure that this collaboration remains dynamic and enduring

The global landscape is swiftly evolving into a multiplex world defined by multiple modernities, diverse civilizations and multiple power centers. This is an interconnected and interdependent world where both state and non-state actors interact to shape the emerging international order. The relationship between the Association of Southeast Asian Nations and China is evolving within this dynamic.

The geographical proximity between the ASEAN member states and China has served as a foundation in shaping their relations and facilitating frequent interactions, exchanges and cooperation at various levels. This proximity has not only encouraged the development of robust diplomatic ties but has also allowed for the easy movement of people, goods and ideas between the ASEAN members and China. The shared land borders, maritime routes and immediate regional presence have created an environment conducive to sustained engagement and collaboration, fostering a sense of familiarity and mutual understanding.

Two decades have passed since China ratified the Treaty of Amity and Cooperation with ASEAN. This milestone provides an opportune moment to reflect on the development of the ASEAN-China partnership, and the contributions China has made toward fostering regional peace and stability. Over the years, the strategic cooperation between the ASEAN and China has yielded significant achievements and demonstrated the potential for mutually beneficial collaboration.

China's adherence to the principles of the Treaty of Amity and Cooperation has played a significant role in maintaining peace and stability in the region. China's willingness to engage in dialogue and collaborate with the ASEAN members has helped build confidence, reduce tensions and establish a foundation for peaceful coexistence.

While remarkable progress has been made, challenges remain in the ASEAN-China partnership. Addressing territorial disputes in the South China Sea and ensuring the effective implementation of existing agreements will require continued commitment and dialogue. Maintaining transparency, adhering to international law, and promoting

peaceful resolution mechanisms will be essential to building trust and confidence between ASEAN and China.

One of the key achievements of the ASEAN-China partnership has been the establishment of a robust economic relationship. China has emerged as ASEAN's largest trading partner since 2009, with trade volumes increasing over the years. Last year, the bilateral trade volume hit \$975.3 billion. The ASEAN-China Free Trade Area has contributed to the expansion of trade and investment, benefiting both sides. Version 3.0 of ACFTA negotiations was officially launched early this year to further liberalize and facilitate bilateral trade flow.

ACFTA 3.0 is set to synergize harmoniously with the Regional Comprehensive Economic Partnership and other collaborative economic and trade mechanisms within the region. This dynamic partnership aims to propel the region into a thriving epicenter of growth that is marked by openness, inclusivity and shared prosperity.

Currently, over 90 percent of goods (approximately 7,000 types) benefit from tariff-free treatment between China and ASEAN. The upcoming ACFTA 3.0 aims to further reduce tariffs, establish regulations in areas such as customs, inspections, and quarantine, and enhance the liberalization and simplification of trade and investment. This will also result in better safeguarding of consumer rights and interests on both sides, fostering the growth of micro, small and medium-sized enterprises, and generating additional employment opportunities.

Beyond economic ties, the ASEAN-China partnership has fostered vibrant people-to-people exchanges. Cultural events, educational programs and tourism initiatives have facilitated greater understanding, appreciation, and friendship between ASEAN and China. These interactions have not only strengthened societal bonds but also paved the way for enhanced cooperation in various sectors such as education, science and technology and tourism.

Connectivity lies at the heart of ASEAN-China cooperation, promoting trade, tourism and people-to-people exchanges. China's Belt and Road Initiative has provided a platform for infrastructure development and connectivity projects in the region. Collaborative initiatives, such as the Lancang-Mekong Cooperation Mechanism, have strengthened regional connectivity, enhancing transportation and fostering cross-border cooperation. China's commitment to investing in infrastructure has boosted connectivity within ASEAN and beyond, facilitating economic integration and regional development.

ASEAN and China have also deepened their cooperation in non-traditional security areas, such as counter-terrorism, disaster management and transnational crime. Joint exercises, information-sharing mechanisms and capacity-building initiatives have strengthened regional responses to common challenges. China's active participation in these areas has facilitated knowledge sharing, technical assistance and resource mobilization, contributing to the overall resilience and security of the region.

While significant progress has been made in the ASEAN-China partnership, there are areas where further cooperation can bring mutual benefits. Continued efforts should focus on strengthening people-to-people exchanges, fostering cultural understanding, and promoting sustainable development. Environmental cooperation, technology sharing and digital connectivity are promising avenues for deepening collaboration. By building on past achievements, ASEAN and China can unlock the immense potential for shared prosperity, greater regional integration and sustainable development.

As the ASEAN members and China navigate future challenges, it is crucial to sustain the positive momentum, reinforce mutual trust and continue to work together to ensure a peaceful and prosperous future for the region. The ASEAN-China partnership serves as a shining example of cooperation and diplomacy in an increasingly interconnected world.

The binding factors of ASEAN-China relations — geographical proximity, civilizational connectivity, economic interdependence, and common security — complement and reinforce each other, forming a multifaceted foundation for a dynamic and enduring partnership. These factors not only facilitate practical cooperation but also promote a sense of shared destiny, fostering an environment where mutual interests are pursued, challenges are collectively addressed, and a true community with a shared future can be realized.

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Is the ASEAN–Japan relationship fit for the times?

❖ In Brief

The ASEAN–Japan relationship today is almost unrecognizable from that of 50 years ago when riots against the visits of former Japanese prime minister Kakuei Tanaka to Southeast Asian capitals were emblematic of its troubled state. Japan's current benign role in ASEAN belies what has been a powerful alignment of interests and influence assiduously developed over the ensuing decades important to the relationship's success.

The question is how these foundations fit the present relationship. The 50th anniversary of the ASEAN–Japan dialogue underscores the strong ties that have been built in the intervening decades. But a fast-evolving, multiplex world order, with new centres of power and increasingly complex interactions, poses a number of challenges to the relationship going forward.

Intense geopolitical rivalry between the United States and China presents unprecedented challenges for ASEAN, and Japan will need to cooperate with heightened awareness and strategic acumen to address these challenges. The relationship with Japan is also a key element in the environment in which ASEAN will have to navigate the strategic dilemma between the United States and China.

Navigating the balance between China and the United States is crucial for maintaining regional stability and upholding ASEAN's shared principles of openness and inclusivity. As Japan tilts towards its US alliance, balancing competing interests, avoiding ASEAN's overreliance on any single power and preserving centrality and strategic autonomy will require continuing and deft diplomatic initiative.

Managing these complexities through dialogue, trust-building and a focus on shared interests is key. Addressing challenges to the ASEAN–Japan relationship, like regional power dynamics, territorial disputes, economic competition and historical tensions will be essential for fostering a more resilient and cooperative partnership.

Japan's commitment to regional security and engagement in multilateral frameworks provides avenues for closer collaboration with ASEAN, under the framework of the East Asia Summit, the ASEAN Regional Forum, the ASEAN Defence Ministers' Meeting Plus and the ASEAN Expanded Maritime Forum. But Japan's involvement in security minilaterals such as the Quad—which China views as a containment strategy—does not sit comfortably with ASEAN.

Compatibility between Japan's Free and Open Indo-Pacific and the ASEAN Outlook on the Indo-Pacific lies in their shared objectives and overlapping principles. Both emphasise a rules-based international order, respect for sovereignty and the promotion of connectivity and economic integration. Through mutual collaboration, these initiatives have the potential to contribute significantly to peace, stability and economic development in the Asia-Pacific region, but how these agendas evolve, are defined and made operational is still a work in progress.

The sharing of intelligence, expertise and best practice has enabled a more comprehensive approach to countering radicalization, preventing terrorist financing and enhancing border security. By pooling resources and knowledge, Japan and ASEAN have bolstered their respective counterterrorism capabilities and contributed to regional stability. In 2014, ASEAN and Japan adopted a Joint Declaration for Cooperation to Combat Terrorism and Transnational Crime to strengthen cooperation in this area.

Given the importance of maritime domains in the region, ensuring security and freedom of navigation has been an area of collaboration between Japan and ASEAN. Japan actively supports ASEAN member states in enhancing their maritime capabilities, providing assistance in areas such as maritime domain awareness, capacity building, joint exercises and equipment.

Since the 1970s Japan has supplied surveillance ships to nations within ASEAN, including Vietnam and Indonesia. It has also financially supported various initiatives aimed at enhancing the capabilities of ASEAN nations to prevent and counteract unlawful fishing activities. In 2017, Japan entered into a collaborative agreement with Thailand, focusing on combating illegal, unreported and unregulated fishing. This agreement emphasized improving the traceability of fishery products and bolstering efforts in monitoring, controlling and overseeing fishing operations.

With Japan and several ASEAN countries prone to natural disasters, sharing expertise and resources in disaster response and recovery is another significant area of collaboration. Japan's experience with disaster preparedness, early warning systems and post-disaster reconstruction is instrumental in assisting ASEAN member states with capacity building to mitigate the impact of natural disasters. This cooperation has not only saved lives but also promoted regional solidarity and cooperation in times of crisis.

Economic ties between ASEAN and Japan have flourished over the years, with Japan remaining one of ASEAN's largest trading partners and a major source of foreign direct investment (FDI). FDI outflows from Japan to ASEAN amounted to around US\$20

billion and bilateral trade reached US\$240.2 billion in 2022. ASEAN is home to 30 per cent of all Japanese overseas subsidiaries. The ASEAN–Japan Comprehensive Economic Partnership has facilitated trade liberalization, market access and economic integration. Infrastructure development, such as the Partnership for Quality Infrastructure, also received active support from Japan, contributing to ASEAN’s connectivity goals.

ASEAN and Japan can focus on enhancing physical and digital connectivity, promoting trade facilitation, strengthening regional supply chains and addressing climate change and sustainable development. Continued support from Japan is crucial to ensure inclusive growth and bridge development disparities among ASEAN member states. The Japan–ASEAN Integration Fund, established in 2006, and Japan–Mekong Cooperation, founded in 2008, are the two such mechanisms established to assist the least developed economies in ASEAN.

Deepening people-to-people ties through cultural exchanges, educational programs and tourism will further foster mutual understanding and friendship. Strengthening educational cooperation and providing reciprocal scholarships for students from Japan and ASEAN nations will also contribute to long-term relationship building.

ASEAN and Japan need to continue working closely together to strengthen open and inclusive multilateralism, promoting a rules-based international order and leveraging opportunities for economic integration, security cooperation and people-to-people exchanges. In this way, ASEAN and Japan can navigate the challenges and build a stronger and more sustainable relationship in the years to come.

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Republic of Korea's Regional Activism

The Asia-Pacific region is undergoing a profound and multifaceted transformation that fundamentally reshapes its geopolitical and geo-economic landscape. This transformation is characterized by a web of interconnected factors collectively redefining the region's dynamics. These factors include intensifying geopolitical rivalries, regional and global supply chain disruptions, a sluggish economic recovery, and the emergence of various non-traditional security threats, such as the climate crisis and natural disasters.

Amidst Southeast Asia's myriad of challenges and pressures, the region remains steadfast in its pursuit of regional integration and connectivity. This unwavering commitment is a testament to Southeast Asia's aspiration to retain its status as an epicentrum of growth and economic dynamism within the broader Asia-Pacific region.

In this context, the Republic of Korea (ROK) unveiled a strategic vision known as the Korea-ASEAN Solidarity Initiative (KASI) at the ASEAN-ROK Summit held in Phnom Penh last year. This initiative marks a shift in the ROK's foreign policy approach, focusing on fostering a free, peaceful, and prosperous Indo-Pacific region through collaboration with major stakeholders, including ASEAN and Southeast Asian countries.

The ROK's Indo-Pacific Strategy presents a comprehensive economic and security framework. Given the ROK's status as an Indo-Pacific nation, its core national interests are intricately linked to the stability and prosperity of the region. Within this framework, Korea aims to strengthen the rules-based international order and promote an inclusive multilateral system.

One notable aspect of the ROK's evolving foreign policy is the broadening geographical scope through its Indo-Pacific Strategy, which now encompasses Southeast Asia, South Asia, Oceania, and the African Coast of the Indian Ocean. This expansion seeks to establish a strategic partnership network tailored to the Indo-Pacific region's unique needs and opportunities.

The Indo-Pacific Strategy is anchored in three core principles: inclusiveness, trust, and reciprocity. These principles underscore the ROK's commitment to fostering a collaborative and balanced regional approach, where all nations are valued participants, mutual trust prevails, and benefits are shared equitably.

Addressing the complex security challenges of the 21st century demands a multi-dimensional and holistic approach. In this regard, Korea has engaged in comprehensive regional security cooperation, addressing traditional and non-traditional security threats. Recent efforts have seen the ROK focus on defense and security through enhanced military cooperation, including joint exercises and consultations with partners such as the United States, Japan, and NATO.

President Yoon Suk Yeol's openness to developing an independent nuclear deterrent or redeploying US nuclear forces underscores the growing nuclear threat posed by North Korea. While Yoon's foreign policy appears pragmatic, its true intention and capabilities remain to be seen.

On the economic front, the ROK is determined to strengthen regional economic security networks, ensuring stable and resilient supply chain management. The nation also advocates for free trade and a rules-based economic order within the Indo-Pacific. Active participation in multilateral cooperation and establishing early warning systems are among the nation's priorities.

ROK's relationship with ASEAN has evolved significantly since establishing the Sectoral Dialogue Partnership in 1989 and the Full Dialogue Partnership in 1991. Economic ties have grown substantially, with ROK's exports to ASEAN reaching approximately USD 125 billion last year. To deepen these ties, Korean entities should align their strategies with the development priorities of ASEAN member countries, recognizing both their diversity and potential for economies of scale.

While economic integration and cultural exchanges have been traditional strengths of the relationship, security, and defense cooperation are gaining prominence. The Plan of Action 2021-2025 reaffirms the commitment of both sides to enhance conflict prevention, preventive diplomacy, and conflict management, thereby bolstering peace, security, and stability in the region.

Efforts to deepen the ASEAN-ROK strategic partnership align with the Joint Declaration adopted in 2010. The forthcoming period of 2021-2025 is crucial for fostering practical cooperation and mutually beneficial relations between ASEAN and the ROK. In defense, both parties aim to enhance dialogue and cooperation through regional forums such as the ASEAN Regional Forum (ARF) and the ASEAN Defense Ministers' Meeting Plus (ADMM-Plus).

While the ROK aspires to be a global pivotal state focusing on 'hard security' components in its international diplomacy, its true global reputation extends beyond military capacity. The future of the ROK-ASEAN partnership lies in its ability to balance security with economic, cultural, and diplomatic interests.

During the bilateral meeting between Cambodian Prime Minister Hun Manet and ROK's President Joon Suk Yeol in Jakarta early this month, both leaders agreed to effectively implement the bilateral Free Trade Agreement, which came into force last December, as well as a customs agreement inked in April. These agreements hold the potential to significantly bolster bilateral trade, which reached an all-time high of US\$1.05 billion last year. Cambodia supports ROK's international initiatives, including its commitment to the Korea-ASEAN Solidarity Initiative (KASI) and the Busan Expo 2030.

Furthermore, parliamentary collaboration between Cambodia and ROK has received renewed momentum following the official visit of the President of the National Assembly, Kim Jin-pyo, to Cambodia earlier this month. During this visit, both nations concurred on the need to further enhance their parliamentary cooperation, spanning both bilateral and multilateral dimensions, with the primary aim of advancing the welfare and interests of their respective populations.

ROK's partnership with ASEAN and each ASEAN member country is entering a new phase marked by expanded cooperation, stronger economic ties, and increased attention to regional security. The success of this partnership hinges on Korea's ability to adapt to the diverse needs of ASEAN members and its commitment to building a comprehensive and inclusive Indo-Pacific region.

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The Belt and Road Initiative, A Pathway to Global Harmony and Prosperity

The Belt and Road Initiative (BRI) has revitalized a rich history of cultural interactions spanning over two thousand years and ignited the aspirations of over 150 nations to realize a shared vision: peace, harmony, and prosperity.

Collaboration within the BRI framework has ushered in significant and deep-seated transformations globally, marking an important milestone in the annals of human history.

Despite some missteps, loopholes, and shortcomings, it is safe to argue that the BRI remains one of the world's largest platforms for international cooperation. It is a driving force of re-globalization and forming a new world economic order.

The third Belt and Road Forum for International Cooperation, which is taking place in Beijing this week, presents an opportunity for deep reflections, honest assessment, and contemplation while setting directions for a new era. Cambodian Prime Minister Hun Manet will deliver an address at the Forum to share the Cambodian perspective on the BRI and the way forward.

In a world beset by turbulence, complexity, uncertainty, and fragmentation, the BRI emerges as a beacon of hope, offering a vision for a brighter, more inclusive, cooperative future.

The current global landscape is fraught with escalating rivalries among major powers, wars and conflicts, a sluggish global economic recovery, and a climate emergency. Zero-sum power politics, protectionism, and unilateralism are rising, threatening to undermine international cooperation.

Humanity's challenges today are unparalleled after the end of the Cold War. The deficit in peace, development, security, and governance is widening, posing a grave threat to humanity and the planet.

From regional conflicts and arms races to food security, cyber-attacks, and climate change, these multifaceted challenges demand cooperation and a united response.

We must seek innovative ideas and concepts for a just, equitable, and effective global governance system. The BRI offers an open and safe space for nations to innovate and unite in the pursuit of exchanges between civilizations.

The BRI is not solely about China's development but a solution for global development issues. It recognizes that economic globalization is an irreversible trend that must be made more open, inclusive, balanced, and beneficial. It seeks to advance modernization in participating countries, fostering dynamic, inclusive, and sustainable economic growth.

The BRI envisions a global community of shared futures, as highlighted in the BRI White Paper. It transcends ideological differences and national borders, creating a platform for mutual trust, economic integration, and cultural inclusiveness. It offers a practical means to build a fairer and more equitable global governance system, guiding humanity towards a better future.

The BRI is firmly grounded in the principles of extensive consultation, joint contribution, and shared benefits. It champions win-win cooperation and encourages economic integration, interconnected development, and the equitable sharing of achievements. It is an open, green, and clean initiative, ensuring that progress is both steady and high-quality.

In line with the UN 2030 Agenda for Sustainable Development, the BRI promotes coordinated economic, social, and eco-environmental development. It addresses root causes and obstacles, striving for lasting, inclusive, and sustainable economic growth.

Over the past decade, the BRI has yielded remarkable results, opening new avenues for global economic growth and improving people's lives worldwide. The BRI remains committed to global connectivity and multilateralism in an era marked by de-globalization.

The BRI is a path to global well-being, peace, prosperity, openness, innovation, and social progress. It promotes all-round connectivity in various fields, facilitating policy coordination, infrastructure development, unimpeded trade, financial integration, and people-to-people ties.

Cooperation in scientific and technological innovation accelerates, promoting technology transfer, knowledge sharing, and talent training. Digital Silk Road cooperation, for instance, fosters an open and equitable environment for digital development.

The BRI supports trade and investment liberalization, eliminating barriers and enhancing global trade efficiency. Building synergies between the BRI and other regional initiatives, such as the ASEAN-led Regional Comprehensive Economic Partnership (RCEP) would be essential.

The BRI advocates for exchanges and mutual learning among civilizations, rejecting divisive concepts like the “clash of civilizations.” Instead, it promotes dialogue, inclusiveness, and shared values, uniting cultures and hearts across borders.

The BRI represents a vast and enduring global project for the 21st century, marked by its long-term, cross-border, and systematic nature. Building upon the achievement over the past decade, the BRI will showcase increased innovation and dynamism, fostering greater openness and inclusivity, thereby creating new opportunities for all.

Indeed, for the continued expansion of the BRI, it is imperative to emphasize principles of good governance, which encompass transparency, accountability, and quality. The Chinese government and private sectors must redouble their efforts to bolster good governance and combating corruption.

It is challenging for China to convince other participating countries and partners that the BRI is not a geopolitical project but purely an economic and cultural project.

Looking ahead, the BRI may encounter new challenges. Nevertheless, if all participating parties join forces, collaborate closely, and persevere, they can surmount these obstacles and elevate their collective efforts, shared contributions, and mutual benefits to new heights. Cooperation will flourish and shine in the dark, and the BRI can anticipate an even more promising future.

This article was first published in Khmer Time on 17 October 2023.

Unpacking the Conflict in the Middle East

The complexity of conflict in the Middle East often gets oversimplified in public discourse. The region is frequently depicted as a battleground for a clash of civilizations or religious warfare.

However, the underlying reality is more about geopolitical competition than ideological or theological differences.

The Middle East's unique geographical and strategic position has historically attracted the attention of major global powers seeking to further their interests in the area. This region is home to the largest oil reserves in the world, which has consistently drawn foreign involvement since the end of World War II.

Additionally, the Middle East is vitally important as the origin and spiritual heartland of the three major monotheistic religions: Christianity, Judaism, and Islam.

Its geopolitical significance means that any local or regional conflicts have the potential not just to disrupt the area's own stability or alter its balance of power, but also to impact global stability.

Consequently, the Middle East remains a crucial focal point in international affairs, playing a pivotal role economically, politically, and culturally.

Great-power rivalry significantly shapes the Middle East's geopolitical landscape. The interests of global powers like the United States, Russia, and China converge around regional centers of economic and political influence and countries that maintain historical relationships with these powers.

This web of influences dictates much of the regional dynamics, including military alliances and enmities.

In the intricate geopolitical chessboard that is the Middle East, the United States has long held the dominant position, particularly in military terms. However, this supremacy is no longer unchallenged as Russia and China increasingly assert their presence.

Yet, the motivation behind these great powers' involvement in potential future conflicts in the region extends beyond mere competition over expanding spheres of influence.

The interconnection between counterterrorism efforts and great-power competition in the Middle East is becoming increasingly evident. As the U.S. recalibrates its engagement level in the region, it inadvertently sets the stage for other powers to step in, potentially through proxy conflicts.

This dynamic illustrates a delicate balance where the extent of U.S. involvement can either deter or encourage other great powers' deeper participation based on perceived opportunities or threats.

Notably, the United States, China, and Russia show limited appetite for direct military confrontation in the Middle East unless their core interests face direct threats. This cautious approach suggests a strategic calculation that weighs the high risks of direct involvement against the geopolitical benefits of influence achieved through less overt means.

Moreover, any conflicts involving these great powers in the Middle East today are unlikely to mirror the proxy wars of the Cold War era. The geopolitical landscape has dramatically evolved since then, with new technologies, changing political alliances, and a complex web of economic interdependencies reshaping traditional military engagements.

Thus, while the specter of great-power competition looms large, the nature of conflict and engagement in the Middle East continues to evolve, driven by a confluence of strategic interests that transcend simple rivalry.

This nuanced reality calls for a sophisticated understanding of the motives and constraints influencing U.S., Chinese, and Russian strategies in the region. As these powers navigate the turbulent waters of Middle Eastern politics, their actions are likely to be calculated, cautious, and, above all, aimed at balancing risk against the strategic advantage in an increasingly multipolar world order or a multiplex world.

A poignant example of this is the evolving relationship between Israel and Iran. Once allies during the reign of Iran's last Shah, Mohammad Reza Pahlavi, their friendship ended abruptly with Iran's 1979 Islamic Revolution.

Iran's new theocratic regime positioned itself staunchly against Israel, labeling it an imperialist entity in the region. This shift set the stage for decades of indirect conflicts. Iran has supported organizations like Hamas and the Hezbollah militia, which Israel and many Western nations consider terrorist groups.

In response, Israel perceives Iran's potential nuclear capabilities as a direct threat to its existence and has not hesitated to undertake covert operations to impede Iran's nuclear ambitions.

The Israeli military operations in the Gaza Strip, which results in a serious humanitarian disaster and a clear violation of the principles of humanitarian law, coupled with the escalating violence in the West Bank, significantly heighten regional tensions and amplify the risk of a broader conflict in the Middle East.

The ongoing covert conflict between Israel and Iran, often referred to as a "shadow war," highlights how longstanding rivalries and alliances in the Middle East are catalyzed by the strategic interests of global powers rather than solely by religious or cultural disputes. This shadow war has seen both nations engaging in acts of sabotage and proxy battles, reflecting a broader pattern of geopolitical maneuvering rather than isolated incidents of aggression.

Hence, the strife in the Middle East is a tapestry of power struggles intricately linked to the interests of global superpowers. Understanding these dynamics is crucial for any meaningful analysis of the region's enduring conflicts. Such an understanding shifts the narrative from one of inherent sectarian violence to a more accurate portrayal of strategic geopolitical competition.

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China and the US Stabilizing their Complex Ties

Accounting for over 40 percent of global GDP, the US-China relationship is undeniably the most significant and complex bilateral relationship in the world.

The interactions between these two major powers not only shape their own futures but also have profound impacts on global stability, economic growth, and international security.

It is therefore essential to ensure that Beijing-Washington relations move in a positive and constructive direction. Cooperation and competition are intertwined. Southeast Asian countries including Cambodia wish to see a healthy and stable US-China competition.

The visit of the US National Security Advisor Jake Sullivan to China last week underscored a mutual political commitment to stabilizing their complex relationship. The discussions were marked by a refreshing level of candor.

China has repeatedly emphasized the importance of strategic perception, likening it to the “first button of a shirt” that must be correctly fastened.

“Establishing the right perception is key for China and the United States to achieve peaceful coexistence,” noted Wang Yi, China’s top diplomat.

The widening “trust deficit” between the world’s leading superpower and the largest developing country significantly heightens the risks associated with the Taiwan issue and other global challenges, including the tensions in the South China Sea, conflicts in Ukraine, the Middle East, and the Korean Peninsula. Addressing these challenges requires coordinated and concerted efforts from both sides.

In a rare move, Jake Sullivan met with General Zhang Youxia, Vice-Chairman of China’s Central Military Commission, before his meeting with President Xi Jinping. This meeting, along with extensive discussions with Wang Yi, underscores the seriousness with which both sides are approaching the current state of affairs.

During their talks, Wang and Sullivan explored the possibility of upcoming discussions between US President Joe Biden and President Xi.

They exchanged contrasting views on key global issues, including the conflicts in the Middle East and Ukraine, China’s territorial claims in the South China Sea, Taiwan, and trade disputes. “The key to the smooth development of China-U.S. interaction lies in

treating each other as equals,” Wang emphasized, reflecting a core principle that China seeks to uphold in its dealings with the US.

President Xi highlighted the need for global solidarity and coordination in a world marked by change and turbulence, rather than exclusion or regression.

Sullivan conveyed President Biden’s commitment to managing the US-China relationship in a way that avoids conflict, expressing that Biden “looks forward to engaging with you in the coming weeks.” The White House characterized the discussions as “candid, substantive, and constructive.”

Sullivan also advocated for improved military-to-military communication during his meeting with General Zhang, marking the first encounter between Zhang and an official from the Biden administration.

He stressed the shared responsibility of both nations to prevent their competition from escalating into conflict. The progress in military communications and upcoming talks between theatre-level commanders were seen as critical steps toward stabilizing regional tensions.

In addition, Sullivan reiterated the importance of maintaining stability across the Taiwan Strait and ensuring freedom of navigation in the South China Sea, a crucial trade route. He also raised concerns about China’s support for Russia’s defense industrial base amid the ongoing conflict in Ukraine.

From the Bali consensus to the San Francisco vision, the strategic communication between Presidents Xi and Biden has been pivotal in steering the course of US-China relations. However, for these interactions to translate into a stable, healthy, and sustainable relationship, both nations must back their words with concrete actions.

While communication is a positive development, it alone is insufficient. Beijing is ready to turn goodwill into tangible results, and the international community now awaits Washington’s demonstration of sincerity in managing differences and cooperating with China.

Domestic politics in the US and anti-China sentiment have a substantial impact on the bilateral relationship between the US and China. The US has increasingly framed its policy towards China through a lens of competition and containment, driven by concerns about China’s rising global influence and its economic and military advancements.

Whoever wins the upcoming US Presidential election is likely to maintain or even intensify this approach, as there is broad bipartisan consensus in Washington about the need to counterbalance China's growing power. This could manifest in various ways, including trade restrictions, military alliances aimed at countering Chinese influence, and support for regional partners and allies who are wary of China's ambitions.

This strategic competition isn't just about direct confrontations; it also plays out in areas like technology, where the US and its allies are working to limit China's access to advanced technologies and critical supply chains. Additionally, there is significant emphasis on promoting democratic values and human rights as part of the broader strategy.

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ASEAN at a Crossroad

This week, ASEAN leaders will gather in Vientiane for their annual Summits among themselves and with dialogue partners, under the theme “ASEAN: Enhancing Connectivity and Resilience.”

The theme reflects the Lao PDR’s focus as ASEAN Chair on strengthening ASEAN’s integration across its three community pillars: the political-security community, the economic community, and the socio-cultural community.

With a focus on infrastructure development, narrowing the development gap, fostering greater economic integration, and enhancing people-to-people exchanges, the Lao Chair aims to strengthen ASEAN’s agency to navigate uncertainties and complexities caused by heightening geostrategic competition, economic fragmentation, and the re-emergence of bloc politics.

The organization’s success or failure in addressing these challenges will determine not only its future relevance but also its ability to act as a stabilizing force in the broader Asia Pacific region.

❖ ASEAN Connectivity

Connectivity has long been viewed as a cornerstone of ASEAN’s integration process. The Master Plan on ASEAN Connectivity 2025 seeks to bridge infrastructure gaps, promote economic interdependence, and foster deeper socio-cultural ties among member states. This vision of connectivity is critical to transforming ASEAN from a collection of individual economies into a more cohesive, competitive regional bloc.

However, while connectivity has brought benefits, it also presents challenges. As regional powers, particularly China and the United States, vie for influence in Southeast Asia, infrastructure projects—many of them tied to foreign investments—risk becoming battlegrounds for geostrategic rivalry.

Thus, ASEAN’s connectivity strategy must be viewed through a dual lens: on the one hand, it serves as a mechanism for greater regional integration; on the other, it exposes member states to external influences, heightening the importance of collective decision-making and strategic foresight in managing these relationships.

ASEAN must ensure that its connectivity projects are not driven solely by external powers' interests but align with the region's long-term vision for sustainable, inclusive development.

❖ **ASEAN Resilience**

Resilience is equally critical in a world characterized by fast-changing and unpredictable geopolitical and geo-economic landscapes. ASEAN must enhance its collective resilience to navigate the strategic uncertainties arising from intensifying competition between global powers. The ongoing US-China rivalry has far-reaching implications for Southeast Asia, threatening to polarize the region and challenge ASEAN's long-held principle of neutrality and non-alignment.

ASEAN's ability to remain resilient amidst these challenges depends on strengthening its internal cohesion. The development of strategic plans for implementing the ASEAN Community Vision 2045 will be crucial in guiding the organization's response to external pressures while promoting internal solidarity.

However, ASEAN's internal diversity—ranging from economic disparities to divergent political systems—makes this an uphill task. The risk is that divisions within ASEAN could undermine its ability to present a united front on critical issues.

The world is transitioning toward a multipolar or multiplex global order, where power is no longer concentrated in a few dominant states but distributed across a broader spectrum of actors.

ASEAN's capacity to withstand the pressures of this shifting global order will depend largely on its ability to enhance resilience through greater cooperation, trust-building, and proactive policymaking.

❖ **ASEAN Centrality**

At the heart of ASEAN's identity is its commitment to maintaining centrality in the regional architecture. ASEAN centrality hinges on two key pillars: its convening power and its normative power.

Convening power refers to ASEAN's ability to bring together major global and regional actors in an inclusive setting—whether through the East Asia Summit (EAS), the ASEAN Regional Forum (ARF), or the ASEAN Defence Ministers' Meeting Plus (ADMM-Plus). ASEAN's neutral platforms have, in the past, allowed it to mediate tensions and promote dialogue, especially in times of heightened geopolitical rivalry.

As major powers become more assertive in asserting their influence, ASEAN risks being sidelined in critical regional security discussions. To preserve its centrality, ASEAN must recalibrate its strategies and engage in more proactive, sometimes assertive, diplomacy, ensuring that its voice remains central in shaping the evolving regional architecture.

ASEAN's normative power, meanwhile, is grounded in its commitment to principles such as non-interference, peaceful dispute resolution, and consensus-building. The Treaty of Amity and Cooperation (TAC) and the ASEAN Charter are foundational to ASEAN's normative framework.

However, for these principles to remain relevant, ASEAN must ensure that they are actively upheld, both within its own membership and by external partners. Challenges to ASEAN's normative influence have emerged, with some external actors disregarding the region's norms in favor of unilateral actions.

❖ **The Path Forward: Ensuring ASEAN's Relevance**

To ensure its relevance in this evolving geopolitical landscape, ASEAN must prioritize both internal unity and proactive engagement with external powers. The ASEAN Outlook on the Indo-Pacific (AOIP) is a promising initiative that promotes ASEAN's centrality while addressing the geostrategic complexities of the Asia Pacific region.

By focusing on practical cooperation in areas such as maritime security, sustainable development, and disaster resilience, the AOIP offers a framework for maintaining ASEAN's central role without taking sides in great power competition.

However, initiatives like the AOIP must be accompanied by concrete actions. ASEAN cannot afford to rest on its laurels. It must continuously refine and innovate its institutional mechanisms, strengthen its internal solidarity, and assert its normative influence in the face of rising external pressures.

The resilience and relevance of ASEAN in this multipolar or multiplex world will depend on its ability to adapt to new realities, while staying true to its foundational principles of cooperation, openness, inclusivity, peaceful co-existence, non-interference, and respect for international law.

As ASEAN convenes in Vientiane, it must seize this critical moment to demonstrate that it remains a key actor, not just in Southeast Asia but in the wider Asia

Pacific region. The path forward requires strategic foresight, unity, and the political will to assert ASEAN's centrality in an increasingly fractured world.

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